

Job: A Translation, Paraphrase, and Summary

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Dedicated to Tim Shorey, a voice of and for the faith of the sufferer

Preface

The book of Job is in equal measure bombastic and dignified, heart-rending and awe-inspiring, universal in scope and intensely personal; throughout, the book rings with passion, yet leaves one in quiet reflection. The questions raised and the responses given to those questions are provocative and profound.

Nevertheless, the passage of time has made the book something of a challenge to read. This document aims to provide some help in the following ways:

(1) To the left of a literal translation of the book (which is broken into sections) is a paraphrase, which aims to clarify the meaning and/or emotional impact of the text using different words and expressions, as well as occasional brief additions aimed at fleshing out the train of thought;

(2) beneath each section, a summary tries to capture in a few words the main thread of the argument; and

(3) a conclusion (entitled, “Considering the Message of Job”) sums up the book as a whole and reflects on what the believer is meant to take away from this book of the Bible. (Some additional notes follow.)

Some notes on the translation and paraphrase: First, I have generally not used quotation marks, since this would be cumbersome in a poetic dialogue like Job. Second, the book of Job is infamous for its linguistic difficulty, so it should constantly be borne in mind that many details in the book of Job are unclear at the present time. Third, brackets in the translation indicate words not found in the original but supplied for clarity. Fourth, the emphasis in the translation is on semantic accuracy, while the emphasis in the paraphrase is on clarity, but in neither case is the elegance of the original transferred in any reliable way (that is to say, poetry does not translate well!). Fifth, I urge the reader to consider the tone of the passage that she or he happens to be reading—whether Job or his friends speaks in anger, sarcasm, irony, confusion, awe, etc.

May God bless his children, especially those undergoing terrible suffering.

Paraphrase of 1:1-22

A man named Job lived in the land of Uz. He was characterized by integrity and uprightness; he feared God, and shunned evil. **1:2** He had seven sons and three daughters. **1:3** He came to have a flock of 7,000 sheep and goats, 3,000 camels, 500 teams of oxen, 500 donkeys, and many servants. Job was more notable than all the famous men of the east. **1:4** Each year his sons would throw a lavish birthday party in the home of the one having a birthday, and they would invite all

Translation of 1:1-22

There was a man in the land of Uz; Job was his name. And that man was a man of integrity and uprightness, and he feared God and turned away from evil. **1:2** And there were born to him seven sons and three daughters. **1:3** And it came about that his flock was seven thousand, and three thousand camels, and five hundred yoke of oxen, and five hundred donkeys, and very many servants. And that man was greater than all the sons of the east. **1:4** And his sons would go and have a

their sisters to come and join in. **1:5** When this would happen, Job would arrange to have them set apart by him to God, and early in the morning he would offer one burnt offering for each of them. He did this because he reasoned to himself, "It's possible that my sons have sinned, and have cursed God in their hearts." This was Job's continual practice.

1:6 On one of these birthdays, the angelic host, Satan among them, came to give an account of their actions to the Lord. **1:7** The Lord asked Satan, "What have you been doing?" "Roaming all over the earth," Satan answered. **1:8** Then the Lord asked Satan, "Have you noticed my servant named Job? He stands out—a man of high character!" **1:9** "It's hardly a coincidence that Job serves you!" Satan sneered in reply. **1:10** "You've protected him and all that he has from harm, and given him great prosperity. At your command, his cattle have practically overrun the land!" **1:11** But take that prosperity away from him, and he will curse you to your face!" **1:12** "I'm giving permission to attack anything in Job's orbit," said the Lord. "As long as you do not harm the man himself." Then Satan left the Lord's presence.

1:13 That same day, **1:14** a messenger came to Job and shouted, "The oxen were plowing, and the donkeys were grazing nearby, **1:15** when suddenly Sheban raiders attacked, seizing the animals and killing the servants. I'm the only one who survived to tell you!" **1:16** While he was still speaking, another messenger came and shouted, "A fireball from God came down from the skies and burned up the flock and the servants. I'm the only one who escaped to tell you!" **1:17** While he was still speaking, another messenger came and shouted, "Chaldean warriors, in three groups, stole the camels and killed the servants. I'm the only one who survived to tell you!" **1:18** While he was still speaking, another messenger came and said, "Your children were enjoying their feast in the house of the oldest, **1:19** and suddenly a terrible wind came from the far side of the desert and utterly flattened the house, crushing the young men and women in it. I'm the only one who survived to tell you!" **1:20** Then Job deliberately tore his clothes in grief, shaved his head, sank to the ground, and worshiped God, **1:21** saying, "I was born with nothing, "And I will die with nothing. "The Lord has given me many good things, and now the Lord has taken away all these things;

feast in the house of each man on his day, and they would send and call for their three sisters to eat and drink with them. **1:5** And it came about when the days of the feast came around, Job sent and sanctified them, and would rise early and offer burnt offerings according to the number of all of them, for Job thought, "Perhaps my sons have sinned, and 'blessed' God in their hearts." Thus Job did regularly.

1:6 And the day came about, and the sons of God took their places before Yahweh, and the adversary also entered in their midst. **1:7** And Yahweh said to the adversary, "From where do you come?" And the adversary answered Yahweh and said, "From going here and there on the earth, and walking around on it." **1:8** And Yahweh said to the adversary, "Have you considered my servant Job? For there is no one like him on the earth, a man of integrity and uprightness, fearing God and turning away from evil." **1:9** And the adversary answered Yahweh and said, "Is it for nothing that Job fears God? **1:10** Have you not put a hedge around him, and around his house, and around all that he has all around him? The work of his hands you have blessed, and his cattle break forth in the land. **1:11** But if you would only send your hand and touch all that he has—surely he will 'bless' you to your face!" **1:12** And Yahweh said to the adversary, "Behold, all that is his is in your hand; only against him you may not send your hand." And the adversary went out from the presence of Yahweh.

1:13 And the day came about, and his sons and his daughters were eating and were drinking wine in the house of their oldest brother, **1:14** and a messenger came to Job and said, "The oxen were plowing, and the donkeys were grazing beside them, **1:15** and Sheba fell [upon them] and took them, and struck the young men with the mouth of the sword, and I alone escaped to tell you." **1:16** This [man] was still speaking, and this [other man] came and said, "A fire of God fell from heaven and burned the flock and consumed the young men, and I alone escaped to tell you." **1:17** The [man] was still speaking, and this [other man] came and said, "The Chaldeans formed three bands and raided the camels and took them, and the young men they struck with the mouth of the sword, and I alone escaped to tell you." **1:18** This [man] was still speaking, and this [other man] came and said, "Your sons and your daughters were eating and were drinking wine in the house of their oldest brother, **1:19** and behold, a great wind came from the far side of the desert and collided

“Yet may the Lord's character be considered blessed!” 1:22 And so, in the midst of all this calamity, Job remained free from sin, and refrained from criticizing God.	with the four corners of the house, and it fell on the young men, and they died, and I alone escaped to tell you.” 1:20 And Job arose, and tore his mantle, and shaved his head, and fell to the ground, and worshiped. 1:21 And he said, “Naked I came out from my mother's womb, “And naked I will return there. “Yahweh has given, and Yahweh has taken away; “The name of Yahweh be blessed!” 1:22 In all these things Job did not sin, and did not ascribe wrongdoing to God.
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Summary of 1:1-22

The curtains of this drama open on Job, a man with a large family and great wealth (1:1a, 2-4). Success has not bred arrogance, however: At each birthday party in the family Job—despite his own clear conscience (v1b)—considers the possibility that one or more of them has sinned and stands in need of a sacrifice, and takes appropriate measures on their behalf (v5).

The scene then shifts to the heavens, where one of the regular check-ins that God apparently requires of all angels and demons is taking place (v6). When God asks what Satan has been doing, the evil one replies—whether in an attempt to evade the question, or in an attempt to boast about the scope of his knowledge—that he has been all over the earth (v7). Yahweh does not dispute this claim or press for a more specific answer, but instead focuses on one person Satan in his manifold journeys must have observed, namely Job. That man, God says, is someone truly remarkable (v8). Satan, however, is not impressed, claiming that Job’s piety is purely utilitarian: If, Satan claims, God were to take away Job’s family and wealth, the man would no longer worship God, but hate him (vv9-11). God calls Satan’s bluff, permitting Satan to attack Job’s family and possessions (v12).

Now, Job—unlike the readers of the *book* of Job—is wholly unaware of what has gone on in the heavens. Nevertheless, he finds himself beset by trouble. One report of disaster after another comes in, the net result being the loss of all of Job’s children, many of his workers, and the wealth of his estate (vv13-19). Needless to say, Job is stricken with grief (v20a-b). And yet, Job does *not* curse God as Satan had claimed; instead, he worships (v20c), refusing to revile Yahweh (v22), and ascribing complete and blessed sovereignty to him (v21).

Little does Job know, things are about to get even worse.

Paraphrase of 2:1-10 The time again came when the angelic host, Satan among them, came to give an account of their actions to the Lord. 2:2 The Lord asked Satan, “What have you been doing?” “Roaming all over the earth,” Satan answered. 2:3 Then the Lord asked Satan, “Have you noticed my servant Job? He still stands out as a man of high character, and he still maintains this character, even though you, for no good reason, asked me to ruin his life!” 2:4 “One man's gain for his friends' pain!” Satan shot back. “Wouldn't anybody accept the loss of his possessions if it meant that he himself would be fine?” 2:5 But if you would harm his body, without a doubt he would curse you to your face!” 2:6 Then the Lord said to Satan, “Alright, I give you permission to harm him as you see fit, except that you must spare his	Translation of 2:1-10 And the day came about, and the sons of God entered to take their places before Yahweh, and the adversary also entered in their midst to take his place before Yahweh. 2:2 And Yahweh said to the adversary, “Where is this you have come from?” And the adversary answered Yahweh and said, “From going here and there on the earth, and walking around on it.” 2:3 And Yahweh said to the adversary, “Have you considered my servant Job? For there is no one like him on the earth, a man of integrity and uprightness, fearing God and turning away from evil. And he still holds fast to his integrity, though you requested me to ruin him for nothing.” 2:4 And the adversary answered Yahweh and said, “Skin in place of skin! Indeed, all that a man has he will give in place of his own life. 2:5
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life.” 2:7 Then Satan left the Lord's presence, and he caused Job to suffer from malignant boils all over his body. 2:8 So Job, sitting in the dumping area for garbage outside the city, used a piece of broken pottery to scrape the pus from his body. 2:9 His wife said to him, “I can't believe you maintain your faithfulness to God in the midst of all this suffering! Curse God so that you'll die, and be free from your pain!” 2:10 “That sounds like what a godless person would say, not you,” Job replied. “If we allow God to give us pleasant things, it is surely reasonable to allow him to give us painful things.” In spite of all these calamities, Job still refused to criticize God.	But if you would only send your hand and touch his bones and his flesh—surely he will ‘bless’ you to your face!” 2:6 And Yahweh said to the adversary, “Here he is, in your hand. Only, keep his life [intact].” 2:7 And the adversary went out from the presence of Yahweh and struck Job with malignant boils from the bottom of his foot to the top of his head. 2:8 And he took a potsherd to scrape himself while he sat in the midst of the [city] trash heap. 2:9 And his wife said to him, “You still hold fast to your integrity? ‘Bless’ God and die!” 2:10 And he said to her, “Like the speaking of one of the foolish women you speak: Shall we indeed accept the good from God, even as the bad we do not accept?” In all these things Job did not sin with his lips.
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Summary of 2:1-10

At some point (apparently not long after Job’s initial series of calamities), God again calls in the angelic beings to give an account of their actions, and repeats his earlier question to Satan (2:1-2a). Satan for his part repeats his former reply (v2b), leading God again to point to Job, adding to his already positive assessment of the man that even Satan’s vicious and baseless attacks have not deterred Job from worshipping God (v3). Satan still finds a way to be unimpressed, reasoning that Job has in some way sacrificed the lives of others (i.e., his children and workers) to preserve his own life (v4). No, Satan says, Job’s worship of God is *still* conditioned on receiving God’s blessing, if only the blessing of his own good health (v5). For a second time, Yahweh calls Satan’s bluff, forbidding only the actual murder of Job (v6).

Thus Job is targeted by Satan again, beset with some terrible disease, with only the most desperate means of mitigation (vv7-8). At this point, Job’s wife has had enough, counseling Job in essence to commit suicide by cursing God (v9). Job rebukes her for this counsel, repeating the thrust of his earlier (1:21) statement that God’s will must be accepted, whether it brings pleasant things or horrible experiences (2:10). The final sentence of v10 “does not suggest that Job did sin in his heart; sin with the lips is what... Satan had predicted, and sin with the lips is what Job has not done” (Ash, 53).

Job’s initial response to these calamities has been admirable indeed. Yet as time wears on, and his thoughts race within him, his desire for answers will become all but unbearable. Meanwhile, some new characters are about to arrive on the scene.

Paraphrase of 2:11-3:26 Now, three of Job’s friends heard about his tragic reverses, and they arranged to come from their hometowns to Job in order to offer their sympathies. These men were Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar the Naamathite. 2:12 They first caught sight of Job when they were still some distance off, and at first they didn't even recognize him. Distraught that the situation was even worse than they had anticipated, they wept loudly, tore their clothes in grief, and tossed clouds of dirt into the air, which came raining down on their heads. 2:13 For seven days and seven nights the three of them sat on the ground with Job; and, recognizing that Job was deeply traumatized,	Translation of 2:11-3:26 And three friends of Job heard all this disaster which had come upon him, and each man came from his place—Eliphaz the Temanite, and Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar the Naamathite, and they coordinated to come to sympathize with him and to comfort him. 2:12 And they lifted up their eyes from a distance, and did not recognize him, and they lifted up their voices and wept, and each man tore his mantle, and they cast dust on their heads toward the sky. 2:13 And they sat with him on the ground seven days and seven nights, with none speaking a word to him, for they saw that his trauma was great. 3:1 After this Job opened his mouth and cursed his
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they made no attempt to say anything at all.

3:1-2 Then, after these seven days and nights, Job ended his silence, and said,

3:3 Perish the day of my birth! I wish I had never even been conceived!

3:4 May the day of my birth be hidden from all sight, shrouded in darkness and forgotten by God.

3:5 May it be enwrapped in stormy darkness, in inky blackness and hopeless mire.

3:6 May it disappear from history, overtaken by despair.

3:7 Oh, may it be a day of nothingness, a day of no happiness!

3:8 I call on the most reckless of sorcerers to curse that day.

3:9 Turn off the stars; may dawn's early light never come!

3:10 I hate that day, because I was fated to be born, to go on to live a wretched life.

3:11 Couldn't I have died while I was still in the womb, or immediately after being born?

3:12 I was placed in my father's lap to be welcomed; I was placed on my mother's breast to drink. Why?

3:13 If I had died in the womb or right afterward, I would have had peace and rest

3:14 With the great men of history, with all of their achievements,

3:15 And with the powerful men of society, with all of their riches,

3:16 And in harmony with those children who have died in the womb, never to walk the earth or see the sun.

3:17 In the afterlife, evil people stop creating chaos, and those who are worn out are able to recuperate.

3:18 The prisoners are free, no longer having to endure the barks of correctional officers.

3:19 Everyone is there—those who were little thought of together with those who were idolized during their lives. The servant and the master are equals there.

3:20-22 It seems pointless for God to give life to a person, only to have that person live a bitter, hardscrabble life to the point where they prefer death to life, and are overjoyed when the end comes.

3:23 It seems cruel for a man to be given absolutely no idea why things are happening as they are in his life.

3:24 Instead of tasting food, I experience trauma; instead of drinking water, I flow with tears.

3:25 What I was afraid of has come true; my worst fears have been realized.

day. **3:2** And Job answered and said,

3:3 May the day on which I was born vanish, And the night that said, "A male is conceived."

3:4 That day, let it be darkness;

Let not God seek it from above,

And let not light shine upon it.

3:5 Let darkness and impenetrable darkness redeem it as their own;

Let a cloud settle upon it;

Let the darkness of a storm terrify it.

3:6 That day, let gloom take it;

Let it not appear among the days of a year;

Into the record of the months let it not enter.

3:7 Behold, that day, let it be barren;

Let no shout of joy enter it.

3:8 Let them who curse a day denounce it—

They who are ready to rouse Leviathan.

3:9 Let the bright stars be darkened;

Let it wait for light, and there be none,

Nor let it see the eyes of dawn.

3:10 For the doors of my [mother's] womb were not closed,

Nor was toil hidden from my eyes.

3:11 Why did I not die in the womb,

Coming out from the womb that I might die?

3:12 Why did the knees receive me,

Or why the breasts, that I should nurse?

3:13 For in that case I would have lain down and been quiet.

Then I would have slept, and found rest for myself,

3:14 With kings and counselors of the earth,

Those who rebuilt for themselves the [ancient cities which are now] ruins,

3:15 Or with princes who possessed gold,

Those who filled their houses with silver,

3:16 Or like a miscarried child who is buried I would have no [earthly] existence,

Like infants who never saw light.

3:17 There the wicked cease from turbulence,

And there those who are weary of strength rest.

3:18 There the prisoners are at ease;

They do not hear the voice of the [prison] official.

3:19 Whether small or great, each is there,

And the servant is free from his master.

3:20 Why is light given to him who undergo toil,

And life to the bitter in spirit,

3:21 Who seek for death, and it is not [there],

And dig for it like treasure,

3:22 Who are joyfully happy,

3:26 I am filled with anxiety, turmoil, and trouble—disaster has ruined my life.	Rejoicing when they find the grave— 3:23 [Why, I ask, is light given] to the man whose way is hidden, Over whom God has cast a shadow? 3:24 For before my food my anguish comes, And my cry pours forth like water. 3:25 For the fear I feared approached me, And that which I dreaded came upon me. 3:26 I am not at peace, I am not quiet, And I am not at rest, for turmoil has come.
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Summary of 2:11-3:26

The news reaches three friends of Job's, and they travel together to console him (2:11). That upon arrival they initially do not recognize him highlights the truly devastating affliction their friend is undergoing (v12a), and their reaction of extreme grief suggests that the situation is even worse than they have anticipated (v12b). A full week of shocked silence descends upon the scene (v13).

But the silence is not eternal. “Job’s inner anguish has been boiling up within him, and in the end he cannot hold it in. And it pours out in the darkest chapter of the book” (Ash, 65): In what must have been a storm of hot tears, Job wishes he had never been born (3:1-12), arguing that his early death would be preferable to his adult suffering (vv13-16). Meditating on death as the fate of all humans (vv17-19), leads Job to wonder why life is given to those whose lives—like his (vv24-26)—will be marked by inexplicable and unbearable pain (vv20-23).

Job’s words trouble his friends, and the reply to Job of the apparent leader, Eliphaz, follows.

Paraphrase of 4:1-5:27 Then Eliphaz replied, 4:2 It feels wrong to say anything to you, Job, with such pain written on your face. But something has to be said in response. 4:3-4 Listen, you've corrected many people who were in sin or getting snared in trouble, and have come alongside many people who were discouraged or frightened. 4:5 But now you are the one in trouble, and you're on the verge of giving up! 4:6 It's clear that you build your life on the principles of God's Word, and stake your future on living rightly. 4:7 But it seems you have forgotten something: No one free from blame has been brought to ruin. 4:8 In my experience, people who plot and scheme immediately see the plot backfire on them. 4:9 God blows on them, and they are whisked away. 4:10-11 Such is the fate of even the strongest and most politically secure of them; as invulnerable as they think they are, if God strips away their resources, nothing is left for them or their families. 4:12-13 I'll tell you a secret I once heard, something I caught a whisper of when, tossing and turning on my bed at night, vivid dreams held me in place. 4:14 I became terrified, and shook all over; in my	Translation of 4:1-5:27 And Eliphaz the Temanite answered and said, 4:2 Shall we take up a case against you who grows faint in spirit? Yet who is able to restrain words? 4:3 Behold, you have reproved many, And you have strengthened weak hands. 4:4 As for the one who stumbles, your words have raised him up, And weak knees you have given courage. 4:5 But now it has come to you and you grow faint in spirit; It has touched you, and you are dismayed. 4:6 Is not your fear [of God] your confidence, The integrity of your ways, your hope? 4:7 Please call to mind: Who is that one who, [though] innocent, disappeared [from history]? And where are the upright who have been hidden [from the eyes of the world]? 4:8 The moment I saw those who plot iniquity, [I saw the truth of this statement:] Those who sow trouble reap the same. 4:9 In the face of the breath of God they vanish, And at the wind of his nostrils they are consumed. 4:10 The roar of the lion, and the voice of the king of the beasts,
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dream my knees were knocking together.

4:15 A spirit came up to me, and my hair stood on end.

4:16a-b It stood right in front of me, but I couldn't make out what it looked like, though there was something there.

4:16c-17 I felt his breath on my face, and he said, "A mortal cannot be acceptable in God's sight; no human's actions are blameless.

4:18 "As it is, God does not even have full confidence in his angels, finding fault with them.

4:19a "So it is preposterous to think that he would have confidence in puny, mortal humans!

4:19b-20 "Humans are like a house of cards; he squishes them like a bug. In the space of a day their hopes and dreams crumble to nothing, slipping right through their fingers, never to be heard of again.

4:21 "All this because they did not pay attention to God's instruction; they perish because they lack wisdom."

5:1 Such was my dream, Job. Its message is clear: Try as you might, there is no angel to which you can appeal for help. You must face up to your sin.

5:2 Unbridled anger leads to death for the obstinate sinner; those unacquainted with wisdom face only destruction if they think that their misguided passion is the path they should follow.

5:3 In my day, I've seen a wicked man getting established in his career more than once or twice, and without a second thought I've pronounced a curse on his home:

5:4-5 I prayed, "God, do not deliver his children; destroy them in the sight of everyone, no one helping, because he didn't share his abundance with the poor, showed no sympathy for grinding poverty, but instead maliciously sent them to places offering no help."

5:6 After all, evil does not come from nowhere; wickedness doesn't grow on trees.

5:7 No, it is mankind that brings trouble to the table—and thereby opens Pandora's box.

5:8 Here's my advice: Turn with humility to God, and explain your situation to him.

5:9 God, after all, is the one who accomplishes innumerable and incomprehensible miracles.

5:10 He sends rain to water the fields,

5:11-12 He changes the topography of the earth, and similarly changes the fate of the humble, while thwarting wicked schemes;

5:13-14 Indeed, he uses the self-perceived cleverness

And the teeth of the young lions are broken;

4:11 A brave lion vanishes where there is no food, And the children of the lioness are scattered.

4:12 A word was snuck to me, And my ear caught a whisper of it

4:13 In troubling thoughts from visions of the night, When deep sleep falls upon men.

4:14 Fear met me, and trembling, And the multitude of my bones became afraid.

4:15 And a spirit passed before me, And the hair of my flesh stood up.

4:16 It stood before me, but I did not recognize its form;

And image was before my face;

A stirring of air I heard:

4:17 "Can a mortal be just before God?

"Will a man be pure from his works?

4:18 "Behold, in his servants he put no trust—

"And to his angels he ascribes error—

4:19 "How much less those who dwell in houses of clay,

"Whose foundation is in the dust;

"He crushes them before the moth.

4:20 "From morning to evening they are beaten down;

"For lack of attentiveness they vanish forever.

4:21 "Is not their [tent] cord pulled up in their midst?

"They die, and not in wisdom."

5:1 Call out! Is there one who will answer you?

And to which of the holy ones will you turn?

5:2 For vexation will kill the fool, And passion will put the naive to death.

5:3 I have seen the fool taking root, And I cursed his dwelling place immediately:

5:4 "Let his sons be far from salvation, "And let them be crushed in the gate with no one to deliver!

5:5 "For the hungry he did not feed from his harvest,

"But took him to the thorny thickets,

"Though the thirsty pant after their wealth."

5:6 For iniquity does not come out from the dust,

And trouble does not bloom from the dirt,

5:7 But man begets trouble, And the sons of Resheph take wing.

5:8 But for my part, I will seek the Divine One,

And I will submit my cause to God,

5:9 Who does great things that are unsearchable, Wondrous things without number—

5:10 The one who gives rain upon the face of the earth,

of people against them, bringing the plans of the wicked to nothing, so that these people wander aimlessly, as if blind. 5:15-16 So God delivers the righteous from the attacks of the wicked, leaving goodness standing at the end of the day, and evil defeated. 5:17 Consider: The man who accepts God's rebuke, accepting correction, experiences the Almighty's goodness. 5:18 God wounds in discipline, but also heals the repentant. 5:19 If you are such a repentant person, no amount of tribulations will harm you, since God will be watching over you. 5:20-22 God will protect you from famine and war, from slander and demonic attack, from national calamity and dangerous animals. 5:23 You will be safe because the stones of the field will have formed a treaty with you, and the animals will be on friendly terms with you. 5:24 Then it will sink in that your household is full of tranquility; your inventory will undergo no shrink. 5:25 You'll also observe that your family is vast, filling the earth. 5:26 When you die, it will be contentedly, having lived a long, full life. 5:27 Well, all this is what the studies show. It will be to your benefit to allow your lifestyle to reflect these best practices.	And sends waters upon the face of the fields, 5:11 Making the valleys high, And raising those in mourning up to salvation, 5:12 Breaking the plans of the shrewd, So that their hands do not effect success, 5:13 Capturing the wise in their shrewdness, While the counsel of the perverse stumbles— 5:14 By day they meet darkness, And they grope in the afternoon as though it was night— 5:15 And he saves from the sword that issues from their mouth, And the poor from the hand of the strong. 5:16 And hope eventuates for the weak, But iniquity shuts its mouth. 5:17 Behold, how blessed is the man whom God reproves, And do not refuse the discipline of the Almighty. 5:18 For he wounds, and binds up; He strikes, and his hands heal. 5:19 In the mist of six trials he will deliver you; Even in the midst of seven [trials] no calamity will touch you. 5:20 In famine he will deliver you from death, And in war from the hands of the sword. 5:21 When the tongue lashes, you will be hidden; And you will not fear the demon when he comes. 5:22 At violence and hunger you will laugh, Nor will you fear the beast of the field. 5:23 For your covenant will be with the stones of the field, And the beast of the field will be brought to peace with you. 5:24 And you will know that your tent is peace, And you will take inventory of your dwelling place and find nothing missing. 5:25 And you will know that great is your seed, And numerous is your offspring, like the greenery of the earth. 5:26 In strength you will enter your grave, When you go up to your tomb in its time. 5:27 Behold, these things we have searched out—thus they are. Hear them, and for your own sake take it to heart.
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Summary of 4:1-5:27

Eliphaz “begins politely” (Andersen, 118), admitting at the outset that it is bold for him and the others to criticize a man in Job's horrendous position (4:2a), and that it is only under a certain compulsion that he finds it necessary to speak (v2b). Indeed, he goes on to catalog some of Job's virtues: Job has been known for offering reproof and

encouraging those beset by fear and insecurity (v3-4). And it is clear to Eliphaz that underlying Job's outward actions is an inward reverence for God (v6).

Yet in spite of all this, Eliphaz feels it necessary to conclude that Job stands in need of rebuke (v5). After all, Eliphaz reasons, history knows no example of the righteous being utterly destroyed (4:7), as Job very nearly has been; the implication is that Job has engaged in some iniquity. Those who plot iniquity must expect calamity (vv8-11). All men face this dilemma, since all men sin—a point brought home to Eliphaz by a frightening dream (vv12-21). No angel can render assistance in this matter (5:1), Eliphaz warns, and to fight against this two-fold law (that sinners face judgment, and that all men are sinners) is nothing but self-destructive folly. Job can fight with all the passion he wants, Eliphaz says, but the only one with a black eye will be Job (v2). It is not that God is being unfair, for the wicked do really deserve judgment, as a man like Eliphaz is astute enough to keep in mind (vv3-5). Men cannot appeal to circumstances to explain away their action (v6); they themselves stir up trouble (v7a), thereby opening Pandora's box (v7b).

What is to be done? One must turn to God (v8), declaims Eliphaz. God is majestic (v9), good (v10), and just (vv11-15), finally silencing the forces of injustice (v16). If a man, wicked though he is, accepts God's reproof, he is blessed (v17), for the God who reproves the wicked also accepts the repentant (v18). Not only this, but the one who has listened to God's reproof enjoys God's security (vv19-25), and passes away peacefully when his days are over (v26). All this, Eliphaz—who speaks now on behalf of Bildad and Zophar as well—asserts to be assured truth, to which Job would do well to listen (v27).

Perhaps these words might have been comforting to Job, except for one thing: They are completely wrong. Eliphaz assumes that Job stands in need of repentance, but he does not. Eliphaz declares that calamity avoids the righteous, but, at least for Job, it did not. Job feels further wounded by his friend's words, and his response will follow.

Paraphrase of 6:1-7:21	Translation of 6:1-7:21
Job replied,	And Job answered and said,
6:2 I wish you were more considerate. Think for a second about what I'm going through!	6:2 If only my vexation was carefully measured, And my devastation taken up on the scales!
6:3 There is no way to measure my pain. So you can understand if I've spoken in an overly strident way.	6:3 For now it is heavier than the sand of the sea; For that reason my words have been rash.
6:4 It's like God is an archer and has shot me with his arrows; they've sunk deep due to his carefully planned ambush against me.	6:4 For the arrows of the Almighty are with me, For my spirit drinks their heat; The terrors of God arrange for battle against me.
6:5 Animals don't make noises for no reason, and you better believe I've got a good reason for talking like this!	6:5 Does a wild donkey bray over grass, Or a bull low over its fodder?
6:6 People don't eat food that has no taste, and I'm not weeping where there is no tragedy!	6:6 Does one eat what is tasteless without salt, Or is there seasoning in the juice of a mallow?
6:7 I've completely lost my appetite; I'm like a sick person, able only to moan in bed.	6:7 My appetite refuses to touch [anything]; My flesh groans as with illness.
6:8 If only God would supply what I hope for and wait for from him: Comfort in my pain, and answers to my questions!	6:8 Oh that my request would come, And that God would grant what I hope for!
6:9 But God has it in his head that he must pulverize me—I'm like a fly he has to swat.	6:9 Yet God wills to crush me; He lets his hand fly to destroy me.
6:10 I want so badly to experience relief from my emotional torment—to be joyful again! If only God would rescue me! It would only make sense, since I have always spoken God's truth unashamedly.	6:10 Let my comfort again be that I might leap for joy! In the midst of [my] anguish, oh that he would spare [me]!
6:11 How can I be expected to keep waiting for	For I have not concealed the words of the holy one. 6:11 What is my strength, that I should wait? Or what is my limit, that I should extend my patience? 6:12 Is my strength the strength of stones,

deliverance and vindication, as if there is no limit to my endurance?

6:12 I'm not a rock—cut me, and I'll bleed.

6:13 Doesn't God know that he is the only one who can help me? I certainly can't do anything to help myself now!

6:14 Isn't it reasonable for a person who's suffering incredible trauma to expect some sympathy from a friend? Eliphaz, though, doesn't respect God's commands enough to give me any sympathy.

6:15 In fact, all three of my friends have let me down in a huge way. They are like a river in the desert:

6:16-18 As ice melts in the mountains above, torrid water cuts paths through the desert. Yet, as the hot sun beats down on the water, it vanishes as quickly as it came.

6:19-20 Traders crossing the Arabian desert stake their hopes on this water, only to be horrified to find nothing.

6:21 I say all this because you offer me no help at all. You've seen something shocking, and you recoil in fear rather than reaching out to lend a hand.

6:22 I've never demanded anything, never asked for a bribe.

6:23 Help me, my friends! I'm in a horrible situation that I can't escape!

6:24 Since you three are so smart, tell me what I've done wrong, and I'll shut up. Just tell me!

6:25 Your claims to be teachers of righteousness are so false right now, they make me want to throw up! Such hypocrisy is worse than useless.

6:26 You should know not to take too seriously what a man whose life has just come crashing down says, so why the effort to crush me verbally?

6:27 You might as well be dividing the possessions of an orphan. You are like imperialistic powers dividing up your new colonies among you.

6:28 Look me in the eye—if I'm lying about my uprightness, wouldn't it be obvious?

6:29 Please don't get caught up in sin; change your ways, because I am innocent.

6:30 I am not a liar, and I know how to sidestep temptation, knowing the havoc sin causes.

7:1 The fact is, being a human is a tough row to hoe. A man's life is hard work with little reward.

7:2 Like a laborer in the hot sun, he hopes for rest, but has only more toil to look forward to.

7:3 My situation is the same. My lifework has been pointless, and I only have worse things to anticipate.

Or is my flesh bronze,

6:13 Or does my source of help not consist in him? For success has been driven from me.

6:14 For the person in despair there ought to be faithful kindness from his friend, But he has abandoned the fear of the Almighty.

6:15 My brothers have proven treacherous like a wadi, Like a channel of torrents they have passed by,

6:16 [Torrents] that are dark from [the melting of] ice, In which is hidden [melted] snow:

6:17 At just the time they flow, they are brought to an end by its heat;

They are extinguished from their place.

6:18 They wend along the paths of their way; They ascend into nothingness and disappear.

6:19 Travelers to Tema look expectantly; Caravans to Sheba hope for them.

6:20 They are ashamed that they were confident; They came there, and were ashamed.

6:21 For now you are nothing.

You see an object of horror and you are afraid.

6:22 Have I ever said, "Give to me,"

Or, "From your wealth bribe me"? [You have not!]

6:23 So deliver me from the hand of adversity, And from the hand of terrors redeem me!

6:24 Instruct me, and I will be silent.

And how have I gone astray? Give me insight!

6:25 How sickening are "upright words"!

And how can one be expected to offer reproof with [the kind of] reproving that comes from you?

6:26 Do you intend to reprove with words,

Though the words of a despairing man are merely air?

6:27 Indeed, you cast [lots] over the orphan, And barter for your friend['s possessions].

6:28 And now, please set your eyes on me, For it is to your faces if I am lying.

6:29 Please repent; let there not be iniquity.

Indeed, repent: My righteousness is still in it.

6:30 Is there iniquity on my tongue?

Or does my palate not discern destruction?

7:1 Is not the life of a mortal hard service on the earth, And are not his days as the days of a hired servant?

7:2 As a servant pants after the shade,

And as a hired servant waits for his work,

7:3 So I for my part have inherited vain months,

And troubling nights have been appointed for me.

7:4 If I have lain down and said,

"When shall I arise?" and the evening lengthened, And I was satisfied with tossing and turning until

7:4-6 I have not been a lazy man. If I had, my health would have collapsed, and I soon would have been brought to the point of death without any prospect for a reversal of fortunes.

7:7 Bear in mind, God, that my life is fleeting, and I will never again experience anything pleasant.

7:8 Soon, I will be just a memory; you see me now, but in the future you won't.

7:9 People are like clouds—there, and then gone forever. They never return from the afterlife.

7:10 They spend no more time in the house they long lived in; their hometowns do not see their faces.

7:11 Well, other people may suffer in silence, but not me—I'm going to say my bit!

7:12 God, you treat me like I'm a demonic being from some myth, or like a ferocious wild animal.

7:13-14 When I think that sleep will bring me some relief, my sleep becomes a terrifying experience, the domain of terrible dreams.

7:15 I would rather die than keep living in this state.

7:16 My decision is final: I do not wish to live. So leave me alone. My life is so pointless!

7:17 Humankind is nothing! So why do you raise it up to be caretakers of your creation? Why does humankind matter so much to you?

7:18 Daily—every second, in fact—you put it under the magnifying glass, scrutinizing its every move.

7:19 Please just give me a second to myself—enough time to swallow without you attacking me!

7:20 I'm not a wicked person! I don't understand you, you Orwellian dictator! It's so illogical that I'm Public Enemy #1 in your eyes—what did I ever do to you?

7:21 You are incredibly oversensitive to my faults. It makes no sense! Look, here I am, lying in ruins, soon to disappear from the world scene forever.

evening,

7:5 My flesh would have been clothed with the worm and with the crust of dirt;
My skin would have become rigid and been rejected.

7:6 My days have speedily escaped the shuttle,
And come to an end without hope.

7:7 Remember that my life is a puff of air;
My eye will never again see good.

7:8 No eye will see me.
Your eyes are on me [now], but [soon] I will be no more.

7:9 The cloud is exhausted and goes away.
In the same way one goes down to Sheol and does not go up [again].

7:10 He does not return again to his house,
And his place does not again recognize him.

7:11 For my part, I will not hold back:
My mouth will speak concerning my spirit's trial;
I will murmur concerning my soul's bitterness.

7:12 Am I Yam, or the sea monster
That you post a guard against me?

7:13 When I say, "My couch will comfort me;
"My bed will bear my complaint,"

7:14 I am shattered by dreams,
And visions terrify me,

7:15 And I chose strangulation for my throat,
Death rather than my bones.

7:16 I have rejected forever that I should live;
Cease from [troubling] me, for my days are vanity.

7:17 What is mortal man, that you magnify him,
Or that you pay attention to him?

7:18 You bring him to account each morning;
Moment by moment you test him.

7:19 How long will you not look away from me?
You do not give me a moment to swallow my spit.

7:20 Have I sinned? What will I do with regard to you,
o watcher of men?
Why have you made me a target?
And am I a burden to you?

7:21 And why will you not bear my transgression,
Or pass over my iniquity?
For now I sit on the dust,
And you have sought me, but I am nowhere [to be found].

Summary of 6:1-7:21

Job's "response [to Eliphaz] is a tremendous emotional outburst. He defends himself mightily, protesting against his friend's insinuation that somewhere in his life there must be some fault which needs correction. Job insists that his wild words are fully justified (6:2-7)" (Andersen, 137). He desperately wants comfort from God (vv8,

10a-b), but God is apparently interested only in crushing him, despite Job's high character (v10c). "[T]he rhetorical questions of vv. 11-13 seem to be expressing his human weakness... implying that he has no strength or power that he would be able to see his way through the crisis" (L. Wilson, 57).

Meanwhile, Job's friends have been a huge disappointment. It is self-evident that a man's friend ought to comfort him when he is despairing (v14a), but Job's friends show a culpable lack of love (v14b). In vv15-21, "Job compares his friends to desert streams that swell with water after a storm but dry up in the heat of summer. He presses the illustration by imagining further the disappointment and tragic results of caravans that perish because they do not find life-sustaining water. Job's disappointment with his friends is analogous. Though in the past he never needed their aid, he does now; but they respond with empty hands" (Alden, 102).

Job's friends know very well that Job is a man of integrity (v22). That being the case, so far from accusing him of wrongdoing, they ought to be defending him before God (v23). Job sarcastically tells them to inform him of his faults (v24). Their stale, unfeeling orthodoxy is appalling to him (vv25-26); they seem eager to benefit from his tragedies (v27). He is not lying (vv28, 30), which means that they are guilty of liable (v29).

Job shifts in 7:1-6 to paint a bleak picture of mankind in general and of himself in particular (L. Wilson, 60). God's treatment of him, he contends, is extremely unfair.

And yet, Job does not turn *away* from God at this point, but *to* him. "It is a hugely significant move Job now turns and addresses the God with whom he grapples. Always he has loved and feared God. He is a true believer. He has never doubted the sovereignty of God... But up until now he has not explicitly spoken *to* God. Now he does" (Ash, 127). What Job asks is for God to take into account how miserable and fleeting his life is (vv7-10, 13-16). It is right, he claims, for him to insist on this (v11)—it is not as though he is God's enemy (v12)! "Why do I matter?" (Ash, 127), he asks God (v17). That is, what has humankind done to provoke such intense scrutiny (vv18-19), even when innocent (v20) of any non-trivial offense (v21a). The concluding note (v21b) is stark: "Life is so fragile that, in Job's condition, death cannot be far away" (G. Wilson, 68).

Job's friends are not convinced. Indeed, Bildad, it turns out, is fully prepared to dial up the intensity of the argument.

Paraphrase of 8:1-22

Bildad replied,

8:2 How long must I put up with such dazzling arrogance from you, Job?

8:3 God does not fail to do the right thing, as you are implying!

8:4 Your children only got what they deserved: They were wicked, and paid the price.

8:5 But if you humbly repent and ask God for his help,

8:6 And if you engage in good deeds, God will take action on your behalf, and will turn things around for you on the basis of your good conduct.

8:7 Then things will be even better for you than they were before your present calamity.

8:8 All this would be clear if you would just stop for a moment and consider the wisdom of the ancients—

8:9 After all, you and I have been around only a short time, and by comparison with the ancients we know nothing—

8:10 And they will impart their wisdom to you.

8:11-13 The wicked man's prospect for his future is as bright as a swamp plant without a swamp;

8:14 What he trusts in is no help to him. It's like a

Translation of 8:1-22

And Bildad the Shuhite answered and said,

8:2 How long will you speak these things,
And your words be [like] a mighty spirit?

8:3 Will the Divine One pervert justice?
Or will the Almighty pervert righteousness?

8:4 If your children have sinned against him,
He has released them into the hand of their transgression.

8:5 If you will seek the Divine One,
And supplicate the Almighty;

8:6 If you are pure and upright,
Surely now he will rouse himself concerning you,
And restore the dwelling of your righteousness.

8:7 And your beginning will be little [by comparison],
And your end will be very great.

8:8 For ask, if you please, the first generation,
And establish what their fathers searched out.

8:9 For we are [only] from yesterday, and we do not know [anything],

For a shadow are our days on the earth.

8:10 Will they not instruct you? They will speak to you,

web— 8:15 Try to lean on it, and it vanishes; in just this way, the wicked man faces utter defeat. 8:16 Here's another visualization of the wicked: He is like a plant that seems very healthy, 8:17 Like a vine that sneaks its tendrils into the crevices between rocks, 8:18 Yet his seeming security is an illusion which will mock him in the end. Let me tell you, I've seen it happen before, and I'll see it happen again. 8:19 But these wicked fellows love it, and for every Hydra's head that gets lopped off, more will come. 8:20 God is faithful to uphold those who do good, and faithful to punish those who do evil. 8:21 It's not over—you can still have a happy life if you repent, 8:22 And your enemies will be put to shame, and the wicked will fade away.	And from their minds will go forth words. 8:11 Does papyrus grow where there is no marsh? Reeds without water? 8:12 When it is still growing it is surely picked, And before all greenery it withers. 8:13 So are the ways of all who forget the Divine One, While the hope of the profane vanishes. 8:14 For his confidence snaps [like a broken rope], And his trust is like a spider's web: 8:15 He leans on his house and does not stand; He takes hold of it and does not arise. 8:16 He is full of sap before the sun, And on his rooftop his vine reaches out. 8:17 On a heap his roots are interwoven; He lives between the stones. 8:18 If his place swallows him up And deceives him, surely I have seen such [before]. 8:19 Behold, he is the joy of his way, And from the dust others will sprout. 8:20 Behold, the Divine One will not reject the person of integrity, Nor take hold of the hand of evildoers. 8:21 Your mouth can still be filled with laughter, And your lips with a shout. 8:22 Those who hate you will be clothed with shame, While the tent of the wicked will no longer be.
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Summary of 8:1-22

Eliphaz having failed on his first try to set things straight (as he sees it), Bildad joins in. If Eliphaz made an effort to be tactful, Bildad is breathtaking in his bluntness, immediately labeling Job as arrogant (8:2); the death of Job's children, he says, is their own fault (v4). After all, Bildad insists, God is just (v3).

It's not all gloom and doom, however: If Job repents, and shows his repentance through good deeds, God will restore his fortunes even beyond what they formerly were (vv6-7). Such is the lesson of history (v8, 10); a single life-time is not enough to think independently on these things (v9). So, if Job will avoid the fleeting and hopeless life of the wicked (vv11-19), and live instead as a man of righteousness (v20), then God will bless and protect him (vv21-22).

In sum, Bildad's tone is sharper than Eliphaz's, but his assumptions are the same. In their view, God rewards the righteous with good things and punishes the wicked with disaster. Therefore, Job must have sinned, and must repent. But Job is not willing to concede any of these points.

Paraphrase of 9:1-10:22 Job replied, 9:2 I have no doubt whatsoever that any attempt of a human being to dispute with God would fail miserably. What a shame! 9:3 If someone tried, God would drown that person in a sea of arguments, leaving them unable to get in a word edgewise. 9:4 No one, no matter how intellectual or how	Translation of 9:1-10:22 And Job answered and said, 9:2 Truly I know that it is thus: How can a mortal man plead his case before the Divine One? 9:3 If one wished to argue a case with him, He would not answer him one word from a thousand. 9:4 The wise of mind and the mighty of strength— Who can be stubborn with him and see repayment
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muscular, can extract damages from God in the courtroom.

9:5 God is altogether too imposing for people to get a proper hearing: His anger causes mountains to tumble, and people don't even know it;

9:6 He shakes the earth so hard that it wobbles in its orbit, unstable in its appointed course;

9:7 At his mere word, the sun forebears to shine, and the stars also;

9:8 His alone is the energy by which space expands, and the roaring oceans are no obstacle for him;

9:9 All the wonders of the starry expanse are his handiwork;

9:10 There is no number or descriptor that can rightly be applied to his astonishing creations.

9:11 God's movements completely escape my powers of perception, leaving me utterly in the dark!

9:12 Moreover, God's actions are unalterable and open to no challenge,

9:13 And his anger—which he does not hold back—is so powerful that the demons tremble.

9:14 If those beings are powerless, what am I, a mere mortal, to do? How could I make myself understood by this God?

9:15 It makes no difference whether I am the one who is right—I cannot hope to make my case before God.

9:16 Even if I heard a reply from him, I would not give credence to what my ears were telling me.

9:17 After all, he seems to have it in for me: God treats me like a weapons testing ground, blowing me to pieces again and again through no fault of my own.

9:18 He won't even give me a second to catch my breath as he ruins my life again and again.

9:19 Justice is a pipe dream for me, because no one can overpower God or subpoena him.

9:20 Even if I was in the courtroom with him, I know that somehow I would trip up in my words and seem like I'm guilty; my innocence would be misconstrued by him.

9:21-22 But let me state what I believe to the core of my being: I am a man of integrity! But my life is pointless; nothing matters. Here's the conclusion I've drawn: God destroys people whether they are righteous or wicked.

9:23 If a pandemic tears through the globe and kills many innocent souls, God will turn their tragedy into a meme.

9:24 God gives the evil men of the earth all the power, and puts corrupt judges into place. Don't tell me it

from him?

9:5 He who moves mountains without their knowledge,

Who overturns them in his anger,

9:6 Who shakes the earth from its place, And its pillars shudder,

9:7 Who speaks to the sun and it does not shine, And seals the stars,

9:8 Stretching out the heavens by himself, And treading on the high places of the sea,

9:9 Who makes [the constellations] Leo, Orion, and Pleiades,

And the chambers of Gemini,

9:10 Who does great things that are unsearchable, Wondrous things without number.

9:11 Behold, he passes by me, and I do not see, And he passes on, and I do not discern him,

9:12 If he tears away, who will restore it? Who can say to him, "What are you doing?"

9:13 God does not restrain his anger; Beneath him crouch the helpers of Rahab.

9:14 How much less can I, even I, answer him? Choose my words before him?

9:15 For [even] if I am righteous, I cannot answer; Concerning my right I [cannot] make a plea.

9:16 If I called and he answered me, I would not believe that he heard my voice.

9:17 For with a storm he wounds me, And he multiplies my blows for no reason.

9:18 He does not allow me to gather in my spirit, For he fills me with bitter things.

9:19 If it is a matter of the strength of might, behold[, he is the mightiest]!

And if it is a matter of judgment, who can see to it that he takes part in the meeting?

9:20 If I am righteous, my mouth will make me out to be wicked;

I am a man of integrity, but he will make me out to be crooked.

9:21 I am a man of integrity; Assuredly I know [this] in my [very] soul.

I reject my life:

9:22 It is all the same.

Therefore I say,

"People of integrity and people of wickedness [alike] he destroys."

9:23 If a scourge puts [many] to death suddenly, He will mock the despair of the innocent.

9:24 The land has been given into the hand of the

isn't God who does these things, because there's no other option!

9:25-26 Few and bitter are the years of my life.

9:27-28 I could pretend as if everything was fine, using cosmetics to hide my condition and putting on a brave face, but deep down the anxiety that my ongoing trauma puts in my chest would be building up, anticipating the day when God holds me guilty.

9:29 God's guilty verdict is inevitable, so what's the point in trying so hard?

9:30-31 If I wash myself clean, he will throw toxic mud on me.

9:32 I say all this because God is completely foreign to my humanity, making impossible any attempt to settle the dispute between us.

9:33 Nobody can be a go-between, impartially helping both me and God to speak fairly and clearly to each other.

9:34 I wish so bad that God would let up, and stop terrorizing me!

9:35 Then I could have fellowship with him again. But that's not my lived experience.

10:1 I hate my life. I'm going to give vent to my bitterness, and I won't hold back!

10:2 Here's what I plan to say to God: Don't paint me as a criminal! Explain to me what your evidence is for dragging me into court!

10:3 What gives you the right to be a tyrant? Why would you destroy the very thing that you created, while you smile at evil men and their schemes?

10:4 It's not as though you are mere flesh, as if you are a mortal man with all of humanity's limitations and weaknesses.

10:5 You are not some fleeting, temporary being; you have all wisdom.

10:6-7 Even though you know that I am not a man bent on sin, you mount a full-scale investigation into the unfounded possibility of sins on my account, and leave me without hope of deliverance.

10:8 How could you carefully fashion me in my mother's womb, and then turn around and turn me into a smoldering crater?

10:9 Don't forget that I am a mere mortal, whose body will one day dissolve into its constituent elements.

10:10 You were the one who formed me at conception,

10:11 And you oversaw the development of my infant body in the womb.

10:12 All my life, you have been faithful to watch over me; you have watched over me with kindness

wicked;

The faces of its judges he covers.

If it is not he [who does these things], then who?

9:25 And my days are faster than a runner's:

They flee, and do not see good.

9:26 They pass on with the papyrus boats, Like an eagle darts to food.

9:27 If as I speak I forget my complaint,

If I anoint my face so that I might smile,

9:28 I am in fear due to all my affliction;

I know that he will not consider me innocent.

9:29 I am held to be guilty.

Why do I grow weary with meaningless toil?

9:30 If I wash myself with snow,

And cleanse my hands with lye,

9:31 Then you will plunge me into the pit,

And my garments would make me an abomination.

9:32 For he is not a man like me that I should answer him,

That we should come together for adjudication.

9:33 There is no mediator between us,

Who could place his hands on the two of us.

9:34 Oh, that he would turn his rod from me,

And his terror no longer beset me!

9:35 I would speak and not be afraid of him.

But it is not so within me.

10:1 My soul despises my life.

I will let my complaint run wild;

I will speak concerning the bitterness of my soul.

10:2 I will say to God,

Do not make me out to be guilty!

Inform me on what basis you strive against me!

10:3 Is it good to you that you oppress,

That you reject the labor of your hands,

And shine on the counsel of the wicked?

10:4 Do you have eyes of flesh?

Or do you see as a man sees?

10:5 Are your days like the days of a mortal?

Or are your years like the years of a man?

10:6 For you seek my iniquity,

And inquire concerning my sin,

10:7 Despite your knowledge that I am not wicked,

And there is no one who can deliver from your hand.

10:8 Your hands shaped me and made me.

Afterwards, you turned and swallowed me up.

10:9 Please remember that you made me clay,

And to dust you will [one day] return me.

10:10 Did you not pour me out like milk,

And curdle me like cheese?

continually. 10:13 Don't try to deny that these are precious memories that you hold close to your heart! 10:14 If I have sinned, you will hold me accountable. 10:15 Yes, if I sin, you will chastise me severely—yet there's an imbalance here: If I do right, you browbeat me. When will you have enough of shaming me, and let me experience some human dignity? 10:16 It's like I'm a bear, and you're a hunter—I'm a creature you can exhibit your great skill on. 10:17 You have witness after witness take the stand to speak against me; your anger builds and builds against me; you have your armies take turns attacking me. 10:18 So what was the point of my being born? It would've made more sense for me to die in the womb, never to be known by anyone. 10:19 I wish I was never born; I wish I was dead now. 10:20 You know how short a person's life is. Why can't you just let up on me for a bit, so I can experience a little bit of happiness before I die? 10:21 Soon I will disappear forever into death, a land that radiates darkness like the sun radiates light, a land of chaos, a land that defines cheerlessness.	10:11 You clothe me with skin and flesh, And you weave me together with bones and sinews. 10:12 Life and faithful kindness you have accomplished with me, And your care has guarded my spirit. 10:13 And these things you have hidden away in your mind; I know that this is with you! 10:14 If I have sinned, you will keep your eye on me, And any iniquity of mine you will not ignore. 10:15 If I have been wicked, woe to me! And if I have been righteous, I cannot lift up my head. Take your fill of my dishonor and look upon my affliction, that I may straighten up! 10:16 You hunt me like a bear; You turn and do great things against me. 10:17 You renew your witnesses against me, And multiply your anger with me; You send armies against me in relays. 10:18 Why, then, did you cause me to exit the womb? I should have died, and no eye seen me! 10:19 Just as I did not have a[n earthly] presence, so I should not have a[n earthly] presence [now]; From the womb I ought to have been carried to a tomb. 10:20 Are not the days of my lifetime few? So turn your attention away from me, that I might smile a little 10:21 Before I go away—and do not return— To the land of darkness and impenetrable darkness, 10:22 A land of where even the light is gloom, impenetrable darkness without order, And shining forth like Gloom.
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Summary of 9:1-10:22

Perhaps more than any single speech in the book, this speech of Job's must have been spoken with tears streaking his face. Job feels on the one hand that his unexplained and unbearable suffering demands an answer from God, but on the other hand that one could not possibly hope for a fair hearing from God (9:2-4). Expanding on the latter point, Job reflects on Yahweh's omnipotence and inscrutability, as seen in Yahweh's creation and governance of the universe (vv5-10, 12-13) and in his transcendence (v11). So Job is helpless (v14); he has no plausible way of insisting on his innocence to God (v15, 19-20). Indeed, even if God *did* speak to him, he would have to believe that his ears were deceiving him (v16). After all, reasons Job, God is capriciously and continuously attacking him (vv17-18)—what else is he to conclude?

One point is very clear in Job's mind: He is a man of integrity (v21). But that, Job mutters, apparently doesn't matter to God (v22a); God seems to delight in destroying *everyone* (v23b-c), so much so that Job pictures him taking pleasure in mass-casualty events (v23). Job goes further, wondering why God gives corrupt judges the means to pervert justice (v24a-b). And Job immediately forestalls appeal to cosmic forces of evil: It is God alone who administrates the universe, and he alone bears responsibility for what happens in it (v24c).

Job feels keenly the brevity of his life (vv25-26), and he cannot act as if everything is fine (vv27-28a) for as long as God continues to act as if he is guilty (vv28b-31), with no one to correct the misrepresentation

(vv32-35). Accordingly, he announces that he will speak freely concerning his vexation (10:1), and imagines what he would say to God if he could appear before him. He would say that answers are necessary, answers concerning God's treatment of Job as a wicked person and of wicked people as good (vv2-3). While a human being, with all of humanity's foibles, might act out of ignorance, God has no such excuse (vv4-5): He knows full well that Job is righteous in his behavior (v7a), yet behaves as if he does not (v6, 7b).

This behavior is all the more perplexing when Job reflects on the fact that it was God himself created Job and shepherded him throughout his life (vv8-13). "If some of Job's more frantic outcries made us afraid that he is in peril of tumbling into unbelief, this exquisite poem on creation makes it clear that Job is basically confident that God's intentions were good... in making man" (Andersen, 166). Job's love for God, and his knowledge of God's love for him, are precisely the things that make the (apparent and inexplicable) rupture in the relationship truly painful.

So it is that Job returns to the idea (cf. 9:25-31) that there is no point to life when God treats Job the righteous as if he was Job the wicked (10:14-20a). To this idea he adds the bleak conclusion that all too soon his eyes will close forever in death (vv20b-22). As noted above, it is not as though Job is losing his faith in God. But in some ways Job might be at his lowest point.

Two of Job's friends have tried and failed to address his situation. Now the third will try his hand at it.

Paraphrase of 11:1-20	Translation of 11:1-20
Zophar replied, 11:2 Such prattling should not be allowed. A man who talks and talks like Job is always wrong. 11:3 So far, your swagger has bullied others into silence, and no one has stuck it to you. 11:4 Furthermore, you have the gall to claim that you know what is right, that you are righteous in God's eyes. 11:5 If only God himself would speak out and repudiate you! 11:6a He would display his wisdom, which is twice as much as anyone else's. 11:6b In any case, Job, realize this: If God wanted, he could completely erase this sin of yours, so beware! 11:7 How could you be so arrogant? You do not understand the depths of God! 11:8 You do not even know how to make the heights of heaven or measure the depths of earth! 11:9 Nothing in your present experience gives an idea of the vastness of it. 11:10 God is unstoppable—no one busts out of his prison, and no one refuses an invitation from him! 11:11 After all, God is fully aware of which men are wicked, and no evil deed escapes his notice. 11:12 So in light of God's limitless power and authority do not expect that a mere mortal like yourself can be smarter than him. That will happen when a horse gives birth to a human! 11:13 But there is still hope: Despite your great guilt, Job, if you humbly repent, 11:14 And reject whatever sin you have been involved	And Zophar the Naamathite answered and said, 11:2 Will a multitude of words not be answered? Or will a man of lips be in the right? 11:3 Your bragging silences men, And you mock, with none to put you to shame. 11:4 And you say, "My understanding is pure, "And I am pure in his eyes." 11:5 But how I wish that God would speak, And open his mouth against you, 11:6 That he may speak hidden things of wisdom to you, For it is double as it relates to insight. But know that God can remove from memory your iniquity as it relates to you. 11:7 Have you found out how to search out God? Have you found the fullness of the Almighty? 11:8 The heights of heaven—how will you go about making them? That which is deeper than Sheol—how will you understand [it]? 11:9 Its length is longer than the earth, And its width [is greater than] than the sea. 11:10 If he passes on and imprisons, Or he calls an assembly, who will turn him back? 11:11 For he knows those who are men of vanity, And he sees wickedness and takes note of it. 11:12 And will an empty man become intelligent? Or a wild colt—will a human be born? 11:13 If you, even you, prepare your heart, And spread your hands to him— 11:14 If iniquity is in your hands, put it far from you

in, disassociating yourself from wicked men, 11:15 Then you will find happiness, your present troubles gone, and a safe and secure future; 11:16 Then you'll forget all this trouble—it'll be water under the bridge. 11:17 The good times will roll; you will be a shining beacon. 11:18 You will be completely safe, having all confidence for the future; 11:19 No one will be your enemy; instead, everyone will ask you to advise them. 11:20 All the hopes and dreams of the wicked, by contrast, will crumble to dust; there will be no escape for them, and what they trusted in will be the very thing that brings their life to an end.	(And do not allow unrighteousness to dwell in your tents)— 11:15 Surely then you will lift up your face, beset no longer, And you will be established and unafraid. 11:16 For you will forget trouble; Like water that has passed on you will remember [it.] 11:17 And from your noon will spring a lifetime; You will be like a radiant morning. 11:18 And you will be secure, for there is hope, And you will be safe, dwelling securely. 11:19 And you will lie down with none to make you afraid, And many will seek your face. 11:20 But the eyes of the wicked will be destroyed, And any escape route will vanish before them, And their hope will be a breathing out of life.
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Summary of 11:1-20

Zophar quickly dispels any notion that he, unlike Eliphaz or Bildad, will sympathize with Job. On the contrary, Zophar immediately labels Job an arrogant bully (11:2-3). Zophar does not for a moment accept Job's claim that he is a man of integrity (v4). On the contrary, Zophar openly wishes that God himself—too wise, Zophar thinks, to be fooled by Job's words and too powerful to be afraid of him—would call out Job for his hypocrisy (vv5-6).

For Zophar, it is sufficient proof that Job is wrong to claim innocence to point to the greatness of God: God's creation is beyond human understanding (vv8-9), so certainly he himself is as well (v7); and his powers to enact justice are unimpeachable (vv10-11), implying that Job's pushback is wrong in the first instance. Humanity faces no prospect whatsoever of reasoning its way around these facts (v12).

And yet there is hope. (Perhaps Zophar's ability to still see a way forward in spite of what he just said is a hint of how it is that he and Job could be friends.) God accepts repentance, provided it is accompanied by deeds in keeping with repentance (vv13-15). If Job does repent, Zophar promises, God will bless him magnificently (vv16-19). Zophar's final word, however, is one of stark warning: If Job does *not* repent, he has only death to look forward to (v20).

Now all three of Job's friends have spoken. All three have essentially the same advice (Job must repent), based on the same logic (given the great calamities Job has suffered, he *must* have sinned). But this advice Job cannot take, and this logic Job cannot accept. And so Job must continue to wonder why he suffers so greatly, even as he hears his friends misjudge him so grievously. Not a man to take things lying down, Job will now respond to his unhelpful friends—and to his silent God.

Paraphrase of 12:1-14:22 Job replied, 12:2 What a privilege to be here with you all—man's last, best hope. When you three die, we'll all be sunk, since then the world's allotment of wisdom will be gone! 12:3 I have a brain just like you. I am not your inferior. Anyone could come up with arguments as good as yours! 12:4 Take a look at me: The people who should be my friends offer only a mocking chuckle. I called to God	Translation of 12:1-14:22 And Job answered and said, 12:2 Truly you are the people, And with you wisdom will die! 12:3 I also have a mind like you; I do not fall beneath you. Indeed, who has nothing like this? 12:4 A laughingstock to his “friend” am I, One who calls to God only to be afflicted by him; The righteous has become a laughingstock, a man of utmost integrity a wreckage.
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looking for a helping hand, and what I got was pushed down. So here I am, a good man whose life is a dumpster fire,

12:5 an object lesson in the imagination of those whose lives know only privilege.

12:6 Wicked, profane people are so much better off.

12:7-8 This is common knowledge—just open up your eyes and look around you, because the evidence is everywhere!

12:9-10 Everybody knows these things. After all, God, who gives existence and life to every living thing in the universe, has brought it about.

12:12 Humans are rational beings, and with age comes experience, so you have no excuse not to be aware of this.

12:13 God is the one who ultimately possesses intellect and strength; any successful strategy and any useful insight has its origin in him.

12:14 Yes, when God decides to destroy something, the destruction is irrevocable. When he closes a door, it is closed forever.

12:15 When he chooses, the floodwaters dry up; when he chooses, the floodwaters sweep away everything in their path.

12:16 God causes all wins and all losses; He is the one causing people to get lost, and he is the puppetmaster behind those wicked men who lead others astray.

12:17 He brings humiliation to the PHDs of the world; civil authorities lose their minds at his command.

12:18 He strips royal robes off of kings, and dresses them in rags.

12:19 He makes rulers into slaves, and warriors into failures.

12:20 Rhetoricians he turns into stammerers; Statesmen he turns into idiots.

12:21 He mocks rulers, and defangs soldiers.

12:22 He unearthed hidden things; he is the one who reveals the secrets of the universe.

12:23 He confuses foreign policy and brings nations to ruin; he turns whole peoples into refugees and blots out their name from the earth.

12:24-25 The rulers he causes to act foolishly, leaving them to stumble around like drunk men in darkness.

13:1 I can testify to all this from personal experience.

13:2 Like I told you, I have a brain just like you; I am not your inferior.

13:3 Here's where I am: I have some things to talk about with God, and I hope to get the chance.

12:5 He is the contempt of the thoughts of those at ease,
Something to be kicked around by those whose feet are firm.

12:6 The tents that belong to the destructive are at peace,

And those who enrage God enjoy security,
[And likewise] those who bring God into their hand.

12:7 Indeed, please ask the land animals, and they will instruct you;

And the birds of the air, and they will inform you,

12:8 Or contemplate the land, that it might instruct you,

And the fish the sea will recount to you:

12:9 Who does not know all these things?

For the hand of Yahweh has done this,

12:10 He in whose hand is the soul of every living thing,

And the spirit of every man.

12:11 Does not the ear test words,

And the palate test food for itself?

12:12 With the aged is wisdom,

And length of days is discernment.

12:13 With him is wisdom and might;

His is counsel and discernment.

12:14 Behold, he tears down and it is not rebuilt;

He closes against a man and it is not reopened.

12:15 Behold, he retrains the waters and they dry up,
And he releases them and they overthrow the earth.

12:16 With him is strength and success;

With him going astray and leading astray,

12:17 Causing counselors to walk barefoot,

While judges act like madmen,

12:18 The bonds of kings he loosens,

And he ties a waste cloth around their hips,

12:19 Causing priests to walk barefoot,

While strong men he subverts,

12:20 Turning speech from the reliable,

While perceptiveness he takes away from the elders,

12:21 Pouring contempt on princes,

And slackening the belt of the brave,

12:22 Revealing deep thing from darkness,

And bringing impenetrable darkness to light,

12:23 Leading nations astray and destroying them;

Scattering nations abroad and abandoning them,

12:24 Diverting the mind of the leaders of the people of the land,

And causing them to wander in wastes with no roads—

12:25 They grope in darkness and not light,

13:4 Meanwhile, you guys smear me with lies. You say you came to help me, but I wouldn't pay a cent for this kind of therapy!

13:5 Please shut your mouths—you might learn something.

13:6 Here's the thing:

13:7 I don't recall anyone making you God's spokespeople, and you certainly don't need to be speaking untruths in his name!

13:8 Do you have some secret deal with him? Are you his defense attorney?

13:9 You better watch out. This is no game; God is not your chess piece for you to move around the board.

13:10 You've got a stern rebuke from God coming, and you don't have secret channels to avoid this.

13:11 Let me tell you, God's anger is going to be more than you can handle.

13:12 Your speeches are oh-so-cute, but I'm dealing with an army and you're offering me a sandcastle.

13:13 Quit talking and hear me out. I'm going to say what I need to say, no matter the consequences.

13:14 I'll accept the risk of what I'm about to say.

13:15 Listen up: God might put me to death for my impudence in speaking to him; still, I will hang on, and in any case, I will dispute my case with him.

13:16 Also hear me on this point: As far as I'm concerned, God is the source of my salvation, for only the righteous can approach him.

13:17 Have you guys been listening? Do you get it? Don't miss what I've been saying!

13:18 So there it is—I've made my case. I'm the most innocent man alive.

13:19 Show me who can prove me wrong on this! But don't take too long finding him, because after all, I can't have long to live. Soon my voice will no longer be heard.

13:20 I only have two requests, God. Then I'll know that you care about me.

13:21 First, stop terrorizing me!

13:22 Second, say something to me, and then I'll answer; or else I'll say something, and you answer.

13:23 What I want to talk about is this: Where is my great guilt? Yes, tell me what I could have done so wrong,

13:24 I've done nothing deserving of all this, so why do you not let me see your smile, and why do you act as if I'm one of your enemies?

13:25 I'm so small and insignificant—it makes no sense that you would chase me down like this.

And he causes them to wander like a drunkard.

13:1 Behold, my eye has seen all this; My ear has heard it and discerned it.

13:2 As you have knowledge, I also have knowledge; I do not fall beneath you.

13:3 For my part, I intend to speak with the Almighty, And I desire to take up the case with the Divine One.

13:4 As for you who smear [me] with a lie— You are all worthless doctors.

13:5 Oh that you would be utterly silent, That you might acquire wisdom!

13:6 Please listen as I offer reproof, And hear the disputations of my lips.

13:7 Will you speak iniquity on the Divine One's behalf?

And will you speak deceit on his behalf?

13:8 Do you show partiality to him?

Or will you take up his case on his behalf?

13:9 Is it good that he should search you out?

Will you make fun of him as one makes fun of a mortal?

13:10 He shall thoroughly reprove you— Or do you in secret show partiality?

13:11 Will not his loftiness terrify you, And his fear fall upon you?

13:12 Your aphorisms are like proverbs of dust; Answers of clay are your answers.

13:13 Be silent before me, that I might have my say, Come what may.

13:14 I take up my flesh in my teeth, And I place my soul in my hands.

13:15 Behold, he may kill me; [yet] I certainly will wait [in hope];

Nevertheless, I will argue my ways before him.

13:16 Also, he is salvation for me, For the profane does not come before him.

13:17 Listen carefully to my words, And let my declaration sink into your ears.

13:18 Behold now, I have set the case in order; I know that of all men, I am innocent.

13:19 Who is he that will contend with me? For presently I will be silent and die.

13:20 Just two things, O Divine One, do in my case— Then I will not be hidden from your eyes:

13:21 Remove your hand from me, And do not let terror beset me.

13:22 Then call, and I will answer, Or let me speak, then you can respond.

13:23 How many are the iniquities and the sins on my

13:26 You put libelous things about me in the newspapers, and every silly mistake I made as a kid you turn into grounds for taking away everything I have.

13:27 It's like I'm in prison, my every step monitored by your bigbrother technologies.

13:28 I'm old and frail—so why act so persistently and cruelly?

14:1 Ah, humankind! A person is born, lives a few, short years marked by discord and strife,

14:2 Then, like a flower in autumn, fades away, leaving no legacy behind.

14:3 It's absurd that you closely analyze such a life of mine, and make me the subject of your judicial proceedings.

14:4 There is no one—no one!—who is completely free from imperfection. So why are you so unreasonably exacting?

14:5 Everyone's fate is foreordained. Foreordained by whom? By you, God! You are the one who determines his course, and he cannot escape from it!

14:6 Give him a break! His life may be tedious and difficult, but at least there would be more consistency and happiness in his life if you left him alone.

14:7 A tree has resilience: Prune it, and it grows stronger.

14:8-9 Even if it seems to have died of old age, give it a little taste of water, and it will sprout and bear abundant fruit.

14:10 But humankind—humans die, and thus lose all capacity for thought and action. Their lives come to an end, and so does their life story.

14:11-12 Humankind is like an inlet which, as it gets further and further from the ocean, gets feebler and feebler, then dries up altogether. All humans die, and they do not get up again; they are off the scene until heaven passes away.

14:13 I wish that you would put me in the most secret place of all, hiding me away until your fit of rage passes by. Make this decree on behalf, and take me into consideration again!

14:14 A person dies, and he's gone. Nevertheless, I will wait like a soldier waiting for someone to relieve him at his post.

14:15 You will one day say my name, and I will say, "Here I am!" You will miss me, me whom your own hands crafted in my mother's womb.

14:16 I long for this, because right now you are hyper vigilant about my every step and misstep.

account?

Indeed, inform me concerning my sin!

13:24 Why do you hide your face,
And consider me to be among your enemies?

13:25 Will you terrify a leaf driven [by the wind],
Or pursue dry chaff?

13:26 For you write bitter things against me,
And cause the iniquities of my youth to dispossess me.

13:27 And you put my feet in stocks,
And guard all my movements,
And you set limits on the soles of my feet.

13:28 And all this with one who is like a worn-out wine skin,
Like a garment when the moth has eaten it.

14:1 A human being, born of a woman—
Short of days and satiated with turbulence,

14:2 Like a flower which sprouts and then withers;
And he flees like a shadow and does not remain standing.

14:3 Over these very things you open your eyes,
And me you bring into judgment with you.

14:4 Who can supply [an instance of] a man who is clean from [any] impurity?
There is not one!

14:5 If his days are determined,
The number of his months are with you;
His limit you have enacted,
And he will not pass over [that limit].

14:6 Turn your gaze away from him, that he might be undisturbed,
And enjoy—[even if] like a hired man—his days.

14:7 For a tree has hope:
If it is cut off, yet it can experience new growth,
And its twigs will not be disturbed.

14:8 If his root grows old in the earth,
And his rootstock dies in the soil,

14:9 At the [mere] scent of water he will sprout,
And generate a harvest like a plantation.

14:10 As for [even the strongest] man, he dies and sees powerlessness,
And a man expires, and [then] where is he [to be found]?

14:11 Waters travel from the sea,
And the rivulet dries and withers.

14:12 Likewise a man lies down and does not rise;
Until the heavens no longer exist, they will not awaken,
Nor be aroused from their sleep.

14:13 Oh that you would hide me in Sheol,

14:17 You won't let my sins go; you cling to them tightly. 14:18-19 You wear down, slowly and surely, people's hope like you wear down the mountains, like water slowly but surely erases stone. 14:20 You brandish your strength, and he stumbles off; you bellow in his face, and point him to the door. 14:21 His children have successful careers, but he's not there to see it; or else they turn out to be failures, but he has no idea. 14:22 All he knows is the pain of his own body, and the sadness of his own spirit.	Put me in a secret place until your anger passes by. Make a decree that pertains to me, and remember me. 14:14 If a man dies, can he live? All the days of my military service I wait Until my relief comes. 14:15 You will call, and I will answer. You will long for the work of your hands. 14:16 For at present you count [all] my steps; You carefully observe my sin. 14:17 My transgression is bound in a bag, And you smear glue on my iniquity. 14:18 Indeed, falling mountains crumble away, And the cliff moves from its place. 14:19 Stones are worn down by water; You flood the dust of the earth with its outpouring, And the hope of mortal man you bring to an end. 14:20 You overpower him utterly, and he goes away; You change his face, and send him off. 14:21 His sons are honored, but he is unaware; Or they become insignificant, but he does not recognize them. 14:22 Only his flesh upon him brings him pain, And his spirit mourns within him.
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Summary of 12:1-14:22

In words dripping with sarcasm (cf. G Wilson, 282), Job wonders how humanity will ever find its way when Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar have left the scene (12:2). He angrily defends his human right to exercise rationality (v3), and laments the insensitive and unjust treatment he is receiving from his so-called friends (vv4-5).

Shifting to the substance of the dispute, Job makes the claim that the godless and the arrogant enjoy good things in life (v6). He turns the tables on his friends' earlier appeals to natural theology and to the wisdom of history, maintaining that the animal and human inhabitants of the earth will, if asked, affirm the truth of *his* claims (vv7-13). His friends' appeal to God's sovereignty, too, is really a weapon that must be turned against their arguments: God, who ordains all things, not fleeting man or imponent nature, places injustice on the throne of the earth (vv14-25).

Such is Job's observation, and he cannot simply be waved away (13:1-4). His friends should instead quiet down and listen up (vv5-6). Not confident that they will do so, he charges them with engaging in fraud in order to make God's case against Job for him (vv7-8); they are no impartial witnesses! "But watch out," Job warns, "when God turns his searching gaze to you!" (vv9-12); theirs will be a rude awakening.

So then, Job repeats his call for them to listen to him (vv13, 17-19), and he has very bold things indeed to say (v14). God might kill him for his impudence (v15a), yet Job can do nothing but speak to him (v15b). God is his problem, but also his solution. Indeed, God is his very salvation (v16a); God will not hear the wicked, but he will hear him (v16b). "At v. 20 Job turns to address God, and this further reveals Job's perception that only God can give or withhold a solution to his dilemma" (L. Wilson, 85-86). Job's request can be boiled down to two things: (1) A change in his circumstances (v21), and (2) an answer as to why all this has happened (vv22-28). It is, after all, cruel to deal so harshly and so inexplicably with a human, who, because human, is a very frail creature, physically and morally (14:1-5). So Job petitions, in vivid and extended language, for relief (vv6-14a, 16a-22), adding that he will never give up seeking an answer (v14b).

But someone else hasn't given up—Eliphaz.

Paraphrase of 15:1-35

Eliphaz replied,

15:2-3 Surely a wise man like you, Job, will not supply a wrong-headed and useless response.

15:4 Just listen to yourself: The effect of your words is to construe godly living as having no benefit, and to drain a life lived in the contemplation of God of all value.

15:5 I say this because your words stem from a wicked lifestyle, and the way you are speaking betrays the fact that you have aligned yourself with the treacherous.

15:6 I don't have to charge you with guilt—your guilt is clear from your own words!

15:7 The depths of your arrogance will become clear when you consider that you are hardly the most ancient of mankind, let alone of all the earth.

15:8 God does not tell you his secrets, so you have no right to belittle the wisdom that speaks to you now.

15:9-10 You cannot reasonably presume to be wiser than us, for we are aged—older in fact than your father!

15:11 It is absurd that God's consolation, brought to you by our gentle intervention, would fail to satisfy you. How ungrateful of you!

15:12-13 It is a mystery to me how it is that you are so taken up in the heat of the moment, so filled with hot emotion, that you even speak harshly against God!

15:14 No human being is perfect.

15:15-16 Not even the angels command God's trust, or can be considered right in his eyes. They are blemished—and how much worse is the condition of mankind, whose daily sustenance is sin!

15:17 Listen closely, and I will pass on what I have learned.

15:18 This information is well-sourced, coming as it does from the wisest and most important of the men of the past.

15:19 They boast unique authority and act as safeguards for civic cohesion.

15:20 What I have learned is this: Wicked people experience only pain and anguish, and their fate is to be conquered by a bellicose autocrat.

15:21 When they think all is well, they hear terrible rumors, and then the invader overtakes their land.

15:22 Then they feel that there is no hope, that their fate is simply death.

15:23 They search in vain for food, and it is clear to them that true disaster has overtaken them.

15:24 They will quake in fear; they will come apart, like a small army blasted to pieces by a larger one.

Translation of 15:1-35

And Eliphaz the Temanite answered and said,

15:2 Will a wise man answer with vacuous knowledge, Or fill his belly with an east wind,

15:3 Reproving with a useless approach, And with words that lack benefit?

15:4 Indeed, you make [the] fear [of Yahweh] useless, And diminish meditation before the Divine One.

15:5 For your iniquity teaches your mouth, And you have chosen the tongue of the crafty.

15:6 Your mouth will condemn you, and not I, And your own lips will answer you.

15:7 Were you born as the first human being, Or were you brought forth before the hills?

15:8 Do you listen in to the secret council of God, That you make [our] wisdom small?

15:9 What do you know that we don't know, [Or] discern that isn't [already] with us?

15:10 Both white hair and old age are among us; Greater than [the years of] your father are the years [we boast].

15:11 Are the comforts of the Divine One too small for you,

Or a word spoken softly with you?

15:12 Why has your heart taken you, And why do your eyes flash?

15:13 For you turn your spirit against the Divine One, And cause words to come forth from your mouth.

15:14 What is mortal man, that he should be pure? Or that the one born of a woman should be righteous?

15:15 Behold, in his holy ones he does not trust, And the heavens are not pure in his sight.

15:16 Indeed, they are corrupted and tainted. A man drinks iniquity like water.

15:17 I will inform you—listen to me!—

And this is what I have seen and what I will recount,

15:18 Things which wise men speak, Which were not concealed from their fathers—

15:19 To them alone the land has been given, And no stranger passes through their midst—

15:20 All the days of a wicked man are a writhing in agony,

And the number of [their] years is stored up for the tyrant.

15:21 The sound of fearful things is in their ears; In [a time of] peace a destroyer comes upon him.

15:22 They do not believe that there is a return from darkness;

And they are scoped out for the sword.

15:25-26 All this comes upon wicked men because they dare to stand up to God, putting on armor like a warrior, making themselves God's enemy. 15:27 They are as fat and proud as walruses. 15:28 As a consequence, they find themselves living in ruins, their cities desolate because of the ravages of war. 15:29 Their riches, power, and land will shrink to nothing. 15:30 There will be no road back; their hope will fade, until they take their final breath. 15:31 Job, don't listen to the lies of the wicked. The end result of that line of thinking is ruin: 15:32 Like a plant blooming in the wrong season, the course of life that the wicked choose looks appealing at first, but turns out to be nothing. 15:33 Nothing that the wicked attempts to accomplish comes to fruition. 15:34 Indeed, the wicked leave no lasting legacy; their holdings, purchased through unethical means, simply burn up. 15:35 Evil deeds become pregnant with trouble, and what comes out of their womb will deceive them, for, as I said, the promises that wickedness makes are only an illusion.	15:23 He is a wanderer for bread: "Where?" He knows that firm in his hand is the day of darkness. 15:24 Trouble and trial will terrify him; It will overpower him like a king ready for battle. 15:25 For he stretches his hand against the Divine One, And he acts arrogantly against the Almighty. 15:26 He stubbornly rushes at God With the stoutness of the bosses of his shield [as his confidence]. 15:27 For he covers his face with his fat, And makes his legs [a display of] obesity. 15:28 And he dwells in destroyed cities, Houses without inhabitant, Which were made into heaps. 15:29 He will not be rich, nor will his power arise, And his possession will not extend to the land. 15:30 He will not turn from darkness; His root will dry out from the flame, And he will turn aside in the breath of his mouth. 15:31 Do not believe corrupt vanity, For vanity will be its reward. 15:32 When it is not its day it will be fulfilled, And its frond will not flourish. 15:33 His grapes will experience violence like a vine, And he will cast off his fruit like an olive tree. 15:34 For the company of the profane is barren, And a fire will consume the tents of bribery. 15:35 Mischief conceives and gives birth to trouble, And their belly establishes [only] deception.
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Summary of 15:1-35

In chapter 15, "Eliphaz begins by rebuking Job for the choices he has made and the effect his words will have (vv. 1-6). The tone is mild correction since it begins with a series of questions (vv2-3) rather than direct accusations" (L. Wilson, 91). Nevertheless, Eliphaz has real concerns: He thinks that Job's claims (that God does *not* reliably reverse the prosperity of the wicked and elevate the righteous) undermine confidence in God's justice and will lead people away from worshipful meditation on him (v4). Job's misguided words, says Eliphaz, betray his wandering heart (v5), so it is Job's own words that will condemn him (v6).

Continuing in the vein of gentle criticism, Eliphaz notes that Job is standing athwart of the collective wisdom of history (v7), acting as if he has some special revelation from God that he could not possibly have (v8). Job ought not set aside his, Bildad's, and Zophar's wisdom so quickly (vv9-10); nor should he be so angry at the means (i.e., repentance) that God has prescribed for comfort (vv11-13). After all, it is no surprise that Job has come up short—every human and angelic being does (vv14-16).

Once again, Eliphaz offers insight from his own experience (vv17-19): Great is the suffering of the wicked (vv20-24, 27-30), for great is their rebellion against God (vv25-27). So then, Eliphaz warns, beware the deceitful whispers of sin (v31b), for its end is death (vv31b-35).

But repeating an argument does not make it true. As far as Job is concerned, Eliphaz is not rich in wisdom, but bankrupt.

Paraphrase of 16:1-17:16

Job replied,

16:2 There you go again, spewing the same garbage over and over again. Your medicine is actually poison.

16:3 It seems like you will never grow tired of this nonsense. And why do you feel the need to “correct” what I say in the depths of my despair in the first place?

16:4 Well, you're not the only one who can play this game! Why don't you walk a mile in my shoes, and then I'll give you a taste of your own medicine!

16:5 Just as your attempts at comfort have been a ridiculous farce, so mine would be. I would shake my head to “console” you.

16:6 Verbalizing or staying silent, it doesn't matter—my anguish gushes forth from the depths of my heart either way.

16:7 Take a look: God has taken away my strength and brought ruin to my family.

16:8 You, O God, have made me like a prisoner—skin and bones at that—and these things malign me in court, making me seem as if I was guilty.

16:9 He ruthlessly pursues me and beats me; his mouth froths with rage against me, and his eyes flash with anger.

16:10 My three friends are eager to accuse me of wrong, slapping me and piling up on me.

16:11 God set a trap so the wicked could catch me, and aided and abetted my attacker.

16:12a-b There I was, peaceful and secure, when he turned my world upside down. I'm like a rabid animal hurled against a rock wall.

16:12c-13 He's made me target practice. His arrows fly every which way, and he doesn't relent even when my innards are falling to the ground.

16:14 I am like a city wall into which his catapults fling stone after after, reducing me to rubble. Then, like a warrior, sword flashing, he runs forward to the battle.

16:15 My grief is so great I might as well be made of sackcloth, and my humiliation is so great I'd like to crawl into a hole and die.

16:16 Weeping has left my face red, and sleeplessness has left dark lines under my eyes.

16:17 This is unfair, because I have done nothing wrong; I have a clean conscience when I pray.

16:18 I call on the earth not to absorb my blood, so that the injustice done to me will forever be clear to all; and I call on my dying shout of pain to echo

Translation of 16:1-17:16

And Job answered and said,

16:2 I have heard many things like these. You are all mischievous comforters.

16:3 Is there an end to vacuous words? Or why does it bother you to the extent that you must answer [my words of pain]?

16:4 I, like you, have something to say: If only your souls were in place of my soul!

I would unite words against you,
And I would wag my head at you.

16:5 I would “strengthen” you with my mouth,
And I would not hold back from shaking my head.

16:6 If I speak, my pain is not held back;
And if I forbear, how it goes forth from me!

16:7 Surely now he has sapped my strength;
You have devastated all my company.

16:8 You have bound me;
It becomes a witness.
My malnourishment rises up;
It answers to my face.

16:9 His anger has torn [me], and he persecutes me.
He grinds his teeth against me;
My enemy sharpens his eyes against me.

16:10 They open their mouths wide against me;
They strike my jaw with reproach;
They all gang up against me.

16:11 He has enclosed me in the hands of the oppressor,
And has shoved me into the hands of the wicked.

16:12 I was at ease, and then he plunged me into chaos,
And he grabbed me by the neck and threw me against a rock,
And set me up as a target [for his arrows].

16:13 He surrounds me with his projectiles;
He pierces my internal organs and does not show compassion;
He pours my gall on the ground.

16:14 He makes breach upon breach in me;
He runs at me like a warrior.

16:15 I have sewn sackcloth on my skin,
And I have buried my horn in the dust.

16:16 My face is red from weeping,
And deep darkness is on my eyelids.

16:17 All this despite the fact that there is no violence in my hands,
And my prayer is pure.

16:18 Let not the earth cover my blood,

without end so that all will hear it.

16:19 But even in the midst of all my suffering, hear me on this: The one who defends me, who pleads my case, is none other than God Most High.

16:20 Yes, the one who speaks for me is the one who loves me more than anyone else loves me. It brings tears to my eyes to think of God!

16:21 But how can I—a human being on the earth— and God—the Divine One in the heavens—possibly be reconciled?

16:22-17:1 I have only a few short years to live, then I will die, never again to walk the earth. My life is for all intents and purposes already over; only the grave waits to welcome me.

17:2-4 In the meantime, I have to put up with such disrespect from these “friends” of mine day and night! God, will you please write me a contract saying that I won't be held liable for having these buffoons around me? Your sovereignty has withheld the decency of wisdom from them, and because of their imprudence you will not give them public approval on the last day.

17:5 There is a sort of man who finds it impossible to speak optimistically about his future; and as for that man's children, their hope fails. Well, that man is me!

17:6 Not only is my future bleak, and not only are my children in the grave, but God's mission for me is to be the thing that the nations mock; my job is to be hated on by everyone.

17:7 I've cried so much in my anguish that I can barely see, and despair has mortally wounded my ability to reason.

17:8 Such things as I've described before—like the disasters that befall the righteous leave good people reeling in confusion, and the innocent boil in anger when they think about the undeserved prosperity of godless people.

17:9 I call on the righteous nevertheless to double down on their righteous way of life; may they become stronger and stronger!

17:10 But you three—I think your talents are best suited elsewhere. After all, none of you is wise enough to help me.

17:11 The days of my life worth living are long gone; all my hopes and dreams have turned to dust.

17:12 Yet you three think that you can turn my night into day with your counsel; you delude yourself into thinking that all this darkness can easily turn into so much light.

17:13 If I just simmer down and not whine to God

And let there be no place for my shout [to be hidden in, out of earshot].

16:19 Yet even now, behold! My witness is in heaven, And he who testifies on my behalf is in the high places.

16:20 My intermediary is my friend; My eye weeps for God.

16:21 But will one arbitrate between a man and God, And a son of Adam and his neighbor?

16:22 For years [few] of number approach, And [then] I will travel a path from which I will not return.

17:1 My spirit has been destroyed; My days are extinguished; Mine is the tomb.

17:2 Surely mockery is mine, And with their contention my eye has made its home.

17:3 Please set a pledge for me with you [O God]; Who will shake my hand?

17:4 From their minds you have hidden from prudence—

It is for that reason that you will not exalt them.

17:5 One's eternal reward might announce harsh things,

While the eyes of his children fail.

17:6 And he has made me a proverb of the peoples [of the land];

I am an object of spitting before all.

17:7 And my eye grows dim from vexation, And my thoughts are like a shadow—all of them.

17:8 The upright are astonished over this, And the innocent are exercised concerning [the prosperity of] the profane.

17:9 But let the righteous take firm hold of his way, And the pure of hands increase in strength.

17:10 But as for all of you—please return [to your homes] and go,

Since I do not find a wise man among you.

17:11 My days have passed by; My [life's] plans have pulled apart, The inheritances of my mind.

17:12 Night they turn to day; Light is near at the face of darkness.

17:13 If I wait, Sheol is my home; In the darkness I will spread my bed.

17:14 To corruption I call, “You are my father,” And, “My sister,” to the maggot.

17:15 Where, then, is my hope? And who can see my hope?

about my condition, it won't matter: My future hometown is "Death." 17:14 My family members are named "Decay," and "Decomposition." 17:15 So tell me how I'm supposed to be optimistic about my future! 17:16 Tell me how things are supposed to get better as I await my death, and the dissolution of my body!	17:16 Will it go down with me to Sheol? Or will we together go down to the dust?
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Summary of 16:1-17:16

Job sharply criticizes his friends' attempts to help him, finding it utterly unhelpful and insensitive (16:1-6). He asks them once again (cf., e.g., 6:2) to try to actually understand how terrible his situation is (16:7). This leads him to ask the same thing from God, describing at length how unfairly he feels he has been treated (vv8-16). In dramatic and emphatic words, Job declares his innocence (vv17-18).

Job's deeply-felt words certainly could leave the impression that he no longer trusts God. Aware of this, he states—in words just as dramatic and emphatic as those that affirmed his own innocence—that he believes that God loves and will (somehow) vindicate him (16:19-20).

Still, Job continues to feel (cf., 9:2ff) that the great gulf between the human and the divine precludes any realistic expectation of such a hearing (16:21). As his mood sinks once again, he contemplates (again and at length) his apparent hopelessness (16:22-17:7). He notes that he is not alone in failing to understand how God can allow so many good people to suffer and so many evil people to prosper (17:8). Invoking the righteous men and women of the earth leads him to call for them to strengthen themselves in their righteous way of life (17:9). He has by no means given up on the need for righteous living; if he has in some measure become cynical, he is not prepared to endorse sin.

But Job has given up (or nearly so; his continued responses suggest that he is exaggerating here) on his friends. He asks them to go home, since they cannot help (17:10). They think (cf., e.g., 5:17ff) that merely by repenting (which he cannot do in any case, since he is innocent), the trajectory of Job's life can be reversed (17:12). This, Job says, is nonsense; no improvements in his life await him (vv11, 13-16).

If Job is unimpressed with his friends' arguments, Bildad is unimpressed with Job's.

Paraphrase of 18:1-21 Bildad replied, 18:2 It's high time you quit your jabbering, Job! Give it up, and then we'll tell you how things really are. 18:3 It's ridiculous that you have such a low opinion of us. 18:4 You're so worked up—as if everything revolves around you! God doesn't cause kingdoms to fall and landslides to rumble because you matter to him. 18:5 No, it is for his own purposes that God puts an end to the wicked man and his influence. 18:6 The evil man's hope is snuffed out; 18:7 His ability to do evil is constrained by God, and the very advice he seeks out is the means by which his failure comes. 18:8-9 He sets out to do his dirty work unaware that he is a moment's notice from becoming hopelessly trapped, left dangling in the air by his foot; 18:10 The rope that will thus ensnare him is hidden	Translation of 18:1-21 And Bildad the Shuhite answered and said, 18:2 How long will you refuse to put an end to [your] words? Desist, and afterwards, we will speak. 18:3 Why are we considered to be an animal; [Why] are we unclean in your eyes? 18:4 He tears his soul in his anger. Is it for your sake that the land is abandoned, And the cliff moves from its place? 18:5 And the light of the wicked will be extinguished, And the spark of his fire will not shine. 18:6 The light becomes darkness in his tent, And his lamp beside him is extinguished. 18:7 The steps of his strength are bound, And his counsel causes him to fall. 18:8 For he is sent away with a net around his feet, And on a net he goes about. 18:9 A trap seizes his heel,
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along the path he will take. 18:11 Terrible things attack him from every direction, and chase him, nipping at his heels. 18:12 His power evaporates; disaster becomes firmly rooted and brings him down. 18:13 He will be so hungry that he eats his own arms as a token of his coming death. 18:14a His source of security is snatched away from his very home; 18:14b-15 Dare I name what chases him? Yes, I dare: The demon Lilith seizes him, and like a jailor with a prisoner she takes him to meet the most terrifying being of all, by taking up residence in his house, cursing all he has with fiery judgment. 18:16 As a result, his well-being will bleed away; 18:17 Soon, he will no longer be remembered, nor will any record of him remain; 18:18 He will go from riches to rags; he will be chased away from civilization like some wild beast; 18:19 He will have no children, no legacy, even in the place he once lived and worked. 18:20 Seeing this judgment, people will be horrified; barbarian hordes will pillage the city. 18:21 Without a doubt, this picture I've sketched is the fate of the wicked who show by their actions that they have no relationship with God.	And a snare takes hold of him. 18:10 His cord is buried in the earth, And his snare along the path. 18:11 Terrors beset him on every side, And scattered him at his feet. 18:12 His strength becomes famine, And calamity is established, resulting in his stumbling. 18:13 He will eat the limbs of his flesh; He will eat his limbs, the firstborn of death. 18:14 His [object of] confidence is pulled away from his tent, And "she" marches him off to the king of terrors; 18:15 She who consists in "Lilith" will dwell in his tent, Scattering sulfur over his dwelling place. 18:16 Beneath, his roots will dry out, And above, his branches will wither. 18:17 His memory will disappear from the land, And no name will be his on the face of the fields. 18:18 They will drive him from light to darkness, And they will chase him away from the inhabited world. 18:19 No posterity is his, nor descendant among his people, And no remnant in the place of his sojourning. 18:20 On his day others will be appalled, And the Kadmonites will seize the gate. 18:21 Surely these are the dwellings of the unjust, And this is the place which has not known the Divine One.
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Summary of 18:1-21

Bildad does not appreciate Job's sharp words about him and his friends (18:2-3). Clearly, Bildad says, Job is hubristic: He acts as if he is the center of the universe—or more specifically, that God's enacting of bitter justice upon the wicked is done specifically with Job's interests in mind (v4).

No, Bildad says, Job matters little to God, who in any case brings ruin upon godless men (vv5-20). The keyword in Bildad's argument here seems to be "terror": Evidently he hopes to paint so horrible a picture of the fate of the wicked that Job can do nothing but cower. Bildad is supremely confident that such is the way of God in the world (v21), implying that since Job is suffering terribly, he must be a terrible sinner; and that if Job does not repent of his sins, he will meet the fate that Bildad has outlined.

But Job will not be browbeaten. He will continue to plead his innocence. More than that, he will, with eyes of faith, see further than most before him have ever seen.

Paraphrase of 19:1-29 Job replied, 19:2-3 I'm wondering how long this has to continue. Again and again you insult me and attack me—and you don't feel bad about it, either! 19:4 I have not wandered off the straight and narrow;	Translation of 19:1-29 And Job answered and said, 19:2 How long will you grieve my soul, And crush me with words? 19:3 These ten times you have insulted me; You have not been ashamed as you attack me.
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you won't find anything incriminating on my records.

19:5 So it's ridiculous that you adopt such a holier-than-thou attitude, and assume that since my life has fallen apart I must have sinned.

19:6 Admit it: God is being unfair to me, and is treating me like he's a land-hungry tyrant.

19:7 You observe how I call out the attacks I see, but receive no reply; how I ask for help, but get no assistance.

19:8 Because of God, I'm stuck, with nowhere to go, and no idea what's going on.

19:9 He has sullied my good reputation.

19:10 He destroys everything I have, leaving me without help or hope.

19:11 He flies into a rage; he's put me on his list of most-wanted enemies.

19:12 It is as if God is an army, taking apart the roads in order to build walls, surrounding my home to starve me out.

19:13 My family isn't helping, and my friends act like they don't even know me.

19:14 Everyone I know keeps their distance and outs me out their mind.

19:15 People who stayed as guests in my house and people who worked for me think of me as a foreigner.

19:16 No amount of pleading from me has elicited any response from my former servants.

19:17 My wife thinks I am repulsive, and my siblings find me revolting.

19:18 Young people think I'm worthless, offering me slander rather than respect.

19:19 Those I used to confide in hate me, and those I've shown love to before line up to attack me.

19:20 I am emaciated, a mere shadow of my former self.

19:21 Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar, I plead with you as my friends—be kind to me, because God has brought me low.

19:22 I don't understand why you three have to join in with God's unprovoked attack on me. You see me here with ruined health, but that's not enough for you—you want to add insult to injury.

19:23-24 With that being the case, I'd like for my words of self-defense to be recorded permanently and for all to see.

19:25 Yet I hold on to my belief in God, who redeems me. I also believe that at the end of time he will appear on the earth.

19:26 Even when my body dies and rots away, I will

19:4 Have I indeed gone astray?
Does my error dwell with me?

19:5 Do you indeed exalt yourselves over me,
And use my reproach as evidence against me?

19:6 Then know that God has subverted my case,
And has arrayed his siege works against me.

19:7 Behold, I cry, "Violence!" but am not answered;
I call for help, and there is no justice.

19:8 He has walled up my path, and I cannot cross over,
And on my road he has set darkness.

19:9 He has stripped my glory from me,
And turned the crown from my head.

19:10 He tears me down all around, and I go off [like a homeless man],
And he pulls up my hope like [someone pulls up] a tree [by its roots].

19:11 And he kindles his anger against me,
And counts me as one of his enemies.

19:12 An army comes in formation against me,
And raises up their ways against me,
And encamps around my tent.

19:13 My brothers are far from me,
And my friends—surely they are strangers to me.

19:14 My acquaintances stay away from me,
And those I know have forgotten me.

19:15 The sojourners of my house and my female servants consider me a stranger;
I am a foreigner in their eyes.

19:16 I called to my servant, but he did not answer;
With my mouth I pleaded with him.

19:17 My spirit is repugnant to my wife,
And I am vile to the sons of my [mother's] womb.

19:18 Young men, too, reject me;
I arise, and they speak against me.

19:19 All the men of my private council abhor me,
And he whom I have loved has turned against me.

19:20 My bones stick to my skin and to my flesh,
And I have escaped by the skin of my teeth.

19:21 Be gracious to me, be gracious to me, you my friends!
For the hand of God has touched me.

19:22 Why do you persecute me like the Divine One [persecutes me],
Nor are satisfied [even] with my flesh?

19:23 Therefore, I wish that my words would be written;
I wish that they would be inscribed

19:24 With a pen of iron or of lead;

see God. 19:27 I will see him with my own eyes; no one will have to report to me what he is like. What a mind-blowing experience it will be! 19:28 This is my blessed hope, even though now my so-called friends shake their heads at me, thinking me to be someone who deserves to be torn down, someone whose actions merit being sued. 19:29 The Almighty's severe wrath is for those who do wicked things, so, my friends, you'd better make a U-turn!	Forever let them be cut into a cliff. 19:25 Yet I know that my redeemer lives, And on the last day he will take his stand upon the dust, 19:26 And after my skin has been struck off, this [is my future]: Without my flesh, I will see God, 19:27 Whom I myself will see, and not another, And my eyes will have seen [him], and not someone I do not know; My mind—situated in my inner person—will have met its end 19:28 Though you [now] say “How we will pursue him,” And “A root of disputation we will find in him.” 19:29 For your own sake be afraid of the sword— For the sword's anger concerns iniquities— So that you might come to know the Almighty.
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Summary of 19:1-29

Job laments his friends' continued verbal assault (19:2-3). They have no basis for attacking his character (v4), except insofar as they assume that his present distress implies earlier sin (v5). But the fact is, Job maintains, God's attack on him is not based on some earlier sin (v6a).

Yet, Job continues, if God's attack is baseless, it is also relentless 19:6b-12). The result is that Job's friends, family, former workers—anyone who might be in a position to show him sympathy—have abandoned him to his fate, closing their ears to his cries for help (vv13-19). Job is left barely clinging to life (v20), and can only plaintively ask for his friends to be kind to him, since God is not (v21).

But Job's friends will not help (19:22). Consequently, Job can only look to the far future. He wishes that an unerasable message could be made, preserving the evidence of his innocence for all time (vv23-24). Yet when Job thinks of the far future, he thinks of God—of his meeting with him, and of God's eventual coming to the earth. In this frame of mind, Job makes one of his greatest statements of faith: In the midst of his suffering, God remains his redeemer; and even his death will not prevent him from the blessed vision of God (vv26-27).

His spirit thus bolstered, Job soberly warns his friends that their unwarranted attacks on him (19:28) can be expected to elicit God's judgment in response (v29). They are the ones who need to repent.

But Zophar, at least, is not yet ready to repent.

Paraphrase of 20:1-29 Zophar replied, 20:2 With you talking like this, I can't help but react—so much is going through my mind right now! 20:3 Job, what I hear from your rebuke is insulting. I haven't learned a thing from your oh-so-heart-felt replies. 20:4 These ideas of yours boast no great pedigree. 20:5 On the contrary, wicked men are happy for only a short time. 20:6 They might think they can swagger right up to the gates of heaven, but they are deluded: 20:7 Like their poop, they will soon be gone forever.	Translation of 20:1-29 And Zophar the Naamathite answered and said, 20:2 For this reason my thoughts turn me back, And, accordingly, haste is in me. 20:3 I hear chastening that insults me, And a spirit that is separate from my discernment answers me. 20:4 Have you known this from all eternity, From when humankind was placed upon the earth? 20:5 For the cry of the wicked is quite recent, And the happiness of the profane is momentary. 20:6 Will his pride go up to heaven, And will his head reach the clouds?
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Those who inquire about their fate will remain in the dark.

20:8 Like a dream, they will quickly vanish from memory.

20:9 Take a good look at the wicked man, because soon you'll never see him again.

20:10-11 Even his children will be so impoverished they will beg the beggars for scraps. His hands will no longer be rugged; his bones will no longer be strong; he will be a skeleton in the dust.

20:12-13 If a man decides that wickedness is pleasurable, and considers it a friend, not an enemy, then this is what will happen:

20:14 The food he eats will not nourish him; it will be like snake poison in his veins;

20:15 The wealth he has gathered will be like a bad meal—God will make him puke his guts out;

20:16 He will imbibe snake poison and die.

20:17 He should not let himself be tempted by the promise of endless prosperity and luxury,

20:18 For his vast income does not truly satisfy him or bring him happiness.

20:19 This is because he has not given help to the poor; instead, he has robbed the less fortunate.

20:20 There is no inner tranquility for him. His insatiable greed has created a trap for him from which there is no escape.

20:21 No one will be there to enjoy his gourmet food after he's gone—no lasting dynasty for him!

20:22 He is going along, so very rich—suddenly, every type of trouble comes at him from every side.

20:23 Yes, he's made himself obese at the expense of others, but God will give full vent to his terrifying anger.

20:24 This man's attempt to flee one means of death will only push him into the arms of another means of destruction.

20:25 God will unsheathe his glinting sword, and pierce the wicked man straight through; such horrors are the fate of a guy like this.

20:26 The blackness of death will forever savor the soul of such a man in its choking embrace, and unquenchable fire will consume him. Even those who survive him in his home will not be safe!

20:27 All creation will expose his sins, and hold him accountable.

20:28 God's anger will utterly sweep away all that is his.

20:29 This is what you can expect from God's hand if

20:7 Like his refuse, he will disappear forever; Those who see him will [soon] say, "Where is he?"

20:8 Like a dream he will fly away, and no one will find him,

And he will flee like a vision of the night.

20:9 The eye will see him, but not again, And will not again behold his place.

20:10 His children will seek the favor of the poor, And his hands will return his strength.

20:11 His bones had been full of youthful vitality, But with him in the dust they will lie.

20:12 If evil has become sweet in his mouth, [If] he has hidden it under his tongue,

20:13 [And if] he has spared it and not abandoned it, Or rejected in the midst of his mouth,

20:14 His bread in his belly will turn over, [And] the gall of asps will be within him.

20:15 He swallowed wealth, then vomited it up; From his belly the Divine One drove it out.

20:16 He will suck the venom of asps; The tongue of the viper will kill him.

20:17 Let him not gaze upon streams of milk fat, [Or] upon torrents of honey and curds.

20:18 He turns back his produce, but does not swallow [it];

He does not rejoice according to [the measure of] the wealth of his income.

20:19 For he has crushed the dwelling of the poor; He has plundered, not built, the house.

20:20 For he does not know quietness in his belly; In his desire, he will not escape.

20:21 There is no survivor for his food; Therefore, his goods will not endure.

20:22 In the fullness of his abundance, he found himself in trouble;

Every means of anxiety comes against him.

20:23 Behold, he certainly filled his belly;

He [who is in heaven] will send upon him the heat of his anger,

And rain upon him [disasters leading to] panic:

20:24 He will flee from the iron weapon;

The double-convex bow will pierce him.

20:25 He draws out [his sword], and it comes out of his back,

And the flash [of the blade] from his gall;

Terrors come upon him.

20:26 All darkness is hidden for those whom it treasures up;

A fire not blown will consume him;

you behave wickedly, if you think that you can live without his approval.	His survivor in his tent will be shattered. 20:27 The heavens will uncover his iniquity, And the earth will rise against him. 20:28 A flood will roll away his house, Poured out in the day of his anger [who reigns above]. 20:29 This is the reward from God for the evil human, And the inheritance of him whose thought is separate from the Divine One.
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Summary of 20:1-29

Zophar takes umbrage at Job's rebuke (e.g., 19:2-5) of him (20:1-3). Job's arguments, Zophar says, have not learned the lesson of history; it is new-fangled foolishness (v4).

Similarly short-sighted and foolish are the wicked themselves (v5), who, so far from attaining the fame and power they envisage for themselves (v6), will find a sudden and ignominious end (v7). Their end will be permanent (vv8-9, 11), even affecting the fate of his children (v10). The fate of wicked, if terrible (vv14-16), are well-deserved (vv11-13, 18-23). Zophar seems to relish the gory details of the imagined fate of the wicked (vv24-28); it is hard to escape the idea that a certain macabre smile sits on his lips as he narrates these things (cf. Andersen, 197). He ends with a thinly veiled threat (v29): Job, he implies, risks being among those who, through their intransigence, will inherit all these things.

"The [last] verse not only concludes the chapter but is also the conclusion of Zophar's argument and the last he will speak in the Book of Job. We will not miss him" (Alden, 218). Even so, Job's troubles are not over.

Paraphrase of 21:1-34 Job replied, 21:2-3 Hear me out, and, as I talk, comfort yourselves with the fact that when I finish speaking, it will be your turn to speak. Then you can deride me all you want. 21:4 But really, it is not to any human that I speak—it is to God. If it was a mere matter of a dispute between people, I wouldn't be so discouraged. 21:5 Take a good look at me, and let the horror of it all sink it, and be silent. 21:6 When it comes to my mind, my spirits sink—so much so that I literally tremble all over. 21:7 I don't understand why wicked people have such good lives; so far from facing death for their crimes, they only see their income grow larger and larger. 21:8 They get to see their children and grandchildren get established and do well for themselves. 21:9 They face no calamity, nor any discipline from God. 21:10 Their business flourish without a single setback. 21:11-12 They get to experience happy times with their family; it's all laughter and happiness for them. 21:13 Only when they've lived a long, full life do they pass away, tranquil and satisfied. 21:14 Meanwhile, they push God out their lives, sneering at his commands.	Translation of 21:1-34 And Job answered and said, 21:2 Listen carefully to my words, And let may this be your consolation: 21:3 Bear with me while I say my bit, And after I speak, you may mock. 21:4 As for me, is my complaint to a human? Or why do I lose heart? 21:5 Turn your faces to me, and be appalled, And place your hand on your mouth. 21:6 And if I remember, I am dismayed, And my flesh is seized with shuddering. 21:7 Why do the wicked live; They go onward, and even increase in strength. 21:8 Their seed is established before them, And their descendants before their eyes. 21:9 Their houses are at peace, with no fear, And the rod of God is not upon them. 21:10 His bull impregnates without failure; His cow delivers without miscarriage. 21:11 He sends forth like a flock his young children, And his children dance around. 21:12 They take up the timbrel and the lyre, And they rejoice at the sound of the reed-pipe. 21:13 They wear out in good their days, And in quietness they go down to Sheol. 21:14 And they say to the Divine One, "Depart from
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21:15 They mock him, and do not link him in their minds with any good thing.

21:16 Incidentally, the wicked should realize that the blessings in their lives are not under their own control—they come from the gracious hand of God. I want nothing to do with these men and their vile ingratitude and arrogance!

21:17-19 Anyway, it is all too rare that God's righteous anger brings the wicked to an end, blowing them away like straw in the wind, exposing their evil deeds, and handing over their wealth to their children.

21:20 You think that God inevitably and everywhere judges the proud, but the truth is it would take an act of Congress to find him pouring out his judgment on the disobedient.

21:21 On the other hand, it is not as though he can enjoy in satisfaction the welfare of his family, when he, like all humanity, faces the grave.

21:22 It's not really possible to say that the wicked man learns anything, despite your claims that God brings judgment on such men.

21:23-26 For there is one kind of man who dies peacefully after a long, full life (and with a very full belly!), and there is another kind of man who dies in bitter disappointment, after a life that was just one hardship after another. Yet both will die and their bodies rot!

21:27 I am fully aware of how you plan to verbally abuse me.

21:28-30 This is what you'll say: "Job, the wicked and their estates fall to pieces, as anyone who's been around the block a time or two can tell you. The inescapable fate of the wicked is destruction. So the disasters that you face are well deserved!"

21:31 God acts, and no one can challenge him.

21:32-33 And when the evil man comes to die, even Mother Earth welcomes them with open arms. But in fact, death is the fate of all mankind; it makes no distinction between the righteous and the wicked.

21:34 Your attempts at consolation are so pointless! You have betrayed the trust of our relationship.

us,

"For in the knowledge of your ways we do not delight.

21:15 "What is the Almighty, that we should serve him?

"Or how shall we benefit if we seek his favor?"

21:16 (Behold, their good is not in their hands. Let the counsel of the wicked be far from me!)

21:17 How rarely is the lamp of the wicked extinguished,

And [how rarely] does their calamity come upon them, [And how rarely] does he in his anger apportion destruction for them!

21:18 [How rarely] are they like straw before the wind,

And like chaff which the storm steals [it] away!

21:19 [How rarely] does God hide away from his children his strength,

Recompensing him [for his wickedness] and making him known [as a criminal]!

21:20 [How rarely] do their eyes see his calamity, And [how rarely] does he drink from the anger of the Almighty—

21:21 Though what is his delight in his household after him?

For the number of his months is cut off!

21:22 [Indeed,] is he taught by God?

For [your claim is that] he judges the proud.

21:23 This man will die in a state of having his life all put together,

Wholly at ease and at peace.

21:24 His thighs are full of fat,

And the marrow of his bones is well-watered.

21:25 And this man will die with a bitter spirit, And will not have tasted good.

21:26 Together they will lie on the dust, And the maggot will conceal both of them.

21:27 Behold, I know your plans, And your schemes to do evil against me.

21:28 For you say, "Where is the house of the noble, "And where is the tent in which the wicked dwell?"

21:29 "Have you never asked those who travel on the way,

"Or do you not recognize their signs?

21:30 "For the evil man is reserved for the day of calamity;

"To the day of wrath he is borne along."

21:31 Who will call out his way to his face; For he has acted; who will recompense him?

21:32 For he is being borne along to the grave,

	And it is over a tomb that he keeps careful watch. 21:33 Dirt clumps from a wadi are sweet to him; And after him all mankind is being drawn, And after him there is no number. 21:34 And how you comfort me with vanity! And as for your answers—treachery is what remains.
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Summary of 21:1-34

Job opens with a tone of sarcasm, or resignation: While he does not anticipate a positive reaction from his friends, he feels compelled to press his case (21:1-4). He does, however, wish his friends would take to heart the gravity of his situation (vv5-6).

“Were human agency the cause of Job’ suffering he would have no complaint. Humans are weak and unable to control their own circumstances, let alone those of another... But the fact is, Job claims rhetorically [vv7-15], God is in control in this world, just as the friends have claimed. God is powerful and in control, *and yet* the wicked pursue their evil with impunity and all this great evil has come upon one who is acknowledged by all to be ‘blameless and upright’ (1:1)” (G. Wilson, 223-224). Job is not for a moment *condoning* the lifestyle of the wicked (21:16). But he is perplexed (vv17-22) at God’s dealing with the wicked, for frequently “God’s judgment fails to materialize” (G. Wilson, 230); indeed, at death there seems to be no difference between the wicked and the righteous (vv23-26).

Perhaps sensing an eagerness on the part of his friends to reply, Job hastens to make it known that he can recite their arguments for them: Ancient wisdom, they will say, teaches that the wicked find wrath (vv27-30). Job preemptively contradicts their line of reasoning. It is instead the case, he says, that no one thwarts the wicked (v31), and evil men seem to have a nice, cozy life laid out for them all the way to a peaceful death in the welcoming arms of the earth (vv32-33a). And, once again, death is the experience of *all* mankind (v33b-c). This, Job says, is their “comfort”; their attempts to help him have been worse than worthless (v34).

But Eliphaz is not prepared to accept this characterization of his argument.

Paraphrase of 22:1-30 Eliphaz replied, 22:2 Neither the might nor the wisdom of mortal man renders any assistance to God. 22:3 Even the “integrity” in which you take such pride is no help to God. God is self-sufficient, and you make no difference to his plans. 22:4-5 People don't bring a person to court for what is right. No, we're bringing charges against you because of your great guilt. 22:6 You're a crook, gaming the courts to steal from the impoverished. 22:7 You have no shame at all, greedily consuming resources desperately needed by others. 22:8 Under your watch, might makes right, and bribes are what makes your corner of the world go around. 22:9 You can't be bothered to give a penny to widows, and when widows hold out their hands for food, you break their arms. 22:10-11 That's the reason all of life is against you, and terrible things are happening to you all the time, leaving you overwhelmed and unable to process it.	Translation of 22:1-30 And Eliphaz the Temanite answered and said, 22:2 Is a strong man of use of God, Or is a wise man of use to him? 22:3 Is it a delight to the Almighty that you are righteous? Or is it of benefit to him that you conduct your ways with integrity? 22:4 Will one reprove you on account of your fear [of God], Come against you in judgment? 22:5 Is not your evil great? And there is no end to your iniquities. 22:6 For you take in pledge from your brothers for no cause, And the clothes of the naked you strip off. 22:7 The very water of the poor you drink, And from the hungry you withhold food. 22:8 And the man of strength—his is the land; And partiality dwells within it. 22:9 Widows you have sent away empty-handed, And the arms of the orphans you have broken.
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22:12 Beyond dispute, God is high up in heaven; even the stars are like ants to him.

22:13-14 So how can you have the gall to claim that God doesn't understand your situation, that he is too remote to sympathize with you?

22:15-18 Perhaps you haven't sufficiently considered the lessons that history teaches the wicked: People who reject God's ways, and who think that they can escape God's judgment, meet an untimely death, swept away like a house whose foundation cannot withstand the floodwaters surging against it—all this, when it was none other than the God they mocked who had given them everything in their lives that was good! I pray that I will never be like those people!

22:19 The righteous take note of this fate of the wicked, and are happy; they rightly make fun of them.

22:20 All that wealth that the wicked used to take such pride in—where is it now?

22:21 Acquaint yourself closely with God, and use some of your wealth to make a covenant of peace with God. Then God in turn will bless your property with good income.

22:22 I'm begging you, listen to God's correction, and take it to heart.

22:23-24 If you do reject evil in your household and in your business empire, forsaking the treasure on which you have relied, God will restore you to prosperity,

22:25 And he will be better to you than all the money you have left behind.

22:26 You'll find happiness in fellowship with him, and he will rejoice over you.

22:27 You'll pray, and he'll hear you; you'll keep your vows.

22:28 You'll give out orders to your workers, and your instructions will be heeded.

22:29-30 Whenever the wicked are brought low, you will cluck your tongue and say, "It was their foolish pride that brought this disaster on them!" God, after all, saves those who are humble, and destroys those who are haughty; he saves the pure on account of their purity, and brings ruin on the impure.

22:10 Therefore traps are all around you, And sudden terror bewilders you.

22:11 Or darkness [such that] you cannot see, And an abundance of waters covers you.

22:12 Is not God in the height of heaven, Looking upon the top of the stars, though they are exalted?

22:13 Yet you say, "How can the Divine One know? "Will he judge from behind thick, dark clouds?"

22:14 "The clouds are a hiding place for him, and he does not see,

"And over the arc of the heavens he walks here and there."

22:15 Have you carefully considered the ancient path Which wicked men have trod

22:16 Who have been seized before the[ir] time? A river has been poured out against their foundation:

22:17 Those who say to the Divine One, "Depart from us,"

And, "What will the Almighty do to us?"

22:18 Yet it is he who has filled their houses with good.

Oh, let the counsel of the wicked be far from me!

22:19 The righteous will see and rejoice, And the pure will mock them:

22:20 Surely their property has been brought to nothing,

And fire has consumed their abundance.

22:21 Please come to know him,

And make a peace offering by means of them; Your income will be good.

22:22 Please receive from his mouth instruction, And place his words in your heart.

22:23 If you will return to the Almighty, you will be built up—

If you will push iniquity far from your tents,

22:24 And place gold in the dust,

And fine gold in the cliffs of the wadis.

22:25 Then the Almighty will be your [source of] gold,

And silver will be [like] mountains for you.

22:26 For then in the Almighty you will delight, And God will smile upon you.

22:27 You will pray to him and he will hear you, And your vows you will fulfill.

22:28 And you will make a decree, and it will be fulfilled for you,

And on your ways light will shine.

22:29 When they are humbled, you will say, "Pride!"

	While the lowly of eyes he saves. 22:30 [Yes,] he saves the innocent, And he is saved by the purity of his hands.
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Summary of 22:1-30

Eliphaz begins by putting Job in his place: Job's complaints about God are based on an assumption that he (Job) has something to offer God, but that assumption is faulty (22:2). Just as faulty, continues Eliphaz, is Job's insistence that he is a man of integrity (v3); no, Job is manifestly guilty of great sin (vv4-9), and for that reason suffers unbearably (vv10-11). Job's insistence that God is distant from his situation is contradicted by God's transcendence (vv12-14): If God is vaster than all of the cosmos, surely he is fully appraised of Job's life!

Yet for all his criticism of Job, Eliphaz remains hopeful. Perhaps Job has simply forgotten his history: Looking more closely at the story of humankind, Eliphaz reminds Job, would amply illustrate the fate of the wicked (vv15-20). And hope remains for Job, for God is abundantly merciful to the penitent; indeed, Job's present calamity and alienation from God can, with repentance, be transformed into prosperity and fellowship with God (vv21-28). Then Job (rather like Eliphaz now) will be in a possession to look on other wicked people when their own day of trouble comes and rehearse to himself that God is just, saving the pure and humbling the prideful (vv29-30).

But if Eliphaz is trying to be helpful, Job will not find him to be so.

Paraphrase of 23:1-24:25 Job replied, 23:2 I'm still not giving up. My outrage is for real, and I'm going to get answers. 23:3 I wish that I knew how to get to where God lives— 23:4 Then I would make my case to his face; I'd be the most persuasive attorney in history. 23:5 I'd anticipate his responses, and see right through his counterarguments. 23:6 His omnipotence is no deterrent to this plaintiff—I'll see to it that he hears me out! 23:7 In God's court, the righteous make their case. I, being one of their number, will be vindicated, and there is no double jeopardy in heaven. 23:8 Ah, but listen to this: No matter where I look, no matter which way I turn, I cannot find God 23:9 He is at work here, and on the move there, but I cannot catch a glimpse of him. 23:10 Yet God is fully aware of my deeds, and my righteousness will be fully vindicated. 23:11 Like a child mimicking his father, I've done everything I see God doing. 23:12 I've paid close attention to his commands and obeyed them; I've treasured his word in my heart. 23:13 God is utterly sovereign; no desire of his can be thwarted. 23:14 In my case, too, God has accomplished what he has decreed. This is the way he always interacts with the world.	Translation of 23:1-24:25 And Job answered and said, 23:2 Even today my complaint is obstinate, And my hand is heavy on account of my sighing. 23:3 Oh, that I might know how to find him; I would go up to the place where he dwells. 23:4 I would arrange the legal case before him, And I would fill my mouth with arguments. 23:5 I would know with what words he would answer me, And I would discern what he would say to me. 23:6 In the greatness of his strength would he contend with me? No, he surely would pay attention to me! 23:7 There the upright argue their cases with him, And I will forever be delivered from my judge. 23:8 Behold, I go forward, and he is not [there], And backward, and I do not discern him. 23:9 At the left, while he is working I do not take hold [of him]; He passes by on the right, and I do not see [him]. 23:10 But he knows the way that is with me; He has tested me; I will come out like gold. 23:11 My foot has seized hold of his footstep, And his way I have watched closely, and not halfheartedly; 23:12 The words of his mouth [I have guarded], and not allowed [them] to depart; I have hidden his words in my inner person. 23:13 For he has chosen, and who can turn him back?
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23:15 With a God like this, I am at a loss. When I try to process what God is doing, the emotion that I feel is fear.

23:16 I'm not kidding when I say "fear." God has terrified me and taken away all my hope.

23:17 After all, I am lost in a fog; I can't see my way through this time of terror.

24:1 I don't understand why God feels it necessary to be so mysterious in his ways, leaving his "friends" with no idea what he's doing.

24:2 After all, the wicked constantly get away with things: They violate property lines established in days gone by, and they steal a flock and pasture it as their own.

24:3 They steal the property of the vulnerable, using legal loopholes to deprive them of anything valuable.

24:4 They deceive the poor, leaving them without any sense of direction; the lower classes huddle together, out of sight of the predatory rich.

24:5 The disadvantaged, together with their children, are forced to scour desolate landscapes for drops of water to drink.

24:6 They are given the worst jobs, and that for wretchedly low wages.

24:7 They are left without clothes, shivering in the cold.

24:8 They are forced to drink from creeks, and live in caves.

24:9 The wicked snatch away nursing infants, making children slaves because of parental debts.

24:10 The poor must go without proper attire, and, despite their hunger, must do the hardest of jobs.

24:11 They do the manual labor of producing oil and wine, yet are not allowed to taste a drop.

24:12 Meanwhile, people, injured and unjustly treated, can only shout out. Despite all this, God does not hold anyone accountable.

24:13 These people who cause all this suffering stand in the long line of those who reject God's truth; they neither notice nor stick to the ways of the Lord.

24:14 By morning, the wicked get busy murdering the poor and needy; by night, they join the thieves' guild.

24:15 Not only that, but they eagerly anticipate nightfall so that they can go unnoticed as they cheat on their wives.

24:16 They stay put at home during daylight, escaping the exposure of their evil deeds that daylight would bring; they do not even know what sunshine looks like.

And his soul has desired [something], and accomplished [it].

23:14 For he has brought to completion the decree that concerns me,

And there are many things like this with him.

23:15 For that reason I am bewildered before him; I consider, and am afraid of him.

23:16 Indeed, the Divine One has made my heart timid,

And the Almighty has brought me dismay.

23:17 For surely I am annihilated by darkness, And deep darkness covers my face.

24:1 Why are times deeply hidden by God, And [why] do his friends not see his days?

24:2 They move boundaries; A flock they snatch away and pasture.

24:3 The orphans' donkey they lead away; They take by pledge the widow's bull.

24:4 They lead the needy away from the road; The poor of the land feel the need to hide themselves together.

24:5 Behold, wild donkeys go out in the wilderness about their work, searching for dew; The desert is for him bread for the children.

24:6 In the field they harvest his fodder; They rake the vineyards of the wicked.

24:7 The naked spends the night without clothing, And there is no covering in the cold.

24:8 From the mountain runoff they get their moisture, And, lacking shelter, they embrace the rock.

24:9 They tear away the fatherless from the breast, And they take in pledge the child of the poor.

24:10 They go around naked, without clothes, And, hungry, they bear sheaves of grain.

24:11 Between the terrace walls they press oil; They thread the wine vats, and are thirsty.

24:12 Outside the city, men cry out, And the soul of the wounded cries out;

Yet God does not assign guilt.

24:13 [As for the wicked,] they are among those who rebel against the light;

They do not recognize his ways, And do not dwell in his paths.

24:14 At [morning] light the murderer arises, killing the poor and the needy;

And at night he is like the thief.

24:15 And the eye of the adulterer watches for twilight, Saying, "No eye will see me,"

24:17 As far as they are concerned, daytime is as frightening as night is to most people. 24:18 Now, it is true that these wicked men will quickly find themselves in the domain of the damned. They live their lives among the citizenry under a curse; next season's crop is not for them to enjoy. 24:19 Unquenchable fire is prepared for them—nothing will cool them down in the afterlife. 24:20 They might as well not have been born, because death is their fate. They will not be remembered after their passing, and their reign of terror will come to an end. But what comfort is this fact to those whose suffering continues unrelentingly? 24:21 The wicked persecute the childless, and withhold aid from the widow. 24:22 Possessing great power, they entrap even warriors; when they move themselves to action, the bravest despair of life. 24:23 God gives the wicked safety, and guides their every step. 24:24 For a brief moment, the wicked rise to prominence, then pass from the scene, humiliated. Theirs is the fate of everyone: Defeat in death. They are as temporary as a stalk of wheat. 24:25 Is what I've described is an inaccurate picture of reality? I challenge someone to prove me wrong—this no one can do!	And makes a covering for his face. 24:16 He digs into houses in the darkness; By day they seal themselves in— They do not know the [day-]light. 24:17 For altogether morning is to them deep darkness, For he recognizes [only] the terrors of deep darkness. 24:18 (Swift is he on the face of the water; Their portion is cursed in the land; He does not face the way of the vineyards. 24:19 Drought, and also heat, tears away; The waters of snow bypass Sheol. 24:20 The womb forgets him; A maggot nibbles at him; He will not again be remembered, And injustice is broken like a tree.) 24:21 He does evil to the barren woman who has borne no child, And for the widow he does not do good. 24:22 And he draws out mighty men in his strength; He arises, and they do not believe in life. 24:23 He gives him security, and he is safe, And his eye is on their paths. 24:24 They are exalted for a short time, then he is no more, And they are brought low; like everyone, they shrink back [into death], And like the head of an ear of grain, they shrivel. 24:25 And if it is not so, then who will show me to be a liar, And make my words to be nothing?
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Summary of 23:1-24:25

Job remains as committed as ever to speak to the injustice of his situation (23:2). Accordingly, he longs to know how he might find God (v3), in order that he might make a convincing argument against God allowing these circumstances to have come about (vv4-7). Yet he cannot find God (vv8-9), and, though God knows that Job is innocent (vv10-12), Job feels that he can expect no reversal of things from God, who acts irrevocably (vv13-14). This impasse leads Job at a loss (vv15-16). His life is in ruins (v17), and he has no idea why (24:1).

Meanwhile, the wicked engage in their evil ways with no one to stop them; Job meditates morosely on this fact at length (vv2-18, 21-23). That the wicked will themselves close their eyes in death provides Job no comfort (vv19-20, v24). Job challenges his friends to show him to be wrong, confident that they cannot (v25).

Job, then, remains thoroughly unsatisfied. With apparently flagging energy, Bildad will attempt one more time to meet Job's challenge.

Paraphrase of 25:1-6 Bildad replied, 25:2 Who do you think you're talking about, Job? God puts kings on thrones, stirs fear in the hearts of all who encounter him, and brings all opposition to heel.	Translation of 25:1-6 And Bildad the Shuhite answered and said, 25:2 [It is God] who causes to rule, and fear is with him, And who makes peace in his high places.
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25:3 You can't count his vast armies, and you can never outsmart his strategies! 25:4 It's utterly impossible for a human being to be in the right before God. 25:5-6 God is dissatisfied with the shining of the moon and of the stars, so what does he think of people? A wriggling maggot feasting on a garbage heap, that's what!	25:3 Is there a number to his armies? And against whom will his ambushade not arise? 25:4 And how can a mortal man be righteous with the Divine One, Or how can he be pure who has been born of a woman? 25:5 Behold, the moon still does not shine, And the stars are no longer pure in his sight. 25:6 How much more is mortal man a maggot, And the son of Adam a worm!
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Summary of 25:1-6

Job's friends are running out of arguments: Bildad here manages just a few lines, and Zophar will not even attempt a third riposte. What is tried is this: God's measureless power rebuffs any assault (25:2-3), so Job's questioning of God is futile; and humankind is tainted in the first instance (vv4-6), making Job's positive self-assessment misguided.

Paraphrase of 26:1-14 Job replied, 26:2 You're a lousy excuse for an advocate, Bildad! You're no help at all. 26:3 Your wisdom is useless, and no one appreciates your advice. 26:4 Nobody here has learned anything from your speech! Nobody is frightened, either. 26:5-6 The dead, in the heart of the earth beneath the fish-laden ocean waves, cannot escape the piercing gaze of God's eyes. Death itself cannot hide anything from him. 26:7 God rolls out the starry curtain of the heavens, needing nothing to hang it on, nor anything on which to place the earth. 26:8 He fills clouds with water, yet knows the breaking-point of each cloud. 26:9 He shrouds his throne from human view with his cloud. 26:10 He decrees where water and earth meet, and where darkness gives way to light. 26:11 When he is angry, the heavens shake like a building in an earthquake. 26:12a When he flexes his muscles, the sea roils as in a hurricane. 26:12b-13 In his cunning, he brings defeat to the greatest of the universe's monsters; Satan, though trying to wriggle away like a snake, is mortally wounded by him. 26:14 Consider this: What I have described is no more than the first road sign pointing the way to him; we humans have received only the faintest hints about his	Translation of 26:1-14 And Job answered and said, 26:2 How you have helped him who has no strength! You have saved the arm with no help! 26:3 How you have counseled him who has no wisdom! And prudence to many you have made known! 26:4 Whom have you spoken to with words? And whose spirit has gone out on your account? 26:5 The ghosts writhe Under the waters and [under] what dwells in them. 26:6 Sheol is naked before him, And there is no covering for Abaddon. 26:7 [It is God] who stretches out the north over formlessness, Hanging the earth on nothingness, 26:8 Binding up the waters in his clouds, And the cloud is not broken under them, 26:9 Overlaying the surface of the throne, Spreading upon it his cloud. 26:10 A decree he has drawn around the surface of the water Up to the end of light with darkness. 26:11 The pillars of heaven shake And are put in awe at his rebuke. 26:12 At his strength the sea churns, And in his discernment he has smitten Rahab. 26:13 The bars of heaven are torn down; His hand pierces the fleeing serpent. 26:14 Behold, these are the extremities of his ways, And what a whisper of the matter we have heard concerning him;
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nature. Imagine what would happen if we were exposed to the full extent of his power?	But the thunder of his might, who can discern?
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Summary of 26:1-14

“As has increasingly been the case in Job's responses, he begins here with words dripping with sarcasm” (G. Wilson, 282) (26:2-3); his “friends” have not acted like friends. Bildad's words in particular have been uninformative and unimpressive (v4).

The following verse paints a mural of God's greatness in hues that inspire and frighten. Bildad has just (25:1-6) spoken (in harsh and unfeeling terms, to be sure) of God's greatness. “Perhaps this section [viz. 26:5-14] is... Job saying that he believes this too, yet it does not solve his dilemma. Job retains a big view of God running his world. All that he laments is that he cannot see how the treatment he has received can be part of God's just plan. This leaves the friends nowhere to stand, and hence they have become silent [cf. 32:1]” (L. Wilson, 128).

Job himself, however, is not yet ready to be silent.

Paraphrase of 27:1-28:28 Job continued to make his case: 27:2-4 I am still very much alive, so I swear by God (I know him now as the one who has ruined my life for no good reason, yet continues to give me life and breath) that I will never speak falsely. 27:5 No way will I ever say that you three are right about me—until my dying day I will be protesting that I am a man of integrity! 27:6 My track record of righteousness is a treasured possession that I will not surrender. Go ahead and dig through my past—I have nothing to be embarrassed about. 27:7-10 Whoever insists to me that I am suffering because I have led a wicked life—I hope they experience the fate of the wicked, of the person who has failed to treasure God or to call upon his name. That fate is to lose all hope when God calls that person's soul to account, when God refuses to listen to that man's pleas for mercy on the day when everything comes crashing down around him. 27:11 Listen up, students; I will teach you fully and accurately about God and his power and unstoppable authority. 27:12 (Guys, you've been around; you know what actually happens in life! So what gives with all this nonsense you're trying to push on me?) 27:13-17 This is what comes from above to the man who flaunts God's laws, to the man who oppresses those with less power and privilege than himself: His children will be murdered, or else go hungry in the streets; after his death, his descendants can expect only their own death, while his widows do not bother to cry at his passing; his money and his fashionable clothes will go to the righteous, not to his children.	Translation of 27:1-28:28 And Job continued his declamation, and said, 27:2 As the Divine One who has diverted the justice due to me lives, And [as] the Almighty [lives] who has embittered my soul— 27:3 For all my breath is still in me, And the spirit of God is in my nose— 27:4 My lips do not speak unrighteousness, Nor does my tongue utter treachery. 27:5 Far be it from me to declare that you [men] are in the right; Until death, I will not put my integrity away from me. 27:6 I have taken firm hold of my righteousness, and will not let it go; My heart will not be reproached from my days. 27:7 May my enemy be like a wicked man, And may my attacker be like the unjust. 27:8 For what hope is there for the profane when he is cut off, When God draws out his soul? 27:9 Will the Divine One listen to his cry When trouble comes upon him? 27:10 Has he delighted himself in the Almighty, Calling upon God at all times? 27:11 I will teach you concerning the hand of the Divine One; That which is with the Almighty I will not conceal. 27:12 (Behold, you yourselves have all seen [how life works], And why ever have you conceived a vain thing?) 27:13 This is the portion of a human who is wicked before the Divine One, And the inheritance of oppressors that they receive from God.
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27:18 His “mansion” is really something a bug might have created; he hires a security firm to guard what might as well be a bramble patch.

27:19 The wicked will soon perish forever, and live no longer on the earth.

27:20 Terrible things will crash against him like a flood, and [the hopelessness of] night[time] will blow him away like a hurricane.

27:21-23 A brutal, hot wind will whip him away, and blow him along—mercilessly hurling him far from security, throwing him through the air like a ball. It will slap him, and stand there, mocking him.

28:1 There is a mine for silver, and a refinery for gold; but where is wisdom to be found, and how can one acquire discernment?

28:2 And it is not as though mining precious metals is a small achievement: Humans find ways to dig through the earth in search of iron, and through the stone in search of copper.

28:3 Miners dispel the blackness of the realm under the earth with torches, exploring every tunnel to its end.

28:4 They work their way through limestone, reaching places long forgotten. When a deep shaft confronts them, they hang ropes and lower themselves down—and they do this far from the comforts of civilization.

28:5 Above—peaceful farmlands. Below—miners turn over the dirt, spadeful by spadeful.

28:6 Amid worthless soil and stones, the miners seek out sapphires and gold.

28:7-8 Miners do this in places not even the birds are familiar with, nor do the lions include it in their kingdoms.

28:9 The miners reach with their hands, and undermine the foundations on which the very mountains are built.

28:10-11 They redirect the flow of water underground, thereby discovering everything of value. The labor involved in extracting the treasures of the earth is indeed great.

28:12 But still more difficult is the task of locating wisdom.

28:13 Humanity cannot assign a value to wisdom, nor is it to be found anywhere among the living.

28:14 The deepest abyss of the sea will not help you in your search,

28:15-19 Nor can any treasure—not even the rarest and most exquisite—purchase it for you.

27:14 If his children multiply—for the sword!
And his descendants will not be satiated with food.

27:15 His survivors will be buried in death,
And his widows will not weep.

27:16 If he heaps up silver like dirt,
And makes a mountain of [fine] clothing,

27:17 He has made [that mountain of clothing], but the righteous will wear [it],
And the silver—the innocent will be apportioned it.

27:18 He has built like a moth his house,
And like a thicket he posts a guard.

27:19 The wicked will lie down and not [arise] again;
He will open his eyes—and he is not [on the green earth any longer].

27:20 Terrors will overtake him like a flood;
Night will steal him away like a gale.

27:21 The east wind will pick him up, and he will go,
And be blown away from his place;

27:22 And it will hurl him without compassion;
From its hand he will speed through the air;

27:23 It will slap him with its palm,
And laugh him away from his place.

28:1 Though for silver there is [such a thing as a silver] mine,
And [there is] a place where they refine gold—

28:2 Iron is taken from the dust,
And the stone pours forth copper;

28:3 An end he [who mines] makes make for the darkness,
And searches out every dead end
[Of] stone, gloom, and darkness;

28:4 He breaks a channel in the soft rock
In the places forgotten of foot;
They hang apart from any mortal[’s dwelling place];
[there] they totter;

28:5 From the earth comes bread,
Yet beneath it is upturned like fire,

28:6 Its stones are the place of sapphire,
While the dust has gold

28:7 On a path which birds of prey have not known,
Nor has the eye of the black kite seen it;

28:8 The sons of pride have not tread upon it;
The lion has not advanced upon it;

28:9 He sends his hand to the flint,
Overturning at the root of the mountains;

28:10 He cuts rivers in the rocks,
And his eye sees every precious thing [hidden there];

28:11 He binds the sources of the river;
And its hidden things he brings to light—

28:20 I say again: Wisdom cannot be located by human efforts, 28:21 For it is beyond the capacities of anyone on the earth; nor can the birds in the skies spot it. 28:22 Death itself can only speak of wisdom as something it vaguely knows of. 28:23 God is the one who understands it. 28:24 This makes sense, since it is God who sees every last thing beneath the skies. 28:25 He grants wind its properties, and easily quantifies the water in the sea. 28:26-27 In the beginning, when God foreordained the course of every raindrop, and charted a course for every lightning bolt, he perceived, described, strengthened, and investigated wisdom. 28:28 Then he told humanity that wisdom consists in this: in holding God in respect, and, by the same token, in eschewing sin.	28:12 Yet as for wisdom, where can it be found, And where is the place of discernment? 28:13 Mortal man does not know its value, Nor can it be found in the land of the living. 28:14 The deep says, “It is not in me,” And the sea says, “It is not with me.” 28:15 Gold filigree cannot be given in exchange for it, And one cannot weigh out silver for its price. 28:16 It cannot be bought with Ophir gold, [Or] with precious red carnelian or sapphire. 28:17 Neither gold, nor pure gold, can match its value, Nor is its exchange rate [to be measured in] vessels of fine gold. 28:18 Neither corals nor crystal can be mentioned, And the pouch of wisdom is corals. 28:19 The topaz of Cush cannot match its value, Nor with pure gold can it be purchased. 28:20 And wisdom—where does it come from, And where ever is the place of discernment? 28:21 For it is hidden from the eyes of all living, And it is hidden from the birds of the heavens. 28:22 Abaddon and Death say, “With our ears we have heard a report of it.” 28:23 God has discerned its way, And he knows its place. 28:24 For he beholds the ends of the earth; He sees all that is under the heavens, 28:25 Making a weight for the wind, And he measured the waters with a span. 28:26 When he made a decree concerning the rain, And made the way for the thunderbolts, 28:27 It was then that he saw it, and recounted it; He established it, and also searched it out. 28:28 And he said to mankind, “Behold, the fear of the lord—that is wisdom; “And turning from evil is discernment.”
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Summary of 27:1-28:28

Job continues to be emphatic about his innocence (27:2-6).

The train of thought in the balance of chapter 27 is difficult to reconstruct, mainly because much of what follows “seems out of place in the mouth of Job” (Hartley, 370); in particular, “[v]erses 8-10 [and much v13ff] are somewhat out character for him since they describe bad things happening to bad people. That is what the friends usually said, not Job” (Alden, 263). Perhaps we should hear an ironic tone in Job's words here: When he says “May my enemy be like a wicked man” (v7), he might be suggesting to his friends (who in their obstinate and unfeeling opposition to him might as well be enemies) that they should be glad that their vision of the fate of an ungodly person (summarized in vv8-10) is *in*accurate. (For if it was accurate, theirs would be a terrible fate indeed.) It is, I think, in a similar frame of mind that Job goes on (vv11, 14-23) to repeat back his friends' words to them (viz. that a terrible fate and an unrighteous lifestyle are altogether coextensive), interjecting (v12) his view that “his side of the argument was patently obvious, that is, that the righteous sometimes suffer and the

wicked often prosper,” and that “the friends' position is... jabbering gibberish” (Alden, 265).

The interpretive difficulties continue with the next chapter. Many take 28:1-28 to be an interlude, but elsewhere the narrator provides some type of heading or transitional statement, so it seems to me that Job must still be speaking. That said, the narrator, if (s)he read this book aloud to a group of listeners, might well share with them a knowing look, since the answer (28:28) to the question that the chapter asks (28:12) is a quality which listeners have learned characterizes *Job's* own life (see 1:1, 1:8, etc.).

The chapter first describes in vivid detail elaborate mining operations (28:1-11). It then pivots to the question of where one finds wisdom (vv12, 20), repeatedly emphasizing that the value of wisdom far surpasses anything the most enterprising of miners could dare to dream of (vv13-19), and the fact that a search of the whole planet, and indeed, of the realm of the dead itself, will fail to discover it (vv21-22). But there is one individual who knows what wisdom is and where to find it—God, fully cognizant of all that is sound and right since the very moment he skillfully fashioned all reality (vv23-27). And God does not keep his knowledge on this point a secret, but discloses it to mankind: Wisdom is to “fear the Lord” and is “turning from evil” (v28).

The difficulty comes in relating all this to the immediate context. Perhaps, having in the previous chapter held up his friends' claims regarding the fate of the wicked as laughable in the light of any reasonable man's experience (27:12ff), Job now sets out to undermine their argument on theological grounds: “To be truly wise is not to be able to perceive the divinely instituted order of things that permeates creation, nor is 'understanding' to gain mastery over life as Job's friends have suggested all along. Instead, true 'wisdom' is 'fear of the Lord.' Of course, this does not mean that we are to be *afraid* of God (Exod. 20:20), but rather that we are to realize and to live according to the recognition that we are entirely dependent on God and his mercy in all things... True wisdom is not to gain *mastery* over life but to acknowledge *dependence* on God” (G. Wilson, 311). Job, in short, points out to his friends that for all their posturing, they have altogether failed to grasp the nature of wisdom.

For all of Job's ability to dismantle his friends' argument, however, he finds himself unable to unpack the baffling behavior of God toward him. To this vexing enigma he next directs his attention.

Paraphrase of 29:1-32:1	Translation of 29:1-32:1
Job continued to make his case: 29:2-3 I desperately long for the way things used to be, back when God was looking out for me. He guided me and protected me day and night. 29:4 Those days were all like payday. God's sovereign oversight blessed my entire household. 29:5 God was on my side then; I still had my workers to banter with as well. 29:6 My life was full of abundance, bathed in butter. 29:7 I was always visible when important business transactions and public discussions were taking place; my voice was trusted in these matters. 29:8 Young men became bashful when they saw me; even the elderly displayed great respect for me. 29:9-10 Those in leadership held back from speaking in my presence, preferring to hear my opinion over voicing their own. 29:11 People acted this way because they had experienced for themselves that God's goodness was at work in my life. 29:12 Indeed, it was known that I made a habit of helping those in dire need, of helping the orphan who lacked an advocate.	And Job continued his declamation, and said, 29:2 If only it could be like the former months, Like the days when God watched over me, 29:3 When his lamp was bright over my head; By his light I walked in the darkness; 29:4 Just as when I was in my harvest days, When the council of God was over my tent; 29:5 When the Almighty was still with me; My servants were around me; 29:6 When my steps were washed in butter, When the rock poured out for me streams of oil; 29:7 When I went out to the gate which sits over against the city, I established my seat in the streets. 29:8 Young men saw me, and hid themselves, While old men arose, stood. 29:9 Princess constrained [their] words, And put their palms on their mouths. 29:10 The voice of noblemen was hidden, And their tongue clings to their palate. 29:11 For the ear had heard me, and pronounced me blessed, And the eye had seen me, and testified [to my blessed

29:13 I was there to comfort people as they lay on their death-beds, and by no means did I neglect to give aid to the woman who had lost her husband.

29:14 Doing the right thing, the just thing, was like clothing to me, so much did it identify me.

29:15-16a I helped the blind, the lame, and those in need.

29:16b If people came to me with a disagreement I wasn't familiar with, I didn't lean on instincts, engage in favoritism, or heed bribes. Instead, I made a careful inquiry as to the truth of the matter.

29:17 The unjust I took down, and I rescued those oppressed by them.

29:18 My expectation was that when my time to die came, it would be peacefully, and after an abundantly fruitful life.

29:19 Mine was a flourishing life, like the garden of Eden.

29:20 My strength was continually renewed; my energy never flagged.

29:21 People would wait until I weighed in before they made any decision.

29:22 Whenever I spoke, they were struck at the wisdom of what I said, and accepted my advice.

29:23 They waited for my input like the ground waits for rain.

29:24 When people around me faltered in their belief in God's provision, I would smile—they could never convince me to be unhappy.

29:25 I provided their leadership; we had a camaraderie like a military commander has with his men after they've been through a battle together.

30:1 Now, however, men younger than me—men whose fathers I didn't trust as far as I could throw them—laugh at my ruin.

30:2 Now we have this ridiculous situation in which these men use the strength of their halcyon days to tear me apart.

30:3 There is a group of people who live in grinding poverty and futility (I know a thing or two about that now!),

30:4 Living off pitiful excuses for food growing in the wild.

30:5 They have been driven away from their communities, chased out like thieves.

30:6 So it is that they live in remote wastelands and dusty caves.

30:7 They cry amidst the untamed undergrowth, and cluster together for warmth.

state].

29:12 For I rescued the poor man who was crying for help,
And the orphan who had no one to help him.

29:13 The blessing of dying came to me,
And the heart of the widow I caused to rejoice.

29:14 I put on righteousness, and it clothed me;
Like a turban or a robe was my justice.

29:15 I was eyes for the blind,
And I was feet for the lame.

29:16 I was a father to the needy,
And the dispute with which I was not familiar I searched out.

29:17 And I shattered the jawbone of the unjust,
And I cast from his teeth his prey.

29:18 And I thought, "In my nest I will die,
"And like the phoenix I will multiply my days."

29:19 My root was open toward the water,
And dew dwelt in my boughs.

29:20 My glory was [continually] fresh with me,
And my bow was [always] new in my hand.

29:21 For me they would listen and they would wait,
And they would be silent for my counsel.

29:22 After I had spoken, they would not deliberate again;
Indeed, my words dropped upon them [like honey].

29:23 And they would wait for my as for the rain,
And they opened their mouths for the spring rain.

29:24 I would laugh when they did not believe,
They could not sadden my face.

29:25 I chose their way for them, and sat as head,
And I dwelt like a king with an army—
When they are mourning, he comforts them.

30:1 But now young men, younger than me in days,
mock me,
[Young men] whose fathers I refused to allow to sit
with the dogs of my flock.

30:2 Also, the strength of their arms—why is it
[directed] against me?
On their account [my] vigor vanishes.

30:3 In lack and famine is the barrenness
Of those who flee to the dry land,
(Recently [I have seen only] devastation and
desolation!)

30:4 Of those who pluck flowers on shrubs,
And the root of flowering desert plants is their food.

30:5 From the midst [of civilization] they are driven
out;
They raise a shout over them as with a thief.

30:8 They are the offspring of those without understanding or reputation, those banished from society.

30:9 Now they make me the butt of their jokes, the object of their ridicule.

30:10 They hate me, and lend no hand to help me; they find me disgusting, and spit at me.

30:11 All this is because God has made me the target for his arrows. I am like a donkey no longer fit for work.

30:12 All around me young people lay traps for me and seek my downfall.

3:13 They don't need help; they are quite successful on their own in ruining my life.

30:14 They rush to attack me like soldiers through a great hole that's been torn through the city wall, surging on amidst the swirling dust and debris.

30:15 I am a powerful magnet, pulling all manner of destruction quickly to myself and repelling all hope for the future.

30:16 I am wracked by grief; my time has come.

30:17 I can feel the hopelessness of midnight seeping into my very bones. My situation is becoming steadily worse.

30:18 God is like a bully, grabbing me by the lapel and shaking me like a rag doll.

30:19 He's thrown me down into the mud. That's a good place for me, though, because I am as frail as a clod of dry earth.

30:20 God, I pray to you, but get no answer; I stand in full view of you, only to receive your steely gaze.

30:21 You have determined to be my bitter enemy, and you use all of your power to attack me.

30:22 You toss me to the wind, and watch as I wither away to nothing. I am a shadow of my former self.

30:23 I can say all this because it's clear to me that your intent is to bring me to death—the common fate of all mankind.

30:24 Why, God, do you feel the need to kick a guy when he's down? Haven't I suffered enough?

30:25 When catastrophe came to someone, I always wept with them; those facing hardship could count on my empathy.

30:26 Yet my own optimism was sorely disappointed; my hope has been turned into hopelessness.

30:27 My mind races; it is a time of turmoil for me.

30:28 I cannot see my way through this calamity. I call for help from the city, but get no reply.

30:29 My only song is as haunting as coyotes in the

30:6 With the result that they dwell in the terrible wadis,
In the caves of dust and rock.

30:7 Between the shrubs they weep;
Under the [shadows of the] weeds huddle together.

30:8 The sons of the fool, together with the sons of those without a name
Are [thus] struck [and driven] away from the land.

30:9 And now, I am their song,
And I have become a target for their gossip.

30:10 They abhor me, [and] are far from me,
And from my face they do not withhold [their] spit.

30:11 For he has loosed his bow, and afflicted me;
And the bridle they have taken from my jaw.

30:12 On my right hand young people arise and push my feet,
And raise up against me their paths of destruction.

30:13 They have broken up my road;
They have effected my ruin [even] with no one to help them.

30:14 As with a wide breech they have come;
Beneath destruction they have swept in.

30:15 Terror has turned to [beset] me;
It pursues my path like wind,
While salvation passes by me like a cloud.

30:16 And now my soul is poured out upon me;
My days of trouble have seized me.

30:17 Night corrodes my bones within me,
And the things that gnaw me do not rest.

30:18 With greatness of strength he seizes my clothing;
By the collar of my tunic he grabs me.

30:19 He has thrown me to the mud,
And I take on the qualities of dust and ashes.

30:20 I cry to you, and you do not answer me;
I stand up, and you look upon me.

30:21 You have turned [yourself] to be cruel to me;
By the strength of your hand you have persecuted me.

30:22 You have lifted me up, and caused me to be carried away by the wind,
And you dissolve me, [and] ruin me.

30:23 For I know that you will return me to death,
And [to] the house appointed for all life.

30:24 Certainly one does not stretch out one's hand against a heap of ruins;
In the midst of one's disaster, does one for that reason raise a shout [of war]?

30:25 Have I not wept for the severe day?
My soul sympathized with the needy.

night. The only tone I can use is sharp and keening.

30:30 I am rotting away. My position is as precarious as a dry forest in a heat wave.

30:31 My only purpose in life is to be wracked by grief.

31:1 All this despite my manifest innocence! For instance, I have put my gaze under a binding contract not to make any woman an object of lustful thoughts.

31:2 I consider that God, sovereignly reigning from heaven, rewards each according to his works.

31:3 Most certainly the wicked suffer for their crimes sooner or later.

31:4 God's omniscience includes my every characteristic, my every action.

31:5 Had I lived a life dedicated to deceit,

31:6 It would have only been fair for God to condemn me—I call on God to apply justice to my case, for when he carefully investigates, he will discover that I am innocent!

31:7 Had I left the narrow way, becoming jealous of someone else's property and taking it for myself,

31:8 It would have been fair for me to leave my material wealth for someone else to enjoy, to be left without a legacy to my name.

31:9 Had I allowed my heart to become the property of someone other than my wife and looked for an opportunity to sleep with someone else's wife,

31:10 It would have been fair for my own wife to be made to sleep with others.

31:11 (After all, my infidelity would have been a civil offense,

31:12 A kindling of hellish fire on all my household!)

31:13 If I had refused to grant a just outcome to one of my servants (of either gender) when there was a claim that I had been unfair,

31:14 It would be fair for me to be condemned; indeed, I would have nothing to say on the day of judgment, no reply to the condemnation of God on that day.

31:15 (After all, God is the one who formed me in my mother's womb and my servant in his or her womb; so there is no partiality with him.)

31:16 Had I refused to give the poor what they needed or dashed the hopes of the widows in need of aid,

31:17 Eating by myself, not bothered by the fact that the widows' children were going hungry,

31:18 It would be fair for me to be condemned. But so far from neglecting the orphans, I was always a father figure for both boys and girls.

30:26 But I waited for good, and calamity came; And I waited for light, and darkness came.

30:27 My innards boil, and are not quiet; My days of trouble have come upon me.

30:28 I walk in the darkness with no sun; I arise in the assembly, [and I] call for help.

30:29 I am a brother of the jackal, And a neighbor for the daughters of the ostrich.

30:30 My skin turns black upon me, And my bones are kindled by the drought.

30:31 My lyre is for mourning, And my reed pipe for weeping.

31:1 I made a covenant for my eyes Not look to gaze upon a virgin.

31:2 And what is the portion of God from above, Or the inheritance of the Almighty from the high places?

31:3 Is there not calamity for the unjust, And misfortune for evil doers?

31:4 Does not he himself see my ways, And number all my steps?

31:5 If I have walked with vanity, Or if my feet have rushed to deceit—

31:6 Let him weigh me in righteous balances, And let God know my integrity—

31:7 If my step has declined from the [upright] way, And if my heart has gone after my eyes,

Or a blemish has stuck to my hand,

31:8 May I sow, and another eat, And let my descendants be uprooted!

31:9 If my heart has been seduced by a woman, And I have waited at the door of my neighbor,

31:10 May wife grind [grain] for another, And let others kneel over her,

31:11 For that would be a crime, And an iniquity for the judges,

31:12 For it would be a fire consuming all the way to Abaddon,

And uprooting all my income!

31:13 If have rejected my servant's (whether male or female) claim to justice,

When they took up a case against me,

31:14 What, then, would I do when the Divine One arises?

And when he attends to matters, what [answer] could I return to him?

31:15 Did not he who made me in the womb make him?

For he established us in the womb as one.

31:19 Had I had knowingly failed to provide clothing for those who needed it,
31:20 It would be fair for me to be condemned. But I did not fail to provide these needs: The poor were amply cared for at my expense.
31:21 Had I used my power to brush aside the need of an orphan who was approaching the authorities for help,
31:22 It would be fair for my power to come to absolutely nothing.
31:23 (After all, God's terrifying vengeance would have me as its target, and there is no one who can withstand his power!)
31:24 Had I put my faith in money, trusting in wealth for security,
31:25 Finding joy in my wealth and prosperity, it would be fair for me to be condemned.
31:26 Had I set my affections on the sun or the moon in all of their celestial splendor,
31:27 And had allowed my heart to be drawn into idolatry when no one was looking,
31:28 That also would be a grave crime, in that I would have betrayed God in heaven.
31:29 If I had gleefully celebrated when someone who had caused me grief encountered a disaster, it would be fair for God to condemn me.
31:30 (The truth is, I have never allowed myself to sin by wishing for someone else to be cursed.)
31:31 Had I left people who visited my home without any provision when I had plenty, it would be fair for God to condemn me.
31:32 (Foreigners were not made to sleep outside; I threw open the doors of my home to them.)
31:33 Had I, like Adam, tried to hide my sin,
31:34 And, intimidated by how people would react, covered up problems instead of being transparent with the larger public, it would be fair for God to condemn me.
31:35 How I wish that there was someone who would take my complaints seriously! Here's my signature: I am prepared to assume responsibility for what happens. I call on God to make a reply to me. I call on him to bring documentation to the court concerning my alleged fault.
31:36 That documentation I would gladly carry with me. Yes, I'd wear it like a crown!
31:37 I'd tell God everything I've ever done, and I would approach him with a swagger.
31:38-39 Had I ever gained the produce of the land

31:16 If I withheld the longing of the poor,
Or the [hope in the] eyes of the widow brought to an end,
31:17 And ate my portion by myself,
While her fatherless child did not eat—
31:18 But from my youth he grew up with me as [though I were] a father [to him],
And from the womb of my mother I guided her—
[Let God bring due justice upon me!]
31:19 If I saw someone coming to nothing, with no clothing,
And there was no covering for the needy—
31:20 Did not his loins bless me,
And did he not warm himself from the shearing of my lambs?—
[Let God bring due justice upon me!]
31:21 If I brandished my hand against the orphan,
When I saw in the gate [someone in need of] my help,
31:22 Let my shoulder fall from its socket,
And my arm be broken, from my humerus [on down]!
31:23 For the terror of the Divine One would come upon me,
And his majesty—who can endure it?
31:24 If I made gold my confidence,
Or said to gold, “[You are] my security!”;
31:25 If I rejoiced when my wealth was great,
Or when my hand had found greatness—[Let God bring due justice upon me!]
31:26 If I saw the light when it shone,
Or the moon, gloriously passing by [in the night sky],
31:27 And my heart was secretly enticed,
And my hand was kissed by my mouth—
31:28 That too would be a criminal liability,
For I would have been disloyal to the Divine One who is above!
31:29 If I rejoiced when the one who hated me met with disaster,
Or shouted [in joy] when bad circumstances found him,
[Let God bring due justice upon me!]
31:30 Indeed, I have not allowed my mouth to sin
By asking for his soul to be enmeshed in a curse.
31:31 If the men of my tent have ever said
“‘Oh that we could have some of his meat! Then we would satisfied!’”—
31:32 The resident alien was not slept outdoors;
I opened my doors to the traveler—
[Let God bring due justice upon me!]
31:33 If, like Adam, I have covered up my

without a fair price, disrespecting its owner and leaving the soil mistreated and uncared for, 31:40a-b It would be fair for weeds to grow on my land instead of crops. 31:40c With that, Job finished laying out his case. 32:1 Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar stopped arguing with Job, since it had become clear to them that he simply refused to say that he was in the wrong.	transgression, Hiding my iniquity close to my chest, 31:34 Having become frightened of a great crowd, Or frightened by the contempt of a [vengeful] clan, And, silent, not gone out the door, [Let God bring due justice upon me!] 31:35 Oh that there was someone to listen to me! Behold, my mark! Let the Almighty answer me! And let him who contends with me file a court briefing! 31:36 Surely I would lift it up on my shoulder, And bind it like a crown on myself! 31:37 I would report to him the number of my steps; I would approach him like a nobleman [approaches someone]. 31:38 Does my land cry out against me? Or do its furrows weep together? 31:39 If I have eaten its strength without silver, And the soul of its owner treated with contempt, 31:40 Let thorns grow in place of wheat, And darnel in place of barley. (The words of Job have concluded.) 32:1 And these three men ceased to answer Job, for he was righteous in his own eyes.
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Summary of 29:1-32:1

Job longs for the way things used to be, before his present calamity, when God—at is seemed from his present vantage point, deathly sick and sitting in the city garbage heap—was still on his side (29:2-5a); when those in his employ were not afraid to associate with him (v5b), life was (comparatively, at least) easy (v6), he was held in respect by all (vv7-11, 21-25), and when he was known for his generous assistance to the needy vv12-17). At that time, it seemed to Job that his halcyon days would continue uninterrupted until he died peacefully after a long, full life (vv18-20).

Job juxtaposes these bright and cheerful reminiscences with his present dark and troubling situation to underscore the extent of the calamity he has faced. Instead of respect, he now receives mockery (30:1), which leaves him disheartened (v2). In fact, even those least esteemed by society—those who have had to flee to desolate places, subsisting on little more than weeds, making pitiful homes out of cracks in cliff walls (vv3-8)—snicker at and spit on Job (vv9-10). God (v11a), society (v11b-14), and terror personified (v15) have all united to cast a deep shadow over Job's formerly sun-lit life. God's treatment of Job seems cruel and capricious (vv16-24), undeserved and unrelenting (vv25-31).

Job in chapter 31 makes a final declaration of his innocence. This declaration take the form of repeated variations on the formula “If I did such-and-such a terrible thing [which I have *not*], then let such-and-such terrible consequence come upon me.” His emotions are so heightened that he does not always finish his sentences, and often interjects material into this formula, most notably vv35-37, where he throws down the gauntlet to Almighty.

The final line of 31:40 informs listeners and readers that Job, like his Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar before him (32:1), has exhausted his arguments. No one has anything more to say. Or so it seems.

Paraphrase of 32:2-5 Then Elihu (Barachel's son, a descendant of the Ram	Translation of 32:2-33:5 And the anger of Elihu, son of Barachel the Buzite,
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family through the Buzites) became incensed at Job. The reason for his anger was that Job put himself more in the right than God. 32:3 Elihu was also angry with Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar for disrespecting Job in spite of the fact that they had made no convincing reply to him. 32:4 All this time Elihu had allowed those four men to speak uninterrupted, since he was younger than them. 32:5 But when Elihu perceived that Job's friends had no further contributions to make, he gave vent to his feelings.	from the Ram clan, burned against Job; his anger burned in that he considered himself more in the right than God, 32:3 and his anger burned against his three friends because they did not find an answer, and [yet] condemned Job. 32:4 Now Elihu had waited for Job when it came to [the use of] words, for they were older in days than he. 32:5 And Elihu saw that there was no answer in the mouth of the three friends, and his anger burned.
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Summary of 32:2-5

At this point we learn that Job, Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar are not the only men present: At least one more, Elihu, has apparently been present, though silent, the whole time. His stance complicates matters in that he is dissatisfied *both* with Job *and* with Job's three friends. He is dissatisfied with the former because, in his view at least, Job was guilty of elevating himself above God (32:2); he is dissatisfied with the latter because their grounds for condemning Job were specious (v3). Elihu has deferred to his elders, and to Job in particular (v4), but now feels compelled to speak (v5). This he will do, in no less than *four* segments—as if to make up for lost time.

Paraphrase of 32:6-33:33 Elihu then said, You three are older than I am, so I was afraid to say what was on my mind. 32:7 I felt that those more experienced than I am should point the way forward. 32:8-9 But here is the truth: It is God's Spirit within mortal man—not the <i>vox populi</i> or the wisdom of experience—that imparts understanding. 32:10 So listen to me; I'm going to sort things out. 32:11-12 Here it goes: I waited for you to show Job how wrong he is, but I was disappointed. 32:13 God is keeping you three from being able to point to your own intellectual abilities: It is God who is going to show Job up. 32:14 Job hasn't tried his verbal jousting skills on me. He's going to find I am more than a match for him. And I'm not going to use your approach; I'm going to use far superior verbal weapons. 32:15 Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar have collapsed under Job's counterattacks. They are at a loss. 32:16 Here I was, waiting patiently, but they gave up any further debate. 32:17 Now it's my turn. You'll see what I can bring to the table! 32:18 I have a lot to say; I am full of passion, and I just have to speak! 32:19 I'm like a carbonated beverage that's been	Translation of 32:6-33:33 And Elihu the son of Barachel the Buzite answered and said, I am younger than you in days, while you are old; For that reason I was trepidatious, and afraid to declare what I know to you. 32:7 I thought, "Days will speak, "And greatness of years will make wisdom known." 32:8 Assuredly, the Spirit is in mortal man, And the Breath of the Almighty gives them discernment. 32:9 The multitude are not wise, Nor do the elderly discern what is just. 32:10 Therefore I say, "Listen to me; "I will declare what I know, even I." 32:11 Behold, I waited for your [vaunted] "discernment" [to come to its anticlimactic conclusion], For your [feebly] "searched out" words. 32:12 And I watched you, And behold, there was none to convict Job, [There was none] among you answering his words. 32:13 Lest you should say, "We have found wisdom," The Divine One will drive him away, not man. 32:14 For he has not ordered words to me, Nor will I answer him with your words. 32:15 They have been shattered, and do not answer further;
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shaken up.

32:20 I've got to speak to get these things off my chest. I'm going to say my bit.

32:21-22a I'll be impartial, and I won't be intimidated by anyone's reputation—I don't even know how to play favorites or turn tail and run!

32:22b-33:1 Life is short, so I must say my bit. Please, Job, listen to me closely.

33:2 It's my turn to speak—listen to what I have to say.

33:3 You'll hear from what I say that I am a reliable man; I'll speak the unadulterated truth.

33:4 The Holy Spirit made me, bringing me to life by breathing out.

33:5 See if you have any clever retorts when I've finished—give it your best shot!

33:6 I'm someone that God has made, just like you. You don't have any special relationship with God that I don't have.

33:7 I'll be gentle; I'm not here to make you despondent.

33:8-9 Now, the record will clearly indicate—my own ears heard this—that you have claimed that you are blameless, above reproach.

33:10 You claim in no uncertain terms that God has manufactured arbitrary reasons to attack you, to treat you like you're one of his enemies.

33:11 You talk as though you're a prisoner, and he's the guard.

33:12 Well, let's be clear: You're wrong, and I'm going to call out your misrepresentations. After all, God is too great to be libeled by a mere human like yourself.

33:13 You're being utterly illogical when you argue with God. You have no way of proving him wrong on even one point.

33:14 At various times God, though invisible to the human eye, will communicate to people.

33:15-17 When people are deep in sleep on their beds at night, God sends a meaningful dream: Scenes dance before their minds. These scenes are terrifying, yet they convey the message that they must repent of their evil and of their arrogance.

33:18 In this way God rescues people who because of their sins face the prospect of rotting away, who are about to rush to their doom as fast as a bullet rushes to its target.

33:19 So it is that they wake up weeping, wracked with grief as painful as a car crash.

33:20 They will be so traumatized that they will find

Words escape them.

32:16 And I waited, but they do not speak, For they have ceased; they have not answered further.

32:17 I, even I, will speak my part; I will declare what I know, even I.

32:18 For I am full of words; The spirit in my belly compels me.

32:19 Behold, my belly is like [an] unopened wine[skin],

Like a wine skin with new wine which is broken open.

32:20 I will speak, that I may breathe easily; I will open my lips, that I may answer.

32:21 I will not be biased; And I will not be swayed by the title of any human.

32:22 For I do not [even] know how to recognize a title;

In a short time my maker will bear me away.

33:1 So now, please listen to my words, Job, And play attention to all that I have to say.

33:2 Behold, I [now] open my mouth; My tongue in my mouth speaks.

33:3 The uprightness of my heart is [evident in] my words,

And in knowledge my lips speak in purity.

33:4 The Spirit of the Divine One made me, And the Breath of the Almighty gave me life.

33:5 If you are able, answer me;

Order before me [your words], [and] take your stand.

33:6 Behold, I am just like you as it relates to the Divine One;

I also have been pinched off from clay.

33:7 Behold, my fear will not beset you, Nor will my hand be heavy upon you.

33:8 Surely you have spoken in my hearing, And the voice of words I have heard:

33:9 "I am pure, without transgression; "I am clean, and claim no iniquity.

33:10 "Behold, he finds grievances against me; "He counts me as an enemy to him.

33:11 "He puts my feet in stocks; "He watches all my ways."

33:12 Behold, in this you are not right; I will answer you,

For God is greater than mortal man.

33:13 Why do you strive against him?

For you can answer none of his ways.

33:14 For once the Divine One will speak, And twice, [but] you will not observe him.

33:15 In a dream, a vision of night,

even the finest of foods repulsive.

33:21 Their bodies will waste away to nothing.

33:22 They will find themselves standing at the edge of their open grave; they will be like inmates on death row walking up to their executioners.

33:23-24 If an angel—they are so hard to find!—inserts himself into the situation, telling these people how they can be in the right and graciously asking God for salvation for them on the basis of payment,

33:25 Then their skin will be as smooth as a baby's; they will be as strong and confident as a twenty-year-old.

33:26 They will pray, and get what they pray for. God will accept their public worship, and return their righteous status to them.

33:27-28 They will bear testimony to others, recounting how they strayed from the narrow way, yet God saved them from death.

33:29 What I've just described is what God offers to people—and he gives people several chances.

33:30 He saves people from death, and lets him live a productive life on this green earth.

33:31 Listen to what I say, Job!

33:32 If you have anything to say, now is the time to say it. I'm only trying to help you.

33:33 If you have nothing to say, then keep listening, and I'll lay out the situation for you.

When deep sleeps falls upon people,
When there is slumber upon the bed,

33:16 He will reveal [his truth] to people,
And in visions terrify them,

33:17 To turn humans from evil,
While pride he destroys in a man.

33:18 He spares his soul from corruption,
And his life from being thrown as a javelin.

33:19 And he will be reproved with grief on his bed,
While the strife in his bones is severe.

33:20 And his life will make bread loathsome,
And his soul, desirable food.

33:21 His flesh will be destroyed, [becoming] unseen,
And the barrenness of his bones—they will not see [them any longer].

33:22 And his soul will approach corruption,
And his life to those who put to death.

33:23 If there is an angel over him,
One out of a thousand who can interpose,
Informing a human of his uprightness,

33:24 And if he is gracious to him, and says,
"Redeem him so that he does not go down to corruption:

"I have found a ransom."

33:25 His flesh will grow fresher than youth;
He will return to his halcyon days.

33:26 He will pray to God, and he will show him favor;
And he will approve of him when he worships publicly,
And return to mortal man his righteousness.

33:27 He will look on [other] men and say,
"I sinned, and perverted my uprightness,
"And did not walk on the straight path.

33:28 "[Yet] he redeemed by soul from crossing over to corruption,
And my life walks in the light [of the living]."

33:29 Behold, all these things the Divine One will do
Three times with a man,

33:30 Returning his soul from [the brink of] corruption,
To shine in the light of the living.

33:31 Listen Job; hear me out!
Be silent, and I will speak.

33:32 If there are words [for you to speak], answer me;
Speak, for I desire your righteousness.

33:33 If not, then you listen to me;
Be silent, and I will instruct you in wisdom.

Summary of 32:6-33:33

Elihu spends a great deal of time explaining himself: He deferred to age (32:6-7), and gave the friends ample opportunity to dismantle Job's arguments (vv11-12, 15-16); but, disappointed in their performance, he feels it necessary to intervene (vv10, 17-20, 33:1-2, vv12, 31-33), justifying his intervention on the grounds first that God's Spirit sometimes puts age and number of shame (32:8-9, vv13-14), and second that Job and his friends have in Elihu an impartial (vv21-22), righteous (33:3), and divinely made (v4) umpire.

All this established about himself, Elihu throws down the gauntlet to Job (vv5), though claiming that he does so gently (vv6-7): Job, as Elihu summarizes his argument, feels that he is innocent, yet without reasonable basis, beset by God's punishment (vv8-11). But, replies Elihu, it wrong to portray God in such harsh terms (v13), for God is in fact gracious, not only revealing by supernatural means his expectations for humankind (vv14-17), but also rescuing people who *do* fail to meet his expectations by interposing an angel (vv18-24) and restoring him to publicly visible favor (vv25-28). The mechanics of such an interposition are a bit vague, and it seems that there is a limited number of times that it can be expected (v29), yet God *does* save sinners from death (v30).

Elihu has already promised much and said much, but he is just getting warmed up.

Paraphrase of 34:1-37

Elihu continued,

34:2 You guys are intelligent people, so listen up.

34:3 When someone hears something being said, they think about it, and make a conclusion on whether it's on the right track or not; or when someone tastes food, they get a sense of whether it's worth eating or not.

34:4 So it is only reasonable in our case that we can discuss the disagreement, and among us we'll come to the right answer.

34:5 Now here's the important thing: Job says, "I'm in the right, and God has been unfair to me.

34:6 "There is no justice here, because everyone assumes I'm lying. I'm being sent to the gallows, even though I've done nothing wrong."

34:7-8 What a case this Job is! Slander is like an energy drink to him, and he finds friendship in the company of wicked men!

34:9 Let me explain: Job says that it doesn't make any difference if someone serves God.

34:10 The situation is clear (if you have half a brain): God will never, ever be unfair!

34:11 On the contrary, God always deals with a person in a way that corresponds to his actions—if that man is wicked, God will punish him; if he is righteous, God will bless him.

34:12 No, God never punishes anyone without due cause.

34:13-14 No one assigned God the job of running the universe. Nor did anyone give the Holy Spirit to God. God is the king and creator of everything on his own authority!

34:15 By contrast, mankind is mortal; death is every

Translation of 34:1-37

And Elihu answered and said,

34:2 Hear, o wise men, my words,
And listen, you who are knowledgeable, to me.

34:3 For the ear tests words,
And the palate tests food.

34:4 Let us assess justice in our case;
Let us know among us what the good is.

34:5 For Job says, "I am righteous,
"But the Divine One has subverted my justice.

34:6 "As touching my case, I am considered a liar:
"My arrow wound is incurable, though there is no transgression."

34:7 Who is a man like Job,
Drinking slander like water,

34:8 And traveling in companionship with evildoers,
And walking with wicked men?

34:9 For he says, "It is no benefit to a man
"When God shows him favor."

34:10 Therefore, those who are sensible, listen to me;
Far be it from the Divine One to do wickedness, and
from the Almighty to do unjustly!

34:11 For according to the work of a human, he will repay him,
And he will cause him to find what corresponds to the
way of a person.

34:12 Indeed, the Divine One truly will not [wrongly]
condemn,

Nor will the Almighty pervert justice.

34:13 Who put him in charge of the earth?
Or who assigned the whole world [to him]?

34:14 Or did he assign to him his Spirit,
And gather his Breath to him?

human's inevitable end.

34:16 If you can understand me, Job, listen carefully to what I have to say.

34:17 It is absurd to think that the ruler of the universe is despotic. It is ludicrous for you to think that God is the one in the wrong.

34:18 It is God who calls out neglect and corruption in rulers and the upper class.

34:19 It is God who is impartial to all, because he made all.

34:20 (Humanity is so temporary and fragile, liable to pass away suddenly, prone to sudden revolution or unprovoked falls from power.)

34:21 God's impartiality stems from God's unrestricted access to people's lives.

34:22 There is absolutely no way for people to hide their actions from him.

34:23 It's not on humans to make God aware of problems he needs to address.

34:24 There is no need for an investigation: God immediately knows of injustice, and he proceeds to bring down the oppressive and to replace them with others.

34:25 Yes, God is fully aware of all evildoing, and brings swift and irrevocable judgment on those who practice wickedness.

34:26 He will bring terror on the wicked, rebuking their brazen acts.

34:27 After all, they have turned away from God, and have neglected to take God's way to heart.

34:28 So it is that God hears the poor appealing for help; he is fully aware of what the wicked are doing.

34:29-30 For God brings peace to the land, silencing the wicked. And at other times God withdraws his blessing from the nation or the individual whose evil (whether the evil of a king or the evils of a nation) has angered him. In those circumstances, no one can coerce God's favor.

34:31 But no one has ever rightly accused God of bringing suffering to their lives when they are innocent.

34:32 If I'm wrong about this, just tell me, and I'll be quiet.

34:33a-b God will not be compelled by you to give back everything that you've lost. Job, you chose this fate for yourself, so don't blame me for your predicament.

34:33c-34 What do you know, Job? I'd rather spend my time with people who can have an intelligent

34:15 All flesh perishes alike,
And a human returns to dust.

34:16 If you have understanding, listen to me;
Hear the sound of my words.

34:17 Will one who hates injustice indeed exercise oversight?

Or will you hold the righteous Mighty One guilty,

34:18 Who says to a king, "Delinquent!"

[And says] "Wicked!" to noblemen,

34:19 Who does not show partiality to princes,
And does not regard the upper class more than the poor,

Since all of them are his work

34:20 (In a moment they die, and that at midnight;

A people quakes and passes over,

And they put aside a powerful person without use of force)?

34:21 For his eyes are on all the ways of a person,
And all his steps he sees.

34:22 There is no darkness, nor deep deep darkness,
Where evildoers can be hidden.

34:23 For it is not continually a person's responsibility
To come to the Divine One in judgment.

34:24 He breaks the powerful without inquiry,
And raises up others to replace them.

34:25 In short, he is cognizant of their works,
And overturns [them] in a night, and they are crushed.

34:26 He will terrify the wicked, [and] rebuke them
In the place where they see,

34:27 Since they have turned from following him,

And did not give thought to any of his ways,

34:28 Bringing to his attention the cry of the poor,
While he hears the cry of the oppressed.

34:29 For he makes [the land] quiet (and who can [thereafter] act wickedly?)

And he hides his face (and who can [then] see him?)—
[This true] both as touching a nation and as touching a[n individual] human—

34:30 From a wicked human when he reigns as king,
[And] from the traps of a people.

34:31 But has anyone every said to the Divine One,
"I endure [suffering], not having acted wickedly?"

34:32 Unless I see you teaching me;

If I have done unjustly I will not continue.

34:33 Will he, on your authority, pay it back what you have rejected?

For you have chosen [this course], and not I.

And what do you know when it comes to speaking

conversation with me, with people smart enough to listen to me. 34:35 Job, you're all washed up. 34:36 I hope that you find yourself in court for the rest of eternity for saying what a wicked person would say. 34:37 After all, you sin more and more, and we who can hear you have to put up with hearing you mock such a serious subject—rebellion against God! On and on you go, attacking God with your words!	[intelligently]? 34:34 Sensible men will speak to me, And a wise man listens to me. 34:35 Job does not speak with knowledge, And his words do not involve prudence. 34:36 Oh, that Job will be forever tried On account of his answers being like [those of] wicked men! 34:37 For he increases his sin; He, among us, makes light of transgression, And multiplies his words against the Divine One.
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Summary of 34:1-37

Elihu continues to implore the three friends to learn from him (34:2-4): He will explain to them the truth of the situation. As Elihu sees it, Job's claim of unmerited suffering (vv5-6) proves only that Job is a man uniquely capable of making a mockery of truth (v7) and of making common cause with evil men (v8), inasmuch as such a claim implies that service for God carries with it no tangible benefits (v9). On the contrary, argues Elihu, God's actions toward people are altogether proportionate to their actions, whether good or evil (vv11-12). By meddling with God's justice, Job acts as though *he* was ruler of the earth (v13), as though he had a monopoly on the Spirit of God (v14), though he is only a mortal, just like everyone else (v15).

Elihu then directs his gaze at Job (v16). God's justice cannot be gainsaid (v17), for he is constantly in the business of dispensing justice to the highest levels of government, without partiality (vv18-31).

Apparently once again concerned with his image, Elihu states that if Job can prove him wrong, he will happily back down (v32). But this offer is surely disingenuous, as Elihu immediately goes on to blast Job's intelligence (vv33-35), longing for Job to be held to account for his blasphemous lies (vv36-37).

Elihu will have more to say as well.

Paraphrase of 35:1-16 Elihu continued, 35:2 Job, how can you possibly think this is the right road to take? You claim you're better at being fair than God! 35:3 That's exactly what you think, because here you are wondering whether the life of sin is better than the life of righteousness. 35:4 Well, I'll set you straight, and your three friends, too! 35:5 Take a good look upward—see the skies way up there? 35:6 God, who dwells in those heavens, will not be harmed in the slightest by even the worst sin you could commit, 35:7 And he is not benefited by your very best deeds. God is unimpressed by your puny mortality! 35:8 No, your good and bad deeds have nothing to do with God; they only affect your fellow human beings. 35:9-10 And humanity certainly is affected by its worst members! Many a person has called for help because of oppression, asking for help and consolation	Translation of 35:1-16 And Elihu answered and said, 35:2 Do you consider this to be justice? You have said, "I am more righteous than the Divine One." 35:3 For you wonder what use it is for you: "How am I better than if I sinned?" 35:4 I will return words to you, And to your friends with you. 35:5 Gaze at the heavens, and see; And look the clouds which are higher than you: 35:6 If you have sinned, what do you do to harm him? And [if] you have multiplied transgressions, what do you accomplish as it relates to him? 35:7 If you are righteous, what will he give you, Or what will he receive from your hand? 35:8 For a person like you is your wickedness, And for a son of Adam is your righteousness. 35:9 Due to a multitude of oppressors they cry out; They shout for help due to the [oppressive] strength of many, 35:10 And it is surely said, "Where is God who made
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from God. 35:11 Job, tell us what you learn from observing what happens around all you: 35:12 The wicked call for God's help on the day of their calamity, but get no response, since God knows their evil pride full well. 35:13 God will absolutely not listen to their empty words! He will turn his gaze away from them. 35:14 Your case will be even worse, since you claim you don't see evidence of his working. So go to him for mercy, and listen for his answer! 35:15 Here's the key: God is gracious and forgiving. 35:16 You certainly need grace and forgiveness, Job, since you drone on and on even though you know nothing.	me, "Who gives songs in the night?" 35:11 Teach us from the animals of the earth, And from the birds of the heavens: 35:12 There they call out, and he does not answer, On account of the pride of wicked men. 35:13 Indeed, the Divine One will not listen to vanity, And the Almighty will not look upon him. 35:14 How much less when you say you do not see him! Take your case before him, and wait for him! 35:15 And now, surely his anger judges nothing, And he does not set his mind on transgression. 35:16 For Job opens his mouth in vanity; It is without knowledge that he makes words many.
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Summary of 35:1-16

Elihu continues to be outraged that Job implies himself to be more righteous than God (25:2), and to see no difference in God's treatment of the unjust and his treatment of the just (v3), so he continues to rebuke him (v4a); he cannot resist a jibe at the three feckless friends as well (v4b).

A simple look upward, Elihu contends, will make clear the magnitude of God who reigns above the clouds (v5). With that in mind, sin and righteousness are both trivial in the sense that neither can bring harm or benefit to God (vv6-7); these things affect only Job's fellow man (v8). And man does indeed suffer under the hand the oppressors (vv9-10). Nevertheless, a look to the law of nature (v11) will disclose that accountability *does* come to the wicked, whose arrogance bars them from God's favorable response (vv12-13). If the wicked, who at least *do* cry out to God for assistance in their time of need, are not heard by him, what will be the outcome for Job who denies God's involvement in the universe (v14a)? Job must set aside presumption and go to God for mercy (v14b); God is indeed gracious (v15), and Job is indeed in need of grace, since his mouth incriminates him (v16).

Such indeed is Elihu's contention, and he has one final salvo in store.

Paraphrase of 36:1-37:24 Elihu continued, 36:2 Give me just a few more minutes, and I'll clear things up for you; there remain things to be said on God's behalf. 36:3 What I know reflects the full spectrum of earthly and heavenly phenomena, and my poetry is an exhibition of right thinking and behavior. 36:4 I do not relate what is untrue; I am equipped to clarify everything as it really is. 36:5 Listen up: God is magnificent, and no one thinks he is insignificant; God is magnificent, and his intellect is vast. 36:6 He will bring death to the wicked, and vindication to the righteous. 36:7 He always watches over good people—and also over kings, keeping them on their thrones. 36:8-10 If people are locked away in prison, he lets	Translation of 36:1-37:24 And Elihu continued and said, 36:2 Wait for me a little longer, and I will inform you, For there are still words [to be said] for God. 36:3 I take my knowledge from afar, And for my work I affix righteousness. 36:4 For truly, my words are not falsehood; Complete knowledge is in my possession. 36:5 Behold, the Divine One is great and is not despised by anyone; Great, [and] powerful in intellect. 36:6 He will not allow the wicked to live, But we will give justice to the humble. 36:7 He will not lift his gaze from the righteous, Nor with kings as it relates to the throne, Seating them forever, that they should be exalted. 36:8 And if there are prisoners in fetters, Being snared in cords of affliction,
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them know just how they have arrogantly sinned, and makes clear to them that they ought to repent.

36:11 If they repent and serve him, theirs is a long and happy life.

36:12 But if they harden their hearts, the fools meet their end at the end of a spear thrown from God's hand.

36:13 Those who are irredeemably irreligious react to this call to repentance only with bitterness, shouting angrily at the chains with which he has bound them.

36:14 A terrifying earthquake will signal their doom, with angels reaching out to slay them.

36:15 But God will rescue those in distress who are not intractably set against him. He will use that very distress to bring them to repentance.

36:16 This is precisely the situation we find ourselves in, Job. God has prevented you from dying in the calamities which destroyed your children, workers, and family, and offers you the choice of a new life after this present trouble—a life of endless prosperity, if you repent.

36:17 But the choice you are making is that of boundless punishment in keeping with your alliance with evil.

36:18 Watch out, in case the prospect of great wealth and vast bribes keeps you from doing the right thing.

36:19 I hope you don't stubbornly argue against God even in the face of all this trouble!

36:20 And don't think that darkness will hide you.

36:21 Be careful not to choose wickedness, because this is the path you are on—this, when you ought to be listening to God's discipline!

36:22 Let it sink in just how powerful God is, and just how far his wisdom goes beyond that of any wise man on the earth!

36:23 No one can tell God what to do, and no one can pin blame on him.

36:24 Don't forget that your job is to praise God's mighty deeds, which are the subject of the best of human songs.

36:26 All of humanity has seen and been amazed by God's deeds, if only at a distance.

36:27 To give an example, God causes the evaporation of water and the formation of clean mists.

36:28 So it is that the clouds form, and the touch of water is felt on the faces of many.

36:29 Yes, a gathering of clouds above is evidence of God moving through the heavens like a traveler through a township.

36:30 God clothes himself in lightning, and pours

36:9 He informs them of their work,

Of their transgressions, for they have been arrogant,

36:10 And he opens their ear to discipline, And says that they should return from evil.

36:11 If they listen and serve [him],

They fill out their days with good,

With their years consisting of pleasant things.

36:12 And if they do not listen, they go away in a javelin,

And did in accordance with [their] lack of knowledge.

36:13 But the profane of heart become angry;

The cry out, for he has bound them.

36:14 Their soul will die in violent quaking,

And their life [will end] among the angels.

36:15 He will deliver the afflicted by his affliction, And will open their ear through distress.

36:16 And indeed, he has drawn you out from the mouth of distress:

Freedom, with no imprisonment following it!

And your table-rest will be full of fat.

36:17 But with the judgment of the wicked you are full;

Judgment and justice will seize [you].

36:18 Beware, lest abundance entice you,

And the greatness of the bribe, let it not deter you!

36:19 Will your battle-cry be ordered even in trial, Along with every exertion of strength?

36:20 Do not long for the night,

When darkness goes up in their place.

36:21 Be on guard, so that you do not turn to evil,

For this you have chosen, rather than [remedial] affliction.

36:22 Behold, the Divine One is highly exalted in his strength;

Who is a teacher like him?

36:23 Who has appointed his way for him,

Or who has said, "You have accomplished iniquity"?

36:24 Remember that you ought to magnify his work, Of which people sing.

36:25 Every human has seen it;

Mortal man gazes at it from afar.

36:26 Behold, God is exalted, and we do not know [the half of it];

The number of his years is without searching out.

36:27 For he draws up drops of water;

He purifies water for his mist

36:28 With which the clouds flow;

Trickling on many humans.

36:29 Indeed, if one sees a spreading out of clouds,

water over the ocean.

36:31 The phenomena of the water cycle are the means by which God exerts his global authority, and by them he generously dispenses food.

36:32 God is in full control of the shining of light; only at his command does it encounter the eye.

36:33 You know God is coming by the sound of his powerful battlecry; for sin awakens his jealousy and his wrath.

37:1 All this causes me terror; my heart pounds in my chest.

37:2 Don't ignore the thunderous sound issuing forth from God's mouth.

37:3 It is like thunder rolling around the earth, like lightning flashing on every horizon.

37:4 Things only get louder as God speaks again. His greatness shakes the earth; he doesn't hold back, and everyone is fully aware of it.

37:5 God shouts out astonishing things, and what he says and does exceeds our comprehension.

37:6 As another example, he is the one who ordains the falling of snow and the turning of seasons.

37:7 He imprints on human nature the recognition that God is the creator.

37:8 Animals flee to their layers

37:9 Because a wintry blast comes forth from the secret chambers of God's house;

37:10 God breathes out, and frost covers the earth, and ice covers the water.

37:11 Yes, he makes clouds heavy with water, then scatters the cloud with the inbreaking of sunlight.

37:12 God is in full control of every meteorological phenomenon. Every action in the skies is in accordance with the proper function of each part and operates at his command, all for the sake of the earth below.

37:13 At times, God uses storms to discipline the earth. At other times, God mercifully sends rain to nourish the earth. Either way, God is the one that makes it all happen.

37:14 Let this sink in, Job. Meditate on the works of the Lord.

37:15 Consider the fact that you do not understand the means by which God causes all things to happen; how, for instance, he creates lightning.

37:16 Moreover, you, like all of us mortals, are ignorant of how exactly clouds disperse, of the dazzling things that come with omniscience.

37:17 When your life was going well, it was because

It is the noise of his booth.

36:30 Behold, he spreads over him his light, While the roots of the sea he has covered.

36:31 For in them he rules the peoples; He gives food in abundance.

36:32 On his palms he covers light, And he gives it orders in the encounter.

36:33 His roar announces him; He is jealously angry on account of iniquity.

37:1 Indeed, on this account my heart trembles, And leaps from its place.

37:2 Listen closely to the roar of his voice, And [to] the utterance that comes forth from his mouth.

37:3 He lets it loose under all the heavens, And his light on the extremities of the earth.

37:4 After it his voice roars, Thundering with the voice of his exaltation, And he does not restrain them, For his voice is heard.

37:5 The divine one thunders wondrous things with his voice, Doing great things, and we do not know [the half of them].

37:6 For to the snow he says, "Fall on the land!" And [to] the light rains and the heavy rains, "Be strong!"

37:7 On the hand of every human he affixes a seal, So that every mortal knows his work.

37:8 And a wild animal comes into its hiding place, And dwells in its lair.

37:9 A storm comes from the inner room, And from the north wind, [a] cold [blast].

37:10 From the breath of the Divine One he produces frost, And the breadth of water is enclosed [in ice].

37:11 Indeed, with moisture he burdens the cloud; He scatters the cloud with his light,

37:12 And it turns all around at his direction; According to their work, according to all that he commands them,

Over the face of the world, earthward,

37:13 Whether for reproof, or for his land, Or for mercy; [in each case] he causes it to find it.

37:14 Listen to [all] this, Job;

Be still, and consider the works of the Divine One.

37:15 Do you understand how God ordained his works,

And causes the light of his cloud to shine?

God created favorable weather. 37:18 You are not God's assistant in his astonishing heavenly handiwork. 37:19 You talk as if you could tell us what to say to God. Teach us, Job, and then we'll be fully informed when we come before God! 37:20 God is not waiting with baited breath to see what I, a mere mortal, will say! When he begins to speak, everyone else shuts up. 37:21 Without warning God is liable to hide, so to speak, behind the clouds, unseen. Yet his Spirit proceeds and purifies. 37:22 God's manifestation, when it does come, is one of blinding, glorious light. 37:23 God's power is beyond our understanding, and his moral character is unimpeachable. 37:24 So people are in awe of him—anyone, that is, with a brain.	37:16 Do you understand the spreading out of clouds, The wonders of perfection of knowledge? 37:17 For your clothes were warm When he quieted the land from the south. 37:18 Are you with him spread out the clouds, [Clouds which are] strong like a cast mirror? 37:19 Inform us what we shall say to him; We will not [then] arrange [our words] before darkness. 37:20 Will it be recounted to him what I speak? Or does a man speak when he makes a pronouncement? 37:21 And now, they do not see light; He is obscure in the clouds, But the Spirit passes on and cleanses them. 37:22 Gold[en splendor] comes from the north; With God is awe-inspiring splendor. 37:23 We have never discovered [the fullness of] the Almighty, who is exalted in strength; And as regards justice and greatness of righteousness, no one can weaken him. 37:24 For that reason people fear him; Indeed, all who are wise in heart fear him.
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Summary of 36:1-37:24

Elihu might sense that his auditors' patience is wearing thin (36:2a), yet he still “claims to be speaking on God's behalf (v. 2b)” (L. Wilson, 173), and he is still eager to trumpet his value as a source of wisdom (vv3-4). His train is thought, however, is by now familiar: God's great strength and intellect (v5) sees to it that the earth is ordered with entire justice (vv6-7), disciplining and reproving those who do wrong (vv8-10); the repentant he frees and blesses (v11), while the unrepentant face his wrath (vv12-14) (his wrath apparently being mediated by angels; v14b). Elihu is charitable enough to hold out the former category as a possibility for Job (vv15-16), but warns Job that, as he sees it, Job's wickedness has brought him to the cusp of disaster (v17). Job's (former!) wealth might lead to a false sense of security, but this misplaced trust in money, Elihu warns, must be avoided steadfastly (v18), along with reckless obstinacy and self-reliance (v19). Job must repent from, not seek solace from, deeps of darkness (vv20-21).

As a lengthy coda to his appeal to Job, Elihu emphasizes the overwhelming power of God and the unquestioning reverence due to him (36:22-37:24). Elihu's final words (“Indeed, all who are wise in heart fear him”; 37:24) contain a biting irony: By implication, these words call for Job to live of a life of reverence for God, as if that is what he has lacked; as if that is what will rescue him from his miseries—yet that is precisely what he had been doing when all his calamities came upon him (1:1ff)!

At long last, Elihu has finished speaking. And at long last, God himself has something to say.

Paraphrase of 38:1-39:30 Then the Lord, his voice sounding from a stormgale, responded to Job with these words: 38:2 Job, why are you muddying the waters, speaking of things you don't really understand? 38:3 By all means, get ready—take your best shot at teaching me how things ought to be!	Translation of 38:1-39:30 And Yahweh answered Job from a storm wind, and said, 38:2 Who is this obscuring counsel By words without knowledge? 38:3 Please gird up your loins like a man, That I may ask you, and you cause me to know.
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38:4 You talk as though you know everything, so would you be so kind as to tell me where you were when I created planet earth?

38:5 Since you have so many advanced degrees, tell me who determined the dimensions of the earth.

38:6 Tell me how stability was given to it, how it remains where it ought to be—

38:7 Tell me all about the time when heaven shook with the triumphant shout of the angels,

38:8 When the sea was placed within its bounds—when it made its grand entrance onto the stage,

38:9 When I covered it with a cloud, and clothed it with darkness,

38:10 When I gave it my orders, placing firm boundaries around it,

38:11 Announcing precisely where its pride would end, and the land would begin.

38:12 Have you, with all your power and might, been the ruler of daybreak, telling the sun where on the horizon to begin its ascent?

38:13 Did you at the same time shake out the earth like you would shake a rug, flinging off the wicked like bits of dirt in every direction?

38:14 Can you crush the unjust like you sear meat? Can you find them and pick them out like animal hairs of a piece of clothing?

38:15 Can you snuff out their existence, break their awful power?

38:16 Has your globetrotting brought you to the sources of water, to the deepest places of the ocean?

38:17 Have you discovered the door to the underworld, the entrance to the realm of shadows?

38:18 Have you figured out where, exactly, the earth has its end? Do you understand all these things?

38:19 Can you describe the location of light? Or are you able to identify the precise scope of darkness?

38:20 I ask because clearly you are the one who delivers darkness to its destination, showing it how to get where it needs to go.

38:21 You have this ability, because you possess the wisdom that comes from long existence.

38:22 Have your travels taken you to the place where snow and hail are stored,

38:23 Held in reserve for use on days of calamity and bloodshed?

38:24 Tell me just how the lightning bolts chart their course across the skies, or just how the wind wanders on its way.

38:25a Tell me how it is that the sea roars and the

38:4 Where were you when I founded the earth; Inform me, if you are acquainted with understanding.

38:5 Who set its dimensions, since you know? Or who stretched a line over it?

38:6 On what were its pedestals set into place? Or who cast its cornerstone [into its place]?

38:7 When the morning stars shouted together, And all the sons of God raised a shout;

38:8 And the sea was bound with doors, When it burst forth, going out from the womb,

38:9 When I made a cloud its covering, And swaddled it in darkness.

38:10 And I assigned over it my decree, Placing a bar and doors.

38:11 And I said, “Up to here you may come, and no further, “And here the exaltation of your waves will be broken.”

38:12 Has your right hand commanded the morning; Have you caused the dawn to know its place,

38:13 Seizing the ends of the earth So that the wicked could be shaken out from it?

38:14 Can you overturn [the wicked] like the clay of a seal, That they might present themselves like [grains of sand on a shaken] garment,

38:15 That light might be withheld from the wicked, And that the hand that is lifted up might be broken?

38:16 Have you traveled as far as the springs of the water, And have you explored the secrets of the deep?

38:17 Have the gates of death been revealed to you, And have you seen the gates of deep darkness?

38:18 Have you discerned the very ends of the earth? Inform [me], if you know all this.

38:19 Where is the realm which light inhabits? And darkness, where is its place?

38:20 For you take it to its border, And you discern the paths to its home.

38:21 You know, for you were born then, And the number of your days is many.

38:22 Have you traveled to the treasuries of the snow, And have you seen the treasuries of the hail,

38:23 Which I have withheld for the day of trouble, For the day of battle and of war?

38:24 Where indeed is the way where light is scattered, [Where] the east wind scatters over the earth?

38:25 Who has split a water course for the torrent,

thunder peels.

38:25b The truth is, Job, you've gone too far, speaking of things beyond your human understanding.

38:26-27 I send rain where no human eye ever sees it; parched deserts spring to life owing to my providence, despite the fact that no one even knows this is happening. So don't you see that I am fully present in the places where people do live?

38:28 You cannot explain what causes rain or dew to materialize.

38:29 You also cannot explain frost and snow,

38:30 When winter comes and lakes freeze over, enclosing their secrets beneath the ice.

38:31-32 It is not at your command that all the various constellations proceed across the night sky at the proper times.

38:33 You are not the one who governs the stars and planets, or the one who manages the gravitational pull of these bodies on the earth.

38:34 You cannot summon the stormcloud, engulfing the skies in darkness.

38:35 The lightning does not flash at your command; they are not your soldiers, doing your bidding.

38:36 I, not you, give the ibis its navigational skills and the rooster its understanding of daybreak.

38:37 I, not you, cause clouds to condense, cause rain to pour forth as from a bucket

38:38 When the dust coagulates, turns into mud.

38:39 You are not able to supply food for the prides of lions.

38:40 They take care of themselves, for they have been taught by me how to lie in ambush, using the surrounding plant life and terrain for their cover.

38:41 The ravens look to me for food as they wend their way through seemingly barren landscapes.

39:1 You do not know when the mountain goats give birth, nor care for the deer in labor.

39:2 You do not have a thorough grasp of their gestation periods or the timing of the birth.

39:3 They crouch down and deliver their young; out of their labor pains comes offspring.

39:4 The fawns are immediately strong, and rapidly grow still stronger; soon they are on their own, wandering free.

39:5 It is not mankind that made the wild donkey free from constraint.

39:6 I made him to be at home in the lonely wilderness, at peace in the salt flats.

39:7 He ridicules those noisy cities, and doesn't have

And the way for the thunder bolt,

38:26 Sending rain on a land where there are no people,

[On] a desert with no humanity in it,

38:27 Satisfying devastation and desolation, And causing grass to sprout.

38:28 Does the rain have a father?

Or who begat the drops of dew?

38:29 From whose womb came frost, And who bore the hoar frost of heaven?

38:30 [Hard] like a stone, the waters are hidden [beneath the sheet of ice on the surface], And the surface of the deep is bound together.

38:31 Can you bind the chains of Pleiades?

Or can you loose the chains of Orion?

38:32 Can you bring forth *Mazzaroth* in its season, And lead Leo with its children?

38:33 Do you cause the heavens to know [their] instructions?

Or do you appoint them as rulers over the earth?

38:34 Do you lift up your voice to the cloud,

And does the mass of waters cover you?

38:35 Do you send the lightning bolts, that they may go;

And do they say to you, "Here we are!"

38:36 Who put wisdom within the ibis?

Or who gave the rooster discernment?

38:37 Who brings down the clouds in [his] wisdom? And the vessels of heaven, who tilts them

38:38 When dust comes together, And clods stick together?

38:39 Can you hunt prey for the lioness, Or satisfy the appetites of young lions?

38:40 For they crouch in their lairs, Sitting in a thicket for cover for their ambush.

38:41 Who prepares for the raven its provisions? For its children cry out to the the Divine One, Wandering for lack of food.

39:1 Do you know the time of birth of the goats of the mountainside?

Do you watch when the does are in labor?

39:2 Do you count the months are they are fulfilled, Or do you know the time when they give birth?

39:3 They crouch down, and give birth; Their birth pangs they send forth.

39:4 Their children are strong; they grow strong in the open country;

They go out, and do not return to them.

39:5 Who sent the onager free,

the time of day for would-be masters.

39:8 He scouts out the mountains, making every grassy oasis his own.

39:9 The wild ox will not serve you or live in your barn.

39:10 You cannot tie it up and work your fields with it; it is much too strong.

39:11 You cannot reasonably think that your strength will be your security, guaranteeing you a plentiful harvest.

39:12 Your hopes that he would bring you wealth would be in vain.

39:13 The ostrich has every reason to flaunt her eye-catching wings—she’s as magnificent as a stork and as fast as a falcon!

39:14-18 Her speed has this significance: I have seemingly deprived her of intelligence, since, despite placing her eggs in the hot sand, rather than in some high place, she seemingly neglectfully runs off, “harshly” leaving them for animals to crush underfoot. It’s as if she doesn’t care about them, as if her carrying them meant nothing to her. Rising up, she flaps her wings, and as she runs off, her speed makes a mockery of the pursuing horseman, leaving her eggs safe.

39:19 You are not the one who gives a horse its strength, adorns him with a mane.

39:20 You do not make his charge into the ranks of enemy soldiers as overpowering as a locust swarm, his neighing as frightening as a lion’s roar.

39:21 He prances, showing off his strength, and goes bravely into battle.

39:22 He laughs in the face of danger; a brandished sword does not turn him away.

39:23 His rider shoots arrows or throws flashing spears.

39:24 He rushes excitedly across the earth and is unafraid at the commander’s trumpeted orders.

39:25 When he hears, “Charge!” he smiles; he looks forward to the clash of arms, to the princely struggle.

39:26 You do not teach the falcon to take the wing, to navigate across the skies.

39:27 You are not the one who sends the eagle to the heights; you do not teach the vulture to build his nest in a secure place.

39:28 He makes his home, day and night, on the mountain heights, on the jagged spikes of the rock.

39:29 From those perches his keen eye spies out prey from far away,

39:30 And his offspring have plenty of food to eat; no

And who loosed the bonds of the wild donkey,

39:6 For whom I made the desert his home, And the salt plain his dwelling place?

39:7 He laughs at the commotion of the city; The roar of the master he does not hear.

39:8 He explores the mountains as his pasturage, And he seeks out the remote portions of all green places.

39:9 Will the wild ox be willing to be your servant? Or will he spend the night over your manger?

39:10 Can you bind the wild ox to a furrow with its rope?

Or will he harrow the valleys after you?

39:11 Will you trust in him on account of his great strength,

And leave your produce to him?

39:12 Will you trust in him that he should return your harvest

And gather [the contents of] your threshing floor?

39:13 The wing of the ostrich is bedecked with joy. Is it the pinion of a stork or of a falcon?

39:14 For she leaves her eggs on the earth, And warms them on the dust,

39:15 And forgets that a foot might crush them, Or an animal of the field might trample them—

39:16 She treats harshly her children, as though they were not hers—

[Living] without fear as though her toil was nothing.

39:17 For God has caused her to forget wisdom, And has not apportioned discernment to her.

39:18 The moment she is elevated [above her nest] she flaps her wings;

She laughs at the horse and its rider.

39:19 Do you give strength to the horse?

Do you clothe his neck with a mane?

39:20 Do you cause him to rush onward like a locust swarm;

The splendor of his neighing is [a cause for] fear.

39:21 He paws in the valley, and rejoices in [his] strength;

He goes forth to meet [men in battle] equipment.

39:22 He laughs at fear and does not tremble, And does not turn back in the face of the sword.

39:23 Upon him the quiver rattles, [And] the flash of spear and javelin [goes forth].

39:24 In agitation and excitement he eats up the earth, And is wholly confident at the sound of the trumpet.

39:25 Whenever the trumpet sounds, he says, “Aha!”, And from a distance is pleased with [the prospect of

corpse escapes his attention.	imminent] battle, [At the prospect of] the thunder of princes [clashing] and of [battle] calls. 39:26 Is it on the basis of your discernment that the falcon can fly, Spreading his wings to the south? 39:27 Is it at your command that the eagle flies high, And the vulture makes his nest high? 39:28 On the cliff he dwells and spends the night, [And] on the tooth of cliff and mountain. 39:29 From there he searches out food; His eyes see [prey] from afar, 39:30 And his young ones slurp blood, And where the corpses are, there is he.
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Summary of 38:1-39:30

Apparently some kind of stormy blast descends upon the scene out which Yahweh finally speaks (38:1).

Yahweh begins by framing the discussion in which someone (Job) who knows little has—on the false notion that he knows much—observed the real issue(s) at stake (v2). Since Job has challenged God (e.g. 13:3), God now cues up Job to enlighten him on how the universe ought to be run (38:3). Yet even as God calls out Job for presumptuousness, he at the same time spares him: Rather than allow Job to speak immediately and no doubt humiliate himself, God asks Job a series of questions which by their very being asked remind Job of the infinite gulf between his knowledge and power and those of Yahweh. In God, grace and truth are friends (cf. Ps 85:10).

God questions Job concerning the formation of the earth and the sea (Job 38:4-11); the dawn (v12); the deep, watery places of the earth (v16) (one thinks of the water table, or of the cenotes of Mesoamerica); the realm of the dead (v17); the furthest reaches of the earth (v18); the extent of light and darkness (v19-21); the source of activities of meteorological phenomena (vv22-30); the heavenly bodies and their effects of the earth (vv31-33); the water cycle (vv34-38); and the diverse and mysterious operations of the animal kingdom, including lions (vv39-40), ravens (v41), mountain goats (39:1-4), wild donkeys (vv5-8), wild oxen (vv9-12), ostriches (vv13-18), horses (vv19-25), and birds of prey (vv26-30). At times Yahweh drops hints of larger concerns. For instance, Job manifestly cannot himself enact worldwide justice any more than he can command the dawn, so questions of fairness—of the kind he has often raised—are outside of his purview (38:12-15). In another example, the ostrich's way of distracting potential prey from the location of her eggs demonstrates that a *seeming* lack of care can mask the very *presence* of benevolent concern (39:13-18).

There are two notable things Yahweh has *not* said here: In a rebuke to Job, he has not provided specific reasons for what he has done in Job's life; and in a rebuke to Job's friends, he has not described a law of nature by which the wicked, and only the wicked, invariably face immediate and crushing discipline. We will elaborate on the significance of these two absences later on.

Next, God will hand the mic the Job.

Paraphrase of 40:1-2 Then the Lord said to Job, 40:2 Job, you have been seeking to set me straight. I am giving you a chance to speak: Reprove me, if you feel you are up to the task!	Translation of 40:1-2 And Yahweh answered Job and said, 40:2 Will he who contends with the Almighty be one bringing chastisement? Let him who reproves God answer it.
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Summary of 40:1-2

Job has been longing for a chance to challenge Yahweh face to face, and now it has arrived, though framed in a way that makes clear that it is folly to think that one can really show up the Almighty.

As it turns out, what Job will actually say now that his chance has come will be quite different from what he had planned.

Paraphrase of 40:3-5 In response to the Lord's words, Job said, 40:4 I'm so incredibly insignificant in comparison to you! I don't have anything to say by way of further complaint. 40:5 I've said a number of things, but I'm not going to press my case.	Translation of 40:3-5 And Job answered Yahweh and said, 40:4 Behold, I am nothing; what [answer] will I return to you? My hand I place on my mouth. 40:5 Once I have spoken, and I will not reply; Even twice, and I will not continue.
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Summary of 40:3-5

Job recognizes how infinitely small he is next to the infinite greatness of God, and wisely refrains from attempting some blistering reply (40:4). He owns up the fact that he has recently launched verbal volleys against Yahweh, but states that such madness will not continue.

Yet Yahweh perceives either that Job has not yet fully absorbed the implications of human limitations, or that Job's claim to have relented from questioning God's ways is at this point less than wholly sincere. Accordingly, "it will be necessary for Yahweh to continue his discourse to persuade Job to submit completely to his lordship" (Hartley, 518).

Paraphrase of 40:6-41:26 Then the Lord, still speaking from the midst of a stormgale, said to Job, 40:7 By all means, get ready—take your best shot at teaching me how things ought to be! 40:8 It is wrong for you to imply that I am unjust, and to represent your innocence as my guilt, 40:9 Nor is it true that your strength and authority are equal to mine. 40:10 But if you think otherwise, show your majestic splendor for all to see! 40:11 Righteously furious, send the wicked flying in every direction; find every oppressor, and break their power base. 40:12 Yes, find every oppressor, and bring them low! Also the evil—pulverize them right where they stand. 40:13 Put them all in the ground; seal their hellish fate. 40:14 Then I'll join the chorus singing your praises, because your own ingenuity will have saved you. 40:15 You are not the only outlet of my creative energies. Consider, if you will, the behemoth. He is an herbivore, just like an ox—yet how mighty he is! 40:16 Consider further the power in his thighs, in his mighty sinews. 40:17 When he moves his tail, it's like a cedar crashing down. His muscles are like finely crafted armor. 40:18 His bones are as strong as bronze, or even iron. 40:19 Foremost of my deeds, the behemoth can only	Translation of 40:6-41:26 And Yahweh answered Job from the storm wind, and said, 40:7 Please gird up your loins like a man, That I may ask you, and you cause me to know. 40:8 Will you indeed make my justice nothing? Will you make me out to be guilty so that you can be righteous? 40:9 Or do you have an arm like the Divine One, Or can you thunder with a roar like his? 40:10 Please, adorn yourself with exaltation and height, And clothe yourself with splendor and majesty! 40:11 Scatter arrogance with your anger, And observe every proud person, and bring them low. 40:12 Observe every proud person—[and] humble them! And crush the wicked where they stand. 40:13 Bury them in the dust together; Their persons bind in darkness. 40:14 And I, too, will acknowledge you, For your right hand has saved you. 40:15 Please behold the behemoth which I have made along with you; He eats greenery like an ox. 40:16 Please behold his strength in his loins, And his strength in the sinews of his belly. 40:17 He bends his tail like a cedar; The sinews of his thighs are knit together.
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be safely approached by me, his creator—and that with a weapon in my hands!

40:20 Everything green in the hill country is his tribute; all the animals of the field are his happy subjects.

40:21 He dips below the water plants, hiding in the reedy marshes.

40:22 There, beneath the riverine foliage and the trees, he is sheltered.

40:23 If the water level rises, he is not alarmed; he is unafraid, even if he has to swallow the whole river.

40:24 No one can snag him like a fish!

41:1 Speaking of fish, don't try going fishing for a leviathan, either. You won't be tying its tongue down with rope!

41:2 You can't put a reed through his nostrils or get a hook into his mouth!

41:3 He won't beg you for freedom, or whisper a plea for mercy.

41:4 He won't be striking a bargain with you, promising to be your perpetual servant.

41:5 You, for your part, won't be putting him in a cage like he's a bird, or making him a pet for your kids.

41:6 You won't see merchants negotiating, cutting him up to sell.

41:7 You won't bring him down with any onslaught of weapons.

41:8 I dare you, just reach out and touch him—I promise you won't make that mistake again!

41:9-10a The person who thinks he can master the leviathan is deluded—I am not going to let him get away with such foolishness! Go ahead and provoke his anger—you'll discover what a monster he can be!

41:10b-11 (But the leviathan does not stand on his own strength. He is answerable to me. No one has ever given me something I need, leaving me in their debt. Everything on earth belongs to me.)

41:12 I would be remiss not to mention his limbs; I must recount the well-founded reports about his beautiful, stunning design.

41:13 No one can peel away his armor, or pierce his double-layered protection.

41:14 No one can pry his jaws open; his teeth inspire terror.

41:15 His back is a series of shields, forming an impenetrable defense.

41:16-17 His scales overlap; you can't fit a piece of paper between them. They stay together, and cannot be separated.

40:18 His bones are tubes of bronze;
His bones are like rods of iron.

40:19 He is the first of the ways of the Divine One;
Let him who made him approach with his sword!

40:20 For the bounty of the mountains they bring to him,

And all the living things of the field play there.

40:21 Under the water shrubs he lies down,
In the secret place of reed and marsh.

40:22 The water shrubs cover him, [and] shade him;
River trees surround him.

40:23 If the river presses, he will not flee;
He is confident, even when a river rushes to his mouth.

40:24 Will one capture it by its eyes,
With traps one pierces its nose?

41:1 Can you draw out a leviathan with a fishhook,
Or hold down his tongue with a cord?

41:2 Can you put a reed in his nose,
Or pierce his cheek with a hook?

41:3 Will he multiply supplications to you?
Or will he speak softly to you?

41:4 Will he cut a covenant with you;
Will you acquire him as an age-long servant?

41:5 Will you make him an amusement, as with a bird,
Or put him in a cage for your children?

41:6 Will traders haggle over him?
Will they divide him among the merchants?

41:7 Will you fill his skin with harpoons,
Or his head with fishing spears?

41:8 Put your hand on him:
Remembering the battle, you will not do it again.

41:9 Behold, his hope is deceptive;
Will God grant his request?

41:10 How ferocious [he is] when one incites him!
(Yet whose is he? He stands before me.)

41:11 Who has [ever] anticipated my needs, that I might recompose him?
Everything under the heavens is mine.)

41:12 I will not keep silent about his limbs,
Or about the report of his might or about the grace of his orderly design.

41:13 Who has [ever] taken away his [scaly] clothing;
Through his double scale armor who can penetrate?

41:14 The doors of his mouth who can open;
Around his teeth is terror.

41:15 His back is grooves of shields,
Enclosed as a tight seal.

41:16 One [scale] approaches another,
And a breath cannot pass between them.

41:18 Fire bursts from his nostrils; his eyes blaze like the morning dawn. 41:19 He breathes fire, ringlets of flame. 41:20 Smoke billows from his nostrils as from a blazing furnace. 41:21 He can breathe coals to life with the flame that shoots from his mouth. 41:22 His neck is powerful; his movements are awe-inspiring. 41:23 There is no weak spot on his belly—he cannot be defeated. 41:24 Not even his head is a weak point; you could sooner smash the foundation of a building. 41:25 Warriors fear his pride, and cower in abject terror at the ruin his warmaking leaves in its wake. 41:26 No weapon of any kind will work against him. 41:27 He snaps iron weapons as if they were twigs; implements of bronze crumble like rotten wood. 41:28 Arrows do not cause him to retreat; stones from a sling are like chaff floating in the air. 41:29 A mace is nothing; a javelin only makes him smirk. 41:30 He is not even vulnerable underneath: His belly is sharp, leaving grooves as he slides through the mud. 41:31 When he is under water, things boil, froth, and turn black. 41:32 Behind him as he swims is a churning froth like the contrails of a jet in the sky. 41:33 No landlubber can boast his strength; the leviathan was born fearless. 41:34 He regards coolly every arrogant person; of all those who are proud, he is the king.	41:17 Each sticks to its neighbor; They are intertwined and do not separate. 41:18 His sneezes flash light, And his eyes are like the radiance of dawn. 41:19 From his mouth flames go forth, [And] sparks escape. 41:20 From his nostrils come smoke, Like [that from] a steaming pot and [from] coals. 41:21 His breath lights coals, And a flame comes from his mouth. 41:22 Strength dwells in his neck, And before him prances power. 41:23 The flesh of his belly sticks together; It is firm on him, and he is not moved. 41:24 His brain is as hard as a stone, And as firm as lower millstone. 41:25 Mighty men are afraid of his exaltation; Owing to his carnage, they are beside themselves. 41:26 If one brings a sword to him, it will not stand, [Neither will] spear, arrow, or javelin. 41:27 He considers iron to be straw, [And considers] bronze to be rotten wood. 41:28 No arrow will put him to flight; Sling stones thrown against him turn into chaff. 41:29 The cudgel is considered to be chaff, And he laughs at the quivering of the javelin. 41:30 Beneath him are sharp potsherds; He spreads out a threshing sledge upon the mud. 41:31 He makes the deep sea boil like a pot; The sea he makes like an ointment pot. 41:32 After him he lights up a path; One considers the deep to be a white-haired old man. 41:33 No one on the soil is his equivalent, This one who was made to know no fear. 41:34 He looks upon all exaltation; He is the king of all the sons of dignity.
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Summary of 40:6-41:34

Again Yahweh challenges Job to make good on his earlier bold claims (40:7), immediately pointing out in no uncertain terms the fact that Job has shown a willingness to maintain his own innocence in a way that paints *Yahweh* as the guilty party (v8); Yahweh nowhere in his two speeches depicts Job as an evil man—as Job's friends, along with Elihu, have done length and in cruel ways—but Job's innocence does *not* entail God's guilt. Job's power to dispense justice is manifestly *not* that of God (v9), and yet Job has been acting as if he himself can arbitrate God's rule over the earth (vv10-14).

To illustrate the exceedingly limited scope of Job's mastery over the universe, Yahweh turns, as he did before (38:4-39:30), to nature. He describes at length and with poetic genius two of the most remarkable creatures of ancient times, the behemoth (40:15-24) and the leviathan (41:1-10a, vv12-34). Within this second illustration Yahweh embeds a hint as to what he is driving at with these examples: If even the mightiest of Planet Earth's inhabitants are nothing more than Yahweh's servants, no one can expect to be add anything to the

Sovereign One (vv10b-11), much less to offer helpful correctives to his justice.

Whereas Zophar has given up on Job after two attempts, Eliphaz and Bildad have contend three times with Job to no effect, and Elihu has lashed out *four* times with still less success (Job does not even answer him), it is Yahweh (who speaks three times; or, if, one sets aside 40:2, which is both brief and, in a sense at least, an invitation for Job to speak speaks, only *two* times) who finally brings about a resolution to Job's crisis; of this resolved state of mind Job will next speak.

Paraphrase of 42:1-6	Translation of 42:1-6
In response to the Lord's words, Job said, 42:2 This truth sinks into my soul in a new way: You are all-powerful, and never-thwarted. 42:3 You found it necessary earlier to ask, "Job, why should you be muddying the waters, speaking of things you don't really understand?" It is now clear to me that my earlier words addressed things far beyond my understanding. 42:4 You also issued me this challenge: "By all means, get ready—take your best shot at teaching me how things ought to be!" 42:5-6 I completely relent from my earlier challenge. And here is the reason: Whereas formerly I—a mortal, here on this earth only for a brief time—had a distant, vague knowledge of you, now I grasp you with a new immediacy. You yourself are enough for me; I do not need to correct you.	And Job answered Yahweh and said, 42:2 I know that you are omnipotent, And no purpose will be withheld from you. 42:3 "Who is this darkening counsel without knowledge?" So then, I spoke, and did not understand, [Meddling in] things too wondrous for me, and I did not know [what I was saying]. 42:4 "Please listen, and I will speak; I will ask you, and you will cause me to know." 42:5 By the hearing of the ear I had heard [of] you, But now my eye sees you. 42:6 Therefore I recant and repent, A child of dust and ashes.

Summary of 42:1-6

"Job changes his mind about... his desire for personal vindication. His new understanding of God practically obliterates any need for a public declaration of his innocence. It is enough for him to stand in right relationship with this sovereign God, who is so far beyond human knowing..." (G. Wilson, 468). Job fully accepts God's unconstrained control over all things (42:2). He quotes (v3a) God's earlier characterization of him as someone speaking of things he did not truly understand, and agrees that he was out of bounds in doing so (3b); he also quotes (v4) God's challenges for him to make his case for vindication, only to decline the opportunity with all humility (v6) in view of the new degree to which he has come to hold God in awe (v5).

That last-cited verse requires some reflection. v5a seems not to be literal (that is, Job had not at some prior point audibly heard God's voice), so v5b is probably not literal either—especially since God is not said to have *appeared* out of the storm, but only to have *spoken* (38:1). Job never needed, and knows now that he never needed, a visual encounter of God as such; what matters in 38:1-42:6 is not so much the sensory experience of hearing God speak (as remarkable as that must have been), but that in it Job comes to a renewed sense of being satisfied in Yahweh's sovereignty.

God has spoken. The poems come now to an end, but a prose epilogue will inform us as to what happens next.

Paraphrase of 42:1-7	Translation of 42:7-17
Having said this to Job, Yahweh turned his attention to Eliphaz. "I'm angry with you," he said. "And I'm angry with Bildad and Zophar as well, because, unlike my servant Job, you have not spoken rightly about me. 42:8 So then, take seven bulls and seven rams, go to	And it came about after Yahweh had spoken these words to Job that Yahweh said to Eliphaz the Temanite, "My anger burns against you and against your two friends, for you have not spoken about me what is right like my servant Job. 42:8 And now, take

my servant Job, and offer these animals as a sacrifice on your behalf while my servant Job prays for you. I tell you, I will answer his prayer, and forbear from chastising you for your foolish misrepresentation of me.” **42:9** So Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar went and did what Yahweh had commanded, and Yahweh listened to Job's prayer. **42:10-12** Now, Yahweh granted a restoration to Job when he prayed for his friends; indeed, he showered on Job twice as much as he had before: 14,000 sheep and goats, 6,000 camels, 1,000 teams of oxen, and 1,000 donkeys. All Job's siblings and friends from years gone by came, fellowshipped with him in his home, and offered their sympathies for all the hardship that the Lord had caused Job to go through. In addition, they all gave Job a certain amount of money, and some valuable jewelry. **42:13** Job had seven sons and three daughters. **42:14** He named the first daughter Jemimah, the second Qetsiah, and the third Qeren-Hapukh. **42:15** No one in all the land was as beautiful as Job's daughters, and he gave them an inheritance in addition to his sons. **42:16** Job lived for 140 years after these events, and he was around to enjoy four generations of children and grandchildren. **42:17** Then he died, having lived a long, full life.

for yourselves seven bulls and seven rams, and go to my servant Job, and offer them as a burnt offering in your places, while my servant Job prays over you. Surely I will accept his request not to do with you in accordance with you foolishness—for you have not spoken of me what is right like my servant Job.” **42:9** And Eliphaz the Temanite, and Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar the Naamathite went and did as Yahweh had spoken to them, and Yahweh accepted Job's request. **42:10** And Yahweh restored what Job had lost when he prayed on behalf of his friends, and Yahweh added to Job double [his former possessions]. **42:11** And all his brothers and all his sisters and all who knew him formerly came to him, and ate bread with him in his house, and showed sympathy for him, and comforted him over all the calamity that Yahweh had brought upon him; and each gave to him a *qesitah* and a gold ring. **42:12** And Yahweh blessed the latter part of Job's life more than the former, and he had 40,000 members of his flock, and 6,000 camels, and 1,000 yoke of oxen, and 1,000 donkeys. **42:13** And he had seven sons and three daughters, **42:14** and he called the name of the first Jemimah, and the name of the second Qetsiah, and the name of the third Qeren-Hapukh; **42:15** and there were not found in all the land women as beautiful as the daughters of Job, and their father gave them an inheritance in the midst of their brothers. **42:16** And Job lived after this 140 years, and he saw his sons and his sons' sons to four generations. **42:17** And Job died old and full of years.

Summary of 42:7-17

God turns from Job to the three friends (42:7). “Speaking only to Eliphaz, but including in the indictment Bildad and Zophar,” God indicts them for “misrepresented him” (Alden, 411; the manner in which they have done so, and Elihu’s role in the book, will be sketched under the section “Considering the Message of Job”).

Job, on the other hand, is upheld. In the midst of his loss and agony, Job had certainly felt, and had frequently expressed, great indignation against God (7:11ff., 9:2ff, etc.). And yet “God... reads between the lines and listens to the heart” (Kidner, 73; quoted in Ash, 429), and what God hears in Job's heart is a persevering faith—battered, bruised, almost breaking, but faith nonetheless (cf. Jm 5:11, “You have heard of the endurance of Job”). Indeed, Job’s standing as God’s honored servant becomes once again clearly apparent, for Yahweh will refer to Job as “my servant” (a “title of honor” [L. Wilson, 207]) four times in this passage, twice as often as in the entire prologue.

While the three friends face rebuke, they are not humiliated or cast aside; even here, the truth of the gospel comes into view, for, an atonement having been provided, forgiveness bears fruit among an undeserving humanity (Job 42:8-9).

Then comes a twist which must have caught Job by surprise—God chooses to restore prosperity to Job, even increasing it from what it was before (vv10, 12); prompting people who had been ignoring him to offer comfort for his trauma (v11); and giving him more children (v13), including some remarkable daughters (vv14-15a) whom he treated remarkably (v15b). And these were no passing joys, for he was permitted to enjoy

his family for an extraordinarily long time (v16), dying in peace (v17).

Considering the Message of Job

Job begins the story as a person who possesses both wealth and integrity. While his wealth will soon vanish before his eyes, his integrity remains with him. Indeed, Job's integrity is crucial to understanding the book. Job's friend will cling to it; God will affirm and reaffirm it; Job's friends will doubt it and attack it; Satan will not doubt it, but will question its basis.

That last point both lays the groundwork for the unfolding plot and drastically raises the stakes. It lays the groundwork for the plot in that Satan, thinking that Job's integrity is disingenuous, successfully petitions to have everything in Job's life come crashing down around him. It raises the stakes in that Job's test is really *God's* test: God is the one who cites Job's worship of him, and Satan responds by claiming that those who are faithful to God only do so because they receive good things from God in return. God's children, Satan sneers, don't love *God*—they only love his *gifts*.

Job becomes a test case. But in order for the experiment to truly work, he cannot know that he is being tested in this way. Readers of the book of Job can see the significance of the drama, but Job himself is in the dark. As calamity after calamity befalls Job, he refuses to respond to God with hate. But his pain and confusion is great, so much so that he expresses a wish that he had never been born.

Three of Job's friends—Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar—having come to comfort Job in his grief, hear his bitter cry. They attempt to clarify for Job the cause of and the solution for Job's problems. But the principles on which they offer their diagnosis and prognosis can only be described as malpractice. In their minds, God is a machine programmed to give certain outputs in response to certain inputs. If a human inputs good deeds, the output is prosperity; if a human inputs evil deeds, the output is calamity (cf. Ash, 96). Seeing the calamities that have befallen Job, the three friends can only infer that some grievous pattern of sin has triggered this cause from God. Job's only hope, then, is to switch his input into the divine machine from wickedness and obstinance to goodness and repentance. Only then will the gears in heaven begin to manufacture a pleasant future for Job.

Job will have none of this. It is wrong in his case, for he knows in his heart of hearts that he is not the reprobate the others assume he must be. It is wrong in many other cases as well, for as Job considers the matter, his mind reels at the truth that many of the wicked prosper, and many of the righteous suffer.

But as passionately as Job rejects his friends' view of how God works, he has no alternative to propose. So Job flounders as he finds himself unable to account not only for his own personal suffering, but for global suffering as well. Most of all, he flounders as he experiences a new and profound emotional disconnection from God. He feels God's control, but not his care; he knows God's power, but not his presence. Repeatedly Job bewails God's apparent injustice and unapproachability, and declares an unshakeable, indestructible faith in him. It is not that Job vacillates between these two opinions, loving God one moment, and doubting him the next. Rather, he holds these views simultaneously. This cognitive dissonance is the possession of all Christians during their earthly sojourn, but especially of whose hearts are decreed to be pierced by great suffering, of those whose minds are designed to contain the pain of the global poor, or (as in Job's case) those whose spirits are destined to contain both.

Even as Job protests against and yearns for God, he continues to fend off repeated attacks from Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar. Only after many tempestuous rounds of argument do the three men give up, nothing really having been settled.

In the face of this impasse, a new character, Elihu, appears on the scene. "The effect of the lead-in [with which Elihu begins his first speech] is to generate suspense, as we are led to wonder whether Elihu will accomplish more than the three friends have accomplished... The suspense... is quickly answered when it is obvious that Elihu, despite his earlier put-down of the three friends' thinking, repeats their arguments" (Ryken and Ryken, 727-728; cf. Alden, 314). If there is a new twist to the argumentation, it is that Job needs not merely confession of his alleged guilt, but angelic intervention. Such is ironic indeed, since it was in the context of an angelic gathering that Job's trials came about. Moreover, while Scripture elsewhere indicates that God sometimes mediates his benefits through angels (e.g., Ac 12:11, Mat 24:31), God will quite directly restore Job (42:10), and the veneration of angels is discouraged (e.g., Col 2:18) In any case, Elihu, for all his vaunted wisdom, is more of

a hindrance than a help.

Then God speaks. In the face of all of Job's anguish and all of his questions, it is remarkable that God promises neither an end to Job's suffering nor answers to Job's questions. But in fact, by withholding those things, and by reproving Job for talking as though the creature knew more about justice than the Creator, God is providing Job an opportunity to do something remarkable—to simply trust him. “Genuine faith is more valuable to God than gold [1 Pet 1:7] because he is a God who delights in being trusted” (Grudem, 69).

And that is just what Job does: Content *not* to expect improvements in his appalling circumstances, content *not* to know just why God has acted and acts as he does, Job declares that simply being in a relationship with God is enough. While Job's definitive statement to this effect comes in 42:2-6, the seeds of this flower of faith are scattered throughout his speeches—even, if not especially, when he wrestles most with what is happening in the world. “Next to Jesus, Job must surely be the greatest *believer* in the whole Bible” (Andersen, 293). For him, God is no manipulable machine, no abstract principle, no unfeeling force; but a person, someone he could not live without, someone he would forever live with. And so it is generous, but not disingenuous, when God says that Job “has spoken... what is right” (42:8). Through Job's great faith, Satan is defeated and God is vindicated. Contrary to what Satan wanted to believe, God is not the kind of God whose children worship him simply because he gives them nice things. He is worshiped for *himself*.

Inasmuch as God in his sovereignty is under no external obligation to give anyone anything, and inasmuch as Job is wholly sincere in expressing no need beyond having a relationship with God, it is evidence that “God is very affectionate and loving” (Jm 5:11; the Greek *αγαπᾷ* there I take to be a calque of רחום) when he proceeds to give Job material prosperity and new children (see further G. Wilson, 469-470, 477). Furthermore, God reproves Eliphaz (as the leader of the group of friends, do doubt), yet also provides a means of atonement. (Elihu is neither condemned nor commended, his role evidently being inconsequential; perhaps his youthful impetuosity is graciously passed over in silence.) Finally, the balance of Job's lifespan is a peaceful and prosperous one, a foreshadowing of the Sabbath rest that will eternally comfort and renew those whose earthly lives are spent in toil and tribulation, whose hope is set on God when all seems hopeless.

Job deserves our admiration, and we can and must learn from him. Negatively, we must avoid impugning God, or setting our own notions about justice above his. Positively, we must follow Job's example of avoiding mechanistic explanations about how God works. We must be concerned for the good of others, and be honest in everything. Above all, we must cling to God in fierce faith no matter the cost.

But there is also someone else who must be mentioned here—someone from whom every friend (even those he had invested in the most), every possession (including his very clothes) was taken away, someone whose most urgent question (“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”) was not answered during his life, yet nevertheless gave himself to God (“Father, into your hands I commit my spirit”). “In the darkness and God-forsakenness of those terrible hours of lonely agony [on the cross], the sufferings of Job are transcended and fulfilled. And as the blameless believer accused and despised by men but finally vindicated by God in the resurrection, Jesus fulfills the drama and longings of Job for justification” (Ash, 436). It is fitting, then, that simple faith in this Jesus, who trusted the Father so fully, secures our justification (Rom 3:21-26). It is fitting, too, that this one who is greater than Job made a sacrifice not of seven bulls and seven rams (Job 42:8), but of himself (Heb 10:10); and he made this sacrifice not for wrongheaded words from friends in a heated argument, but for the constant and grievous sin of enemies (Jn 1:29, Rom 5:10). God loves us despite what we have done; we love God for who he is. So it was with Job, and so it is with every saint.

Additional Notes

At the risk of oversimplifying, the four friends can be thought of in these terms: Eliphaz is a gentle, wise man trying to mentor someone younger; Bildad is “Mr. Blunt”; Zophar can be harsh, but is also trying to be helpful; and Elihu is the guy who is impatient with the inability of the older generation to get things right.

1:3 The Hebrew for “flock” (צֹאן) is ambiguous as to whether sheep, goats, or a mix of the two meant.

1:5 Here (and also in v11, 2:5, v9), the word “bless” in its context clearly means the exact opposition, viz. “curse.” But the notion of cursing God was so abhorrent that it was not spoken of directly; instead, the concept was hidden behind a euphemism.

1:6 The sons of God “are the celestial beings or angels whom God created as his servants” (Hartley, 71).

1:6 “The adversary” (השטן) is what Satan's name (שטן; in the New Testament, Σατανας) means. Probably the title came first, in time becoming a name.

1:15 Sheba is an Arabian people.

1:15, 16, 17 The “young men” are workers in Job's employ (cf. Ruth 2:5, 9).

2:8 Potsherds were the ancient equivalent of trash, being broken fragments (of all shapes and sizes) of the various household items made of pottery littered all over any ancient settlement, though mainly (one hopes) in the communal dump.

2:10 Job's words to his wife are not overly harsh. “In kindness he does not actually call her a foolish woman. But he says that what she has suggested is not worthy of her. Hers is the suggestion that you would expect from a fool. She has spoken under stress, as if she were foolish” (Ash, 53).

2:11-13: It might seem natural to connect this material more closely with 1:1-2:10 than with 3:1ff. Such a division is valid insofar as 1:1-2:13 is (predominantly) prose, while 3:1-42:6 is poetry (aside from brief introductions, such as 3:1). However, (1) the best Hebrew manuscripts lack a paragraph break between 2:13 and 3:1; (2) these manuscripts employ a different type of paragraph division between 3:1 and 3:2 than they do between 1:22 and 2:1; and (3) various literary indicators (for instance, the echo of 1:22 in 2:10) make the text unit 2:1-10 answer to 1:6-22 (1:1-5 being an introductory setting of the stage before the two accounts of disaster that follow). The material in 2:11-13, while indeed reinforcing the depth of the tragedy, has as its primary literary function a segue into the body of the work in which the three friends will dispute with Job the meaning and proper response to God's actions in 1:6-2:10.

2:11 The identity of these men is quite unclear. Scholars down through the ages have attempted to fill out their backstory, but almost nothing is certain. From what is said by and about them in the book of Job, it is inferable that they were notably wealthy, more or less elderly men with a reputation for wisdom.

3:8 Those Job wishes would curse the day of his birth are those who are as theologically reckless as it would be physically reckless to provoke the anger of a ferocious beast (cf. 41:1ff). (Job thus indirectly acknowledges that it is wrong for him to speak this way about God's deeds, or at least creates tension along these lines; yet the depths of his despair lead him to feel more or less justified in speaking in such appalling language.)

3:14 In the ancient Middle East (particularly in Mesopotamia), it was a point of pride for kings to rebuild cities that had been destroyed or had fallen into disrepair.

3:16 That the lack of existence Job ascribes to a miscarried child and wishes for himself is not absolute lack of existence is shown by the context, for in the preceding lines he imagines his death placing himself in the company of kings and princes (not of endless shapeless nothingness). Other biblical descriptions of death point in the same direction: If death brings rest in some sense (Job 3:13), it nevertheless entails such things as consciousness (Isa 14:9-10, Lk 16:23) and cognizance of events of the past (Isa 14:12-17, Lk 16:25). This clarification is salutary for at least two reasons: (1) That there are consequences for one's actions that transcend this life is a call for immediate reconciliation with God; and (2) those who do not survive until or long past childbirth are nonetheless people who will, along with kings and princes, populate the afterlife, and their full and unending humanity has implications for social justice (viz., that the rights of the unborn should be respected).

3:18 It seems that Job would have taken a dim view of mass incarceration.

4:3a The positive kind of reproof that seeks to deter someone from a path that will ultimately lead to their own destruction (cf., e.g., Pr 3:12, 19:25, 25:12).

5:7 Resheph was an ancient false god, apparently associated with fire. Since Eliphaz elsewhere seems to be a monotheist, this is probably a figure of speech, rather as (for many) the words “good luck” are not an appeal to a powerful but capricious force actually at work in the universe, but simply a traditional way of expressing a hope things turn out well for the one these words are spoken to.

5:11 Incidentally, this verse suggests that Isa 40:4 is a figure of speech.

5:23 The idea of a covenant with the stones of the field is obscure. Perhaps “stones of the field” is a euphemism for spirits that do, or are thought by Eliphaz to, inhabit the rocky wilderness of Uz. Or perhaps the idea is that stones will not interfere with the planting and growth of his crops (Hartley, 127).

6:1 “In v.1 Job ‘answered’ in the sense of ‘responded,’ not necessarily answering every matter raised by Eliphaz” (L. Wilson, 55).

6:8 The content of Job's wish is unclear. Andersen (137) thinks that Job “still wishes to die” (and so most commentators); in that case, the first part of v10 should be translated something like, “So may God will to crush me.” But although Job feels exceedingly weak (e.g., v11) and hopeless (e.g., 7:21b), he still longs for joy from God (6:10a-b), confesses his allegiance to God (v10c), and means to continue making his case (7:11). So much so that if the majority opinion is correct that Job in our verse longs for death, this longing begins, almost as soon as it is uttered, to transform into a firm resolve to seek out an answer he can be satisfied with. Job has not given up.

7:7 Since Hebrew verbs convey how many people are spoken to or about than most English verbs do, the original text of Job is at times clearer than the English translation. In this case, the Hebrew verbs in the prior section clearly address Job's friends, but here there is a shift that indicates that he is talking to God.

7:12 Instead of “Yam,” it is possible that the correct translation is “the sea.” Yam was a false god whose name means “Sea”; the great waters of the Mediterranean were at any rate an ominous sight to many in the ancient Levant. Job is very clearly a monotheist who believes in Yahweh, so if I am right in translating “Yam,” this is a figure of speech (cf. on 5:7 above).

7:17 Job seems to have in mind Gen 1:26ff and/or Ps 8:4ff, or at least the truths that lie behind those passages.

7:21 In light of Job’s constant and strident protestations of innocence (and particularly statements like those in 1:1 and 42:7), this verse cannot be an admission that he has been in the wrong all the time. Rather, Job readily agrees with the proposition that all men sin (cf., e.g., Ecc 7:20), but is well aware that God in his mercy constantly forebears from bringing a railing judgment against every failure (cf., e.g., Rom 2:4).

9:13 On “Rahab” see the Additional Note on 26:12.

9:20 Or possibly, “Behold, I am righteous” or “I am indeed righteous”: I wonder whether אֲנִי can (in the book of Job, at any rate) be a synonym of הֵן (via influence of the Aramaic הֵן?) and/or be an asseverative particle (by way of idiomatic simplification of לֹא אֲנִי, comparable to the English expression “I could care less”). Other notable verses in this book in this connection are 7:4, 8:4, v18, 9:19, v23, 11:14, 14:5, v8, 19:5, 21:6, 30:24, 38:4, v18 (this verse and the previous being ironic in tone), 42:8.

9:24 Elsewhere (not least in this same speech), Job ascribes all power to God, so it is hardly plausible to see Job as doubting whether God is really in control. Rather, with his rhetorical question Job is bringing into sharp focus precisely the point that God is wholly sovereign. Job would not be satisfied with any attempt to solve the problem of evil ascribing evil in the world to evil forces acting in a way that is fundamentally independent of God.

9:25 Job’s life was unusually long for a human, yet for *any* human life tends to roll on faster than expected and with fewer successes than expected (cf. the book of Ecclesiastes *passim*).

9:26 Papyrus boats were used in ancient Egypt.

9:31 There might be a reference to Jewish law here, where contact with the dead (which is what is signified by “the pit”) would render one unclean, and clothing can similarly be contaminated.

10:6-7 It is difficult to follow Job’s train of thought here. Another notable approach to paraphrase “Even though you know that I am not a man bent on sin, you insist on minutely examining [and severely punishing] my [every] sin, and leave me without hope of deliverance.” The logic would then be that “God has entirely too much time on his hands... To while away the eons of divine life, God spends his days and years probing into the... [iniquity] of his creatures” (G. Wilson, 103); Job does not question the presence of sin in his life (cf. 13:26), but maintains that God is acting out of all proportion.

10:10 It’s not altogether certain that Job is thinking as specifically as the paraphrase would indicate, but there’s at least a good case to be made for this understanding of his words.

10:21-22 What the ancient people of God knew about life after death is a difficult question to tease out from the various texts that touch on the topic, such as this one. Here the emphasis is clearly on the distressing abnormality of the thought of a human being separated from God’s good earth by death. In fact, such a negative view of death is a prerequisite for a full appreciation of the blessings of those whom God will raise to life on the last day.

11:9 I have little idea what Zophar is referring to here—some sort of (meta)physical realm of which Sheol is a member?

12:4 The Hebrew word translated here “only to be afflicted by him” (וְיַעֲנֶהוּ) is a wordplay, being on the page identical to and to the ear similar to a Hebrew word which conventionally would be expected after “calling” (קָרָא) to God and would mean “and he answered him.” This verbal sleight of hand directs listeners’ attention to the fact that God’s response is exactly the opposite from what should be expected. Such are Job’s feelings.

12:16 The second line bespeaks God’s absolute sovereignty over even error, and not only over error, but over malicious intent (cf. Gen 50:20).

12:19 In many cultures, including some with which Job and his friends would have been familiar, priests occupy positions of prestige. This part of the verse, then, is making much the same point as the surrounding material: Even those who seem too well-placed to suffer harm or dishonor God in his omnipotence makes a habit of bringing low.

14:9 In Job’s culture plantations were not (ordinarily) powered by race-based chattel slavery as in the antebellum United States. That said, the wickedness of the human heart has a long history, and, whether racism played a central role or not, certainly many landowners in ancient days engaged in exploitative and oppressive activities.

14:14 Job here speaks of the normal state of affairs—very rarely indeed to this point has a human being, once dead, stood up again. He is not here contemplating what God will do in the future (contrast 19:25ff).

14:15 It is one of the core practices of the United States military, inculcated into its soldiers from the beginning of their service, that a man or woman assigned to a post must never leave that post until it is properly handed over to authorized individuals. This is the imagery that Job uses: He is a soldier who will not budge until his relief comes—which is to say, until God provides him with the answers to which he feels entitled.

15:4 Christians have a long history of seeing in behavioral practices or theological positions of other Christians a “tendency” toward a diminished view of God. Often they, like Eliphaz, have been well-intentioned yet off base in such assessments. Accordingly, Christians ought to ponder Scripture long and hard before they forecast negative outcomes for the

approaches taken by other believers.

16:21 It is possible that for “son of Adam” (בן אדם) one should render more simply “human being”; in other words, whether Job is familiar with the historical Adam is not quite certain. That said, I think that 31:33 makes it probable that Job is aware of the man Adam.

16:19-20 Some argue that the witness that Job appeals to is *not* God (e.g., G. Wilson, 182-183; L. Wilson, 97-98), but I hold that the witness *is* God (cf., e.g., Andersen, 197-198; Ash, 193). Among the reasons for thinking this is that for Job to appeal to some mediator other than God himself would be to cede the field to what Elihu will later argue, but Elihu’s argument will in no way be endorsed when Yahweh speaks. Job “is not essentially pitting God against God; rather, he is affirming genuine confidence in God regardless of the way it appears that God is treating him. Since Job, in contrast to his friends, will not concede that truth is identical with appearances, he presses on for a true resolution to his complaint from God himself (Hartley, 264).

18:15 Lilith was (is?) a demon of the night.

19:15 By “sojourners,” Job means those who are not part of his country or culture but for one reason or another (for example, they might be merchants, buying products from one culture to sell to another; or they might be refugees escaping famine, political turmoil, or some other crisis). These people Job welcomed into his home to give them shelter and food (as he states more directly in 31:12).

19:23-24 While the first part of v23 allows for the possibility that Job wishes for his words to be written with ink on a scroll (the closest ancient equivalent to the later book), in the rest of this passage it becomes clear that what Job wishes is for his words to be incised with a chisel or similar tool into the face of a cliff. This wish might have been inspired by the Behistun Inscription (which Darius the Great carved into the side of a cliff), or by similar monuments elsewhere. At any rate Job longs for a permanent, public testament to the (perceived) miscarriage of justice he faced.

19:26 As with numerous verses in Job, this verse is very difficult to understand, so any translation or interpretation must be somewhat provisional. I think that in this verse Job speaks of a day after the loss of his *present* body on which he will see God; it is beyond his purposes (and possibly his understanding) here to speak to the theological question of whether it will be in *some* body (and if so, what relation that body will bear to his prior body) that he will see God. (The premiere text of resurrection is 1 Corinthians chapter 15, but Job obviously did not have that passage at his disposal.)

19:27 Job does not mean that he *alone* out of all humanity will see God on the last day (cf. Andersen on this passage). Rather, he uses intense language here to highlight what is uppermost in his mind: For Job, it is immeasurably reassuring that *Job* will one day stand before his redeemer. The last part of the verse is, I think, Job’s version of “Woe is me, for I am undone!” (Isa 6:5).

20:24 Literally, “serpentine bow.” See Pinker, Aron, “On the meaning of קשת נחוש,” *The Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol. 5, article 12.

21:4 Alternatively, “Or why do I not lose heart?” The difference lies in whether one construes לא as asseverative or as negative.

21:31-33 It is also possible that the quotation that began in v27 should include these verses as well.

22:18 It is possible that Eliphaz is quoting Job’s words in 21:16. (Ancient Hebrew lacks quotation marks, so it is often difficult in the book of Job to know whether someone is speaking for himself or putting words in another man’s mouth.) But it seems to fit the context better to see here an example of a phenomenon that is common in the poetry of predominantly oral cultures, viz. the use, often in varying contexts, of set phrases and lines. In other words, Job in 21:16 and Eliphaz in 22:18 are both making use of a snatch of poetry well-known to and often used by many poets of their day.

23:2 Or, “My hand is heavy on account of my sighing,” i.e. “I feel so [physically] weak because of my [psychological] distress.”

24:10 The second half of the verse depicts a situation like that seen in the book of Ruth, with many people unable to meet their own needs and consequently forced to engage in the (legal, but undignified) activity of gathering surplus grain from the fields of the more fortunate.

24:12 This verse assumes a socio-economic context in which the desperately poor were generally to be found *outside* city limits (cf. vv5, 8), whereas such individuals are in the modern United States most often to be found *within* city limits.

25:4 The words “born of a woman” are not *necessarily* sexist; probably the intent is merely poetic (viz., kenning and/or filling out the meter with a two-word label for a human being as such). That said, respect for others does not seem to be Bildad’s greatest strength.

26:4 Regarding “And whose spirit has gone out on your account?”: I have tentatively understood “spirit” here as human resolve; hence my paraphrase “Nobody is frightened, either.” But the word is often thought to refer to supernatural inspiration, in which case a literal translation would be “And the spirit of whom has gone out from you?”; a paraphrase could then be, “Just whose spirit has gone out from you?” In the latter case, Job seems to suggest demonic influence on Bildad’s discourse. The former understanding seems to me to fit the context better, however.

26:6 The first line of the verse is possibly alluded to in Heb 4:13. Abaddon is Hebrew for “destruction,” and is a synonym

for Sheol / Death. (In Rev 9:11, the same Hebrew word occurs as the name of a monstrous king.)

26:9 God frequently obscured himself from view by means of a dark cloud (e.g., Ex 19:16). Who, after all, bears in themselves the right to look upon holy God?

26:12 Rahab (which, in Hebrew, is different from, and therefore not to be confused with, the Rahab of Josh 2:1ff) is evidently the name of a sea monster (or demon) whom God had in ancient times defeated (e.g., Ps 89:10).

26:13 The first line is obscure. The second line speaks of another victorious struggle with some terrible beast (perhaps Satan himself; cf., e.g., Gen 3:1ff, Rev 20:2).

27:1 Possibly the declamation which Job continues is that found in 3:1-26, but probably it is more correct to say that it is a continuation of his reply to Bildad (based on its juxtaposition with it and in view to the degree to which in 27:1ff Job interacts with what his friends said *after* chapter 3). That said, Job is not *only* replying to Bildad, but summing up with a reply to all three friends and his case to (against?) God.

Since there are *three* sets of attacks and rebuttals between Job and Eliphaz and between Job and Bildad, but only *two*, between Job and Zophar, some commentators have supposed that the text of the book of Job has been damaged, with some material lost and/or misplaced. There is no documentary evidence for the presence of a third Zophar/Job interchange, however, so such is only speculation. Moreover, the notable brevity of Bildad's final speech (25:1-6) suggests a gradual dropping off of the friends' energy, such that the absence of a third speech from Zophar is not really surprising.

27:2 To say something like "as God lives" in Hebrew underscores the truth of what the speaker is about to say (in this case, that Job will forever maintain that he is innocent—see vv4-6) by typing it to the eternal existence of God. Here Job shows an alertness to irony when he embeds within the oath formula descriptors of God as the one who had harassed and embittered him.

27:3 By "the spirit of God" Job probably does not mean to say that the Holy Spirit lives within him, but simply that by God's empowerment he is still alive: The Hebrew word here translated "spirit" can also mean "wind" or "breath," and the parallel line speaks of Job's own life as still existing. We should, then, be cautious about ascribing to Job on the basis of this verse certain developed tenets of pneumatology (though perhaps in a sense he is speaking more truly than he knows). (He speaks of this spirit that God has gifted him as being in his nose because it is through the nostrils that one principally intakes oxygen.)

27:8ff An alternative approach to the one sketched in the "Summary" section above is this: Job *does* accept that the obstinately wicked (of whom he is not one) bring upon themselves a terrible fate (but he denies that he is one of their number). Or it can be supposed that this section (if it begins with v7) is "an imprecation, not a statement of fact" (Andersen 237). In this connection, the words of Andersen concerning the frequent surface similarity of Job's words to the friends' words can be cited: "The gulf between Job and his colleagues is more than it appears, because their formal theological agreements are extensive. They concur completely in the supreme truth that God is sovereign.... Yet Job's thought is on a different level than theirs, even if it has the same formal expression when it comes to the character of God in his dealings with men" (136-137).}

27:11 Job "adopts an instructive disposition similar to the style of his friends" (Hartley, 371), as if so say "I can play this game too," or, "Listen, friends, to what you sound like."

27:12 The interpretation of this line is complicated in part by the lack of an expressed object for the verb "seen." Also, Hebrew does not have parentheses, so while I have used them in my translation in view of what seems to be Job's train of thought (see Summary of 27:1-28:28 above), it must be borne in mind that it is quite possible to translate this verse without parentheses enclosing it.

28:1-28 It is sometimes said that this poem has a kinder, gentler tone than the other poems in the book, but this claim is at least debatable, given the references to a personified Death, the relentless piling-on of mind-boggling treasures, and the repeated, plaintive, "Where can wisdom be found?" I think that the tone is one of rising drama, albeit with a clear and definitive conclusion (v28).

29:5 The wording in the Hebrew suggests that Job is missing the companionship of his servants, not merely their labors on his behalf (they were well paid in any case—cf. 31:13).

29:7 The gate complex of a city in ancient times served not only as the point of ingress and egress for the urban center but also the place of civic discussion and planning. The second line bespeaks his visibility and influence (cf. Pr 8:1-3).

29:8 Probably in every epoch and in every culture—if to varying extents—young men tend to be dismissive of authority figures, and yet the standing of Job was such that even these members of society preferred to make themselves scarce rather than embarrassed themselves in front of him. Meanwhile, the elderly—a class who in Job's day enjoyed general respect and deference—would stand upon seeing Job, a sign in that culture of honor. In other words, people from all walks of life held Job in great esteem.

29:16 Job was familiar with the truths of Jm 1:27 and Pr 18:17.

29:17 The second line shows that the first line is not to be taken overly literally. Nevertheless, those who deliberately set out to destroy others need to be held accountable (though not by mob violence—recall v7, from which we learn that Job had a

voice in the civic affairs on the city, and note Rom 13:1-7, which assigns the dispensing of justice to the civil government); and if someone is being violently attacked, surely bystanders with the capacity to intervene ought to do so, acting in a manner proportionate to the nature of the attack.

29:18 Reports of and myths concerning a bird more or less resembling the legendary phoenix are ancient and cross-cultural. Perhaps Job refers to an actual bird which was not yet extinct in his day, or perhaps he makes use of popular culture (note that the phoenix occurs here in a simile, not in a zoological text); either way, the point of contact is probably to the (real or supposed) long life of the bird. (As so often in Job, there is considerable uncertainty as to the most accurate translation of this verse; the reference might instead be to sand or to a certain type of tree.)

29:16 Job does not oppose the concept of certain humans exercising authority over others, but he also sees as part of the role of even a king the drying of tears.

30:3-10 The cumulative effect of a number of lexical difficulties in this passage makes it difficult to be sure whether the people described in these verses are outcasts due to various societal prejudices, to these individuals' own intransigence, or some combination of these and other factors. Either way, the argument is that since "even those with no community respect at all are all currently mocking or belittling him" (L. Wilson, 145), Job's humiliation has reached truly appalling depths.

30:8 Hebrew idioms pile up in this verse. (1) Often in Hebrew someone who is a "child of" someone or something is not literally that person or thing's biological offspring, but rather is someone who is part of or even typifies what that person or thing stands for. (2) The "fool" spoken of here (and often in related literature) is "not someone with diminished mental capacity, but who *willfully* chooses to reject the instruction and discipline of wisdom (G. Wilson 325). (3) The term "name" often refers to one's reputation or character, so that here "those without a name" is certainly not to be taken literally, but as referring either to their unknown in society or to those who (fairly or unfairly) have by society been branded with a reputation for being criminal, useless, or vile.

30:11 The first line means that God "freed" arrows from his bowstring, that he pierced Job with his long-range weapon. The second line seems to be an idiom; "the point is that the rabble relentlessly, ruthlessly, and unconscionably abused our hero" (Alden, 290).

30:24 Often in history one nation does invade another when for some reason the latter nation has been weakened, but Job speaks here of propriety, not actuality: One *ought not*, he says, pile trouble on trouble for another. But the meaning of the verse is unclear.

31:10 Probably both lines (seemingly by way of idiom or euphemism in the first line, but more directly in the second line) speak of other men having sex with his wife, the consequence Job invokes if (v9) he has *not* been faithful to his wife. "Job describes both the sin and the punishment from the man's point of view. This is not necessarily a sexist lack of concern for women and their point of view. It simply says that if Job steals his neighbor's wife, causing him pain and loss, it will be an appropriate punishment for Job also to suffer the theft of his own wife" (Ash, 313). The scenario is a counterfactual one: "The language is harsh, but one must remember that Job is absolutely certain of his own innocence and never anticipates that the consequence would be realized" (G. Wilson, 340). All this said, perhaps Job—who, like every human apart from Jesus Christ, is morally flawed—has been reckless in his words at this point.

31:38 Job is possibly borrowing from Gen 4:10, though it is not clear whether he is saying specifically that he has never *murdered* anyone; what v39 seems to deny is that Job ever acquired land (or its produce) apart from appropriate compensation.

31:40 In this context, it is possible that the final line is Job's voice (that this is uncertain is due to the fact that ancient Hebrew lacks quotation marks, so it is not always clear where direct speech ends and narration, or another voice, begins) saying in effect, "I've said my bit; take it or leave it." But in light of similar terminology found elsewhere (Ps 72:20, Jer 51:64), it seems that another voice is making clear that Job has finished speaking. Most likely, this is the voice of the narrator, who does not mean by this to say that Job has nothing more to say *ever*, but only that Job has finished making his case, and now awaits God's reply. It is true that the mere presence of a heading identifying the next speaker—together with vv35-37—would imply that Job's speech had come to an end, but by including this note the narrator brings listeners and reader to the key inflection point of the book—Job has challenged God concerning his unmerited calamities; how will God respond?—with almost frightening clarity. That Elihu, not God, is the next voice to speak, will prologue the suspense resolving around this unresolved chord.

32:2 The name "Ram" means "exalted"; it is only a linguistic happenstance that it sounds like the English word for a male sheep.

32:2-5 These verses, together with v12, are taken by L. Wilson to indicate that "Elihu has admitted that the friends' narrow view of retributive justice, inflexibly applied to Job's present condition, has failed" (156-157). But such reads too much into Elihu's words here (cf. the following Additional Note). In fact, in 34:7-12 Elihu will make clear that he *does* hold to a "narrow view of retributive justice" (ibid.; cf. L. Wilson, 167), and find this principle to explain Job's suffering.

Commentators vary widely in their assessments of Elihu. (For largely positive assessments, see Ash, 327-330; G. Wilson 359. For largely negative assessments, see Alden, 314; Andersen, 265ff; Ryken and Ryken, 726-727; L. Wilson,

156-157.) Without going into detail, I find him deficient in both substance and in style.

32:3 It is a bit difficult to see how the statement that the three friends condemned Job fits in to this specific context. Is Elihu angry at the friends for condemning Job at all, or for condemning Job without convincing grounds? (This difficulty seemingly led to scholarly efforts to ameliorate the difficulty in antiquity, viz. the rabbinic tradition of substituting a reference to God for the name “Job” (cf. Ginsburg, 361; and Tov, 59-61) and the Old Greek reading εὐσεβῆ(ν) for ασεβῆ(ν).) The latter is probably the correct answer, since Elihu is hardly on Job's side (v2), and will go on to criticize the friends' *failure* to wreck Job's arguments (see especially v12), not their *attempt* to do so. (If I am right on this point, perhaps I can be permitted to speculate that Elihu stands near the head of a tradition of love for debate and for hair-splitting that would later culminate in the pages of the Talmud.)

32:6 Elihu's words “You are old” are not an insult, for in that culture elders were highly valued, and assumed to command considerable knowledge and insight.

32:8 Hebrew does not have capital letters, so we could also translate “the spirit.” But while it is difficult to ascertain how much Elihu would have known about pneumatology, the parallel line does suggest that he does refer in this verse to the Holy Spirit, or at least to a concept that is not too far from the truth on this point.

32:19 Elihu seems to be comparing his mounting agitation to the expansion of gasses in a container of wine soon to explode.

33:6 The first line could also be translated (if the Hebrew is understood literally rather than idiomatically), “Behold, I am like your mouth to the Divine One,” in which case Elihu is seemingly offering his services as a mediator. The parallel line (which speaks of Elihu's being mortal) and Elihu's general stance toward Job (adversarial) suggest the idiomatic interpretation given in the translation better captures Elihu's intent.

33:8-11 While on the basis of this sketch of Job's argument it might be argued that Elihu criticizes only Job's response to his *suffering*, not Job's *prior* life, Elihu's views on Job will later prove to be more comprehensively condemnatory (e.g., 34:6-7).

33:23-24 Perhaps this is an early form of a preoccupation with angels that finds a continuation in those called out by Paul in Col 2:18.

33:32 In light of Elihu's self-presentation as a whole, it seems to me that this is not a sincere statement that Elihu judges Job charitably and is willing to listen to Job's side of the story. I think that Elihu is either implying that Job has *nothing* plausible to say after such an awe-displaying display of logic and rhetoric, or attempting to wrest a confession of guilt out of him.

36:16 It is notable that the first verb is in the Hebrew perfect tense. Possibly this is because Elihu views this outcome as so certain as already to be established, but if so, this stance probably does not reflect a confidence in Job's character as much as confidence in himself—since he, Elihu, is here, certainly God's mission of drawing Job back to himself will succeed!

37:17 “When the sirocco or *south wind* blows off the desert, village life comes to a standstill. The land becomes still as every creature seeks shelter under some shade” (Hartley, 482).

37:22 This verse is obscure, but seems to speak of a manifestation of God's presence (whether Elihu imagines this manifestation as historical, present, or future is one of the uncertainties that attaches to the verse). God is in a number of passages referred to as in or coming from the north.

38:1 Cf. on 26:9.

38:9 Cf. Gen 1:2.

39:17 The tone is ironic.

40:1-2 Whereas Elihu makes four speeches, Yahweh makes three, and the middle speech is in reality an invitation for *Job* to speak. True, this invitation is, as noted above, made with the understanding that to reprove God would be foolish (it would not wrongheaded and unhelpful to pretend otherwise); yet it grants Job an agency that gives him a level of dignity that Job's three friends (not to mention Elihu) struggled to recognize in him. So even in reproof, God is gracious.

40:5 The escalation of “once, twice” might highlight Job's “repeated efforts” (cf. Hartley, 442).

40:15 In the Summary it was mentioned that “Yahweh turns, as he did before (38:4-39:30), to nature.” In this connection, it is well to observe that there is “a long-standing tradition in Western Christian thought that belittles the knowledge of God gained by thinking about the world... The book of Job does not take this discouraging attitude. Just as Jesus invited us to ‘consider the lilies of the field’ [see Mat 6:28-30], so the Lord is like a friend who asks you to join him in a walk around his garden. God enjoys his world, and he wants us to enjoy it with him. But it is only when God himself conducts the tour that the excursion is profitable” (Andersen, 292).

40:15-24 What is the behemoth? The Hebrew (בהמות) is a plural of majesty, meaning something like, “mighty beast,” “the animal of all animals.” The description partly fits a hippopotamus, a powerful and dangerous semiaquatic animal widely feared both in ancient and modern times, though some details are questionable. Perhaps some animal since hunted to extinction (the hunting of dangerous animals, partly no doubt for protection but partly also to showcase the prowess of kings) was widespread in the ancient and medieval worlds, to the detriment of wildlife everywhere.

41:1-34 What is the leviathan? The Hebrew term (לִיָּאָן) seems to bespeak some vaguely serpentine, distinctly ominous creature. It is often thought to be a crocodile. If so, the descriptive is quite poetic, though such is to be expected in the book

of Job. On the other hand, perhaps it is an extinct creature (cf. the previous note).

40:15–41:34 From ancient times onward, men have often hunted certain types of animals—not least those that pose real or perceived danger to people or to prosperity—to extinction (or nearly so), and/or contributed to extinction through a narrowing of the animals' habitat. Perhaps the behemoth and the leviathan suffered that fate in the centuries after Job.

41:1 In the standard Hebrew-language versification, this is 40:25, and chapter 40 continues through v32 (=41:8 in English). The two systems do not synchronize until 42:1.

42:2 The Hebrew verb behind “know” (יָדַע) does not imply a mere intellectual acceptance, but instead underscores something felt powerfully by his inner person.

42:3 Job paraphrases God's question from 38:2.

42:4 Job paraphrases God's challenge from 38:3, 40:7.

42:6 I take “dust and ashes” here as an idiom not for despondent grief, but for human mortality (cf. Gen 18:27). In other words, Job is newly aware of his smallness next to God's vastness.

42:7 Eliphaz, whether due to age or some other reasons, seems to have held seniority among the three friends, and so is addressed as their representative.

42:11 “It is worth dwelling on the fact that, even when everything is set right, Job still feels the hurt of his losses, and needs human comfort for them” (Andersen, 317). On a related note, Ash (21-22) observes that – at least in view of the heart-wrenching content of the book—Job is a lengthy book; but just as therapy cannot be rushed, so it is worth taking a considerable period to ponder the poetry of Job.

42:12-13 God gives Job double the wealth he formerly had, but the same number of children. It has been suggested that this is because in the resurrection Job's first set of children would join with the second set, so that in the long term his family really is doubled in size.

42:15 Giving daughters as well as sons an inheritance was unusual in that culture. Whether this was done owing to Job's tremendous wealth, his esteem for his daughters, or some other reason is not mentioned.

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